

TOP SECRET - VERDANT COVENANT - EYES ONLY

THE VERDANT COVENANT · INTERNAL USE ONLY · FORM VC-1 · REV. 1987

NEON RELIC

CORE OPERATIONS MANUAL

The Verdant Covenant - Field Agent Edition



DOCUMENT CONTROL

CLASSIFICATION: TOP SECRET

COPY NO.: _____ Prepared by: Agent Bruce & Agent Stu

DATE ISSUED: _____

RECIPIENT SIG: _____

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*"What is found must be known. What is known must be contained.
What is contained must be guarded."*

– The Oath of the Verdant Covenant



CLASSIFIED

PART I – INTRODUCTION

Classification: Unrestricted (Covenant Personnel Only)

Distribution: All Divisions

CHAPTER 1. INTRODUCTION

Project Neon Relic is a tabletop roleplaying game of occult investigation, psychological horror, and artifact recovery set in an alternate 1980s. Players are agents of a secret society called **The Verdant Covenant**, tasked with discovering, retrieving, and containing supernatural artifacts before they destroy the world – or the people who find them.

The game uses the **Year Zero Engine (YZE)** dice-pool variant – the same framework behind *Vaesen*, *Mutant: Year Zero*, *Forbidden Lands*, and the *Alien RPG*. If you have played any of those, the core dice mechanics will feel familiar. What makes Neon Relic different is its **Corruption** system: a steadily rising psychological damage track with no safe reset, turning every pushed roll and every artifact activation into a calculated gamble against your own sanity.

1.1. What This Game Is

- **Episodic investigation.** Each session follows a structured **Case File** – a "artifact-of-the-week" mystery driven by artifact recovery, faction interference, and occult threats.
- **Base management between missions.** The team maintains a **Headquarters** – a Covenant facility they upgrade, staff, and defend over the course of a campaign.
- **Psychological attrition.** The real threat is not the monsters. It is the toll the work takes on the agents. Corruption accumulates from pushing rolls, using supernatural abilities, and confronting the unnatural. It does not go away easily. Characters who cross the threshold are permanently retired.
- **Analog procedural thriller.** No internet. No GPS. No cell phones. Investigations require physical legwork, face-to-face conversations, and fragile 1980s technology that degrades under use.

1.2. What This Game Is Not

- Not a step-dice system. Neon Relic uses d6 dice pools, not the step-dice variant from *Twilight: 2000* or *Blade Runner RPG*.
- Not high fantasy or superhero action. Powers are rare, dangerous, and always come at a cost.
- Not a dungeon crawl. There are no experience points for killing monsters. Advancement comes from completing missions, surviving trauma, and confronting your Dark Secret.

1.3. The 1980s Setting

The world of Project Neon Relic is an amalgamation of neon-noir aesthetics and deep historical conspiracies. It is an alternative reality where the geopolitical tension of the Cold War is not merely fought with the threat of nuclear deterrence, but through the covert weaponization of ancient, mythological artifacts.

The Analog Aesthetic

The technological environment is characterized by analog limitations, forcing a distinct style of investigative gameplay. The absence of smartphones, GPS, and ubiquitous high-speed internet forces players into physical legwork and face-to-face interactions:

- **Communication** relies on vulnerable payphones, easily intercepted HAM radios, and analog cassette answering machines.
- **Information** is not Googled; it is painstakingly recovered from microfiche spools, physical library archives, and fragile floppy disks.
- **Surveillance** uses bulky camcorders, grainy polaroid cameras, and temperamental infrared equipment.

The juxtaposition of high-tech, neon-lit urban sprawl against the ancient, rotting, cosmic horror of the artifacts creates a stark, atmospheric dichotomy. Audio aesthetics play a major role – underground clubs pulse with aggressive synthwave beats, while secretive government laboratories hum with the low, oppressive frequencies of massive server mainframes.

The tactile, error-prone nature of 1980s technology maps flawlessly to the engine's attrition mechanics. Batteries die at the worst moment. Magnetic tapes corrupt. CRT screens flicker and distort in the presence of the anomalous.

1.4. The Verdant Covenant

For as long as civilizations have risen and fallen, the world has produced objects of unusual power and importance – relics of faith, symbols of kingdoms, forbidden texts, cursed idols, lost maps, sacred bones, and artifacts whose origins are long forgotten.

Some inspire devotion.

Some bring prosperity.

Some bring ruin.

Throughout history, wars have been fought over such objects. Empires have risen seeking them, and entire cultures have been erased because of them. To prevent the

past from destroying the present, a quiet order was formed centuries ago.

The Verdant Covenant.

The Covenant is a secret society devoted to the **discovery, recovery, and protection of artifacts of magical, religious, occult, or cultural significance**. Its members believe that the greatest dangers in history have not been armies or kings – but **objects that hold power beyond understanding**.

The Covenant does not seek to own these relics for wealth or prestige. Its singular purpose is **stewardship**.

- To **study** them.
- To **preserve** them.
- To **ensure they never fall into the wrong hands**.

The Square of Harmony (The Rule of 441)

The organization strictly maintains exactly **441 active members worldwide at all times** – not a single operative more or less. This figure is derived from the "**Square of Harmony**," a principle rooted in the sacred geometry of Reversible Multiplicative Symmetry. Covenant occultists recognize that $441 = 21^2$, symbolizing the gross material plane; while its exact numerical reversal, 144 , represents the enlightened, inverse stewardship of the anomalous.

The Covenant believes this numerical balance acts as a metaphysical anchor, keeping the organization from becoming corrupted by the volatile artifacts it hoards. Because of this rigid cap, the initiation of a new member invariably means a previous member has died or fallen to permanent Catatonia – ensuring the cycle of stewardship continues unbroken.

Organizational Structure

Within the Covenant there are **three Divisions**, each responsible for a different stage of the artifact lifecycle:

Division	Motto Segment	Purpose
The Wayfinder Division	<i>"What is found must be known."</i>	Scholars and researchers who uncover the existence and locations of lost artifacts.
The Recovery Division	<i>"What is known must be contained."</i>	Field agents who retrieve relics from ruins, vaults, corporations, and those who would misuse them.

Division	Motto Segment	Purpose
The Keep	<i>"What is contained must be guarded."</i>	Wardens and archivists who guard the Covenant's vaults and ensure dangerous artifacts remain contained.



Note on Stack: The Keep's Department of Logistics – informally known as "Stack" – operates with enough autonomy and unique expertise to function as its own playable division for game purposes. See [Division 4: Stack](#) for details.

1.5. How to Use This Book

This rulebook is organized into six parts:

- **Part I: Introduction** – You are here. The game's premise, setting, and the Verdant Covenant.
- **Part II: Character Creation** – Build your agent step by step.
- **Part III: Core Mechanics** – The dice, attributes, combat, social conflict, health, and the Corruption system.
- **Part IV: The World of Neon Relic** – Divisions, equipment, artifacts, headquarters, and advancement.
- **Part V: The Director** – GM-facing tools: Case Files, factions, bestiary, travel, and guidance.
- **Part VI: Glossary** – Quick reference for all game terms.

If you are a player, start with Character Creation and Core Mechanics. If you are the GM (the **Director**), read everything – but especially the Director section and the Corruption chapter.



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PART II – CHARACTER CREATION

Classification: Unrestricted (Covenant Personnel Only)

Distribution: Incoming Agent Onboarding

CHAPTER 2. CREATING YOUR AGENT

Every player in Neon Relic portrays a sworn agent of **The Verdant Covenant** – a specialist with a particular expertise, a history that brought them to this work, and a threshold for the horrors they are about to witness. Character creation follows these eleven steps in order.

2.1. Step 1: Choose Your Division

Your **Division** is your character class. It defines your role within the Covenant, your key attributes, your starting skills, and your access to supernatural Division Talents. There are four playable Divisions:

Division	Role	CL	Key Attributes
Wayfinder	Research and intelligence. You find what others don't know exists.	3	Wits, Empathy
Recovery	Field retrieval. You go in and bring the artifact out.	2	Strength, Agility
The Keep	Vault security and custody. You guard what has been won.	3	Empathy, Wits
Stack	Logistics and technical support. You make sure everyone else can do their job.	4	Wits, Agility

Clearance Level (CL) represents your seniority and authorization within the Covenant. A higher CL grants access to better gear requisitions and more sensitive intelligence. Your final CL equals your Division's base CL plus your Age Group modifier (minimum 1).

Read the full Division descriptions in [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#) before making your choice.

2.2. Step 2: Choose Your Department or Background

Within your Division, you have a specific background:

- **Wayfinder:** Choose a Department – **Research** or **Counterintelligence**. Within that, choose a role (Desk Analyst or Field Analyst).
- **Recovery:** Choose an Operational Background – **Ex-Agency Operative**, **Heavy-Hitter**, or **Acquisition Specialist**.
- **The Keep:** Choose a Department – **Catalogers**, **Wardens**, or **Internal Counterintelligence**.
- **Stack:** Choose a specialty – **Quartermaster**, **Retro-Engineer**, or **Paratech Inventor**.

Your background is primarily a narrative statement – it tells you and the GM where you came from. It does not grant mechanical bonuses at creation, but it should inform which skills you prioritize.

2.3. Step 3: Choose Your Age Group and Distribute Attribute Points

Choose an **Age Group** that reflects your agent's seniority and experience. This determines your age range, attribute point pool, skill point pool (used in Step 4), and **Clearance Level modifier** – the longer you've served the Covenant, the higher your authorization.

Age Group	Age Range	Attribute Points	Skill Points	CL Modifier
Young	22-28	14	10	-1
Experienced	29-38	13	12	+0
Senior	39-52	12	14	+1

Younger characters are physically sharper (more attribute points); older characters are more skilled and better connected (more skill points and higher clearance). The trade-off is real and interesting – there is no "best" choice.

Distribute your **Attribute Points** across your four core attributes. Each attribute has a minimum score of **2** and a maximum score of **5**.

Attribute	Range	Description
Strength	2-5	Physical power, endurance, and resistance to bodily harm.
Agility	2-5	Reflexes, coordination, fine motor control, and speed.

Attribute	Range	Description
Wits	2-5	Perception, memory, deductive reasoning, and technical aptitude.
Empathy	2-5	Charisma, social intuition, and resistance to psychological horror.

Division Favorite Attribute: *Each Division has one Favorite Attribute – the stat at the core of your agent’s identity. Plan to assign 4 or 5 points there. Wayfinder: Wits | Recovery: Agility | The Keep: Empathy | Stack: Wits. Investing there is strongly recommended but not mechanically enforced.*

Attributes as Health: *Your attributes also serve as your health pools. Strength absorbs physical damage; Agility absorbs exhaustion; Wits absorbs mental horror; Empathy absorbs emotional trauma. A score of 0 in any attribute means your character is Broken.*

2.4. Step 4: Distribute Skill Points

Distribute your **Skill Points** (determined by your Age Group in Step 3) across the twelve core skills. No single skill may exceed **3** at character creation.

Skill	Attr	Starting Max	Recommended Division Priority
Force	STR	3	Recovery
Brawl	STR	3	Recovery
Endure	STR	3	Keep
Sneak	AGI	3	Recovery
Sleight of Hand	AGI	3	Stack

Skill	Attr	Starting Max	Recommended Division Priority
Firearms	AGI	3	Recovery
Investigate	WIT	3	Wayfinder, Stack
Tech	WIT	3	Wayfinder, Stack
Lore	WIT	3	Wayfinder, Keep
Manipulate	EMP	3	Wayfinder
Command	EMP	3	Keep
Psychoanalyze	EMP	3	Wayfinder, Keep

Unranked skills: A skill at rating 0 means you have no formal training. You may still attempt rolls using only your Attribute Dice – there are no "untrained" restrictions.

Division Key Skill – Starting Cap Exception: Each Division has one designated Key Skill that may start at rating 4 instead of the normal maximum of 3. This represents professional specialization before Covenant service. You may spend up to 4 of your starting points on that skill.

Division	Key Skill (Starting Cap: 4)
Wayfinder	Lore
Recovery	Firearms
The Keep	Command
Stack	Tech

2.5. Step 5: Choose Your Starting Talents

At creation, every agent selects **two** talents:

- **One Division Talent** chosen from your Division's talent list (see the Divisions chapter). You may only choose from your own Division's list at creation.
- **One General Talent** chosen from the General Talents list (see the Advancement chapter). These are available to every agent regardless of Division.

Most Division Talents cost **+1 Corruption** to activate. One talent per list is a **Healing** talent, usable freely but once per session. General Talents are passive or per-session effects with no Corruption cost unless noted.

Talent Advancement: *Additional talents can be purchased during play using experience points. See the Advancement chapter.*

2.6. Step 6: Record Your Starting Statistics

Once attributes are set, note the following:

Statistic	Starting Value
Clearance Level (CL)	Division base CL + Age Group modifier (minimum 1)
Corruption	0 – you begin psychologically intact
Max Corruption Threshold	10 + Empathy score
Broken Thresholds	Any attribute reaching 0

Maximum Corruption Threshold is the number at which your character's mind permanently fractures, resulting in catatonia and character retirement. This is the most important number on your sheet – protect it.

2.7. Step 7: Claim Your Division Item

Every agent receives their Division's **signature item** at induction. This item requires no CL check and no requisition roll – record it automatically.

Division	Item	Granted Abilities
Wayfinder	Verdant Codex	Secures memory, decodes language and symbols, maps artifact locations, preserves documents.
Recovery	Verdant Satchel	Suppresses artifact aura, seals cursed items, warns of instability, produces basic tools on demand.
Keep	Warden's Bracer	Suppresses artifact magic nearby, warns of containment failure, safe handling of cursed objects, absorbs 1 Corruption/session, +1 Armor Rating.
Stack	<i>(none)</i>	Stack agents receive no Division Item, but gain +1 requisition die whenever acquiring <i>crafting materials</i> during the Equipping Phase.

2.8. Step 8: Select Starting Gear

Each agent begins with a Division-appropriate kit. Gear beyond this standard kit requires a **Clearance Level** roll during the mission's Equipping Phase.

Wayfinder Starting Kit

- Verdant Codex (*Division Item – automatic*)
- Briefcase with research materials (notepad, pens, carbon paper)
- 35mm camera with two rolls of film
- Forged credentials (press pass, academic ID, or government contractor badge – player's choice)
- Civilian clothing (appropriate for the investigation environment)
- 1× small concealable weapon (pocket knife, derringer) (*optional, CL 3 item – already authorized*)

Recovery Starting Kit

- Verdant Satchel (*Division Item – automatic*)
- Sidearm (.38 Special revolver or 9mm semi-automatic, 12 rounds)
- Flashlight (D-cell)

- Basic field kit: 10m rope, zip ties × 6, chalk × 2, crowbar
- Field jacket with concealed holster
- One additional item from the Equipment tables (*CL 2 or lower*)

The Keep Starting Kit

- Warden's Bracer (*Division Item – automatic*)
- Containment kit: 1kg salt, copper wire (10m), chalk × 4, sealed glass canisters × 4
- Lore reference binder (photocopied Covenant texts on known artifact types)
- Formal attire or tactical jacket (*player's choice based on role*)
- 1× sidearm (*optional, CL 3 permitted – Wardens only*)

Stack Starting Kit

- Personal toolkit: flathead and Phillips screwdrivers × 3, soldering iron, wire cutters, electrical tape, multimeter
- Signal jammer (prototype; 1 use before requiring repair; Gear Die d6)
- Walkie-talkies × 2 (range: ~2km, 9V battery)
- Duct tape (1 roll), WD-40
- Practical coveralls or utility vest

2.9. Step 9: Choose Your Anchor

Every agent carries an **Anchor** – a tangible, physical object tied to a core humanizing memory from before the Covenant. It connects you to the ordinary world you are fighting to protect, and it is your most reliable tool for healing Corruption.

Choose one of the following options:

- **Roll d66** on the Memento Table in the Healing chapter and accept the result as written.
- **Invent your own:** name a specific object and the memory attached to it. Run it by your GM.

Record your Anchor's name and the memory it represents on your character sheet.

Mechanic: *Once per session, dedicate a scene to your Anchor –*

a quiet moment where you handle the object and let the memory surface. Heal 1d4 Corruption. Full rules in the Healing chapter.

2.10. Step 10: Choose Your Dark Secret

Every Covenant agent harbors a **Dark Secret** – something from their past that the Covenant knows, or should know, about them. It must be specific enough that the GM can use it as a story hook when the investigation points in the right direction.

Choose one from your Division's example list in the Advancement chapter, or write your own. The XP question at session end – "**Did your Dark Secret complicate the mission?**" – is the mechanical payoff. Full rules and Division-specific examples are in [docs/chapters/13-advancement.adoc](#).

2.11. Step 11: Name and Biography

Choose a name appropriate for the 1980s United States setting. Write 2–3 sentences of biography: who were you before the Covenant? What incident drew their attention? What can you not bring yourself to talk about?

1980s Name Inspiration: *The era favors names like Karen, Debbie, Steve, Randall, Tracy, Rick, Tamara, Dale, Connie, Barry. Government agencies use surnames in the field.*

2.12. Character Sheet Summary

After completing all steps, your sheet should record:

Field	Notes
Name / Division / Department	Identity and role
Clearance Level	Division base CL + Age Group modifier (minimum 1)
Age Group / Age	Chosen in Step 3 (Young / Experienced / Senior)

Field	Notes
Attributes (STR / AGI / WIT / EMP)	Attribute Points distributed per Age Group, 2–5 each
Skills (12)	Skill Points distributed per Age Group, 0–3 each
Division Talent	One chosen from Division list
General Talent	One chosen from General Talents list (Step 5)
Division Item	Automatic (or Stack bonus)
Starting Gear	Division kit ± optional items
Corruption	Starts at 0
Max Corruption Threshold	10 + Empathy
Dark Secret	Chosen from Division list or custom (see Advancement chapter)
Anchor	Object name + memory (see Healing chapter)

2.13. Worked Example: Creating Petra Vasquez

The following example demonstrates a complete character build for a Recovery agent.

Step 1–2: Division and Background

Petra Vasquez is a **Recovery** agent with the **Ex-Agency Operative** background. She is a former DEA field agent who recovered an artifact during what she thought was a routine drug raid – and has been in the Covenant’s employ ever since.

Step 3: Age Group and Attributes

Petra’s six years in DEA field operations put her at age 34 – she selects **Experienced** (29–38), giving her **13 Attribute Points** and **12 Skill Points**.

Attribute	Score	Reasoning
Strength	4	Ex-agency physical conditioning

Attribute	Score	Reasoning
Agility	4	Trained for fast entries; Recovery Key Attribute
Wits	3	Sharp but not an analyst
Empathy	2	Gets by on presence, not charm; lower threshold is a real risk

(13 points spent: $4 + 4 + 3 + 2 = 13$)

Max Corruption Threshold: $10 + 2 = 12$. Petra has a tighter margin than she'd like – but those attribute points went where they needed to go.

Step 4: Skills (12 points)

Skill	Rating	Reasoning
Sneak	3	Core recovery skill; DEA background
Firearms	3	Agency-trained; Recovery Key Skill
Force	2	Physical entries, breaking down doors
Brawl	2	Hand-to-hand when it comes to that
Investigate	1	Enough to read a crime scene
Endure	1	Agency conditioning

(12 points spent: $3 + 3 + 2 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 12$. Remaining 6 skills at 0.)

Step 5: Starting Talents

- **Division Talent:** Petra chooses **Shadow Walker** (+1 Corruption): Become entirely imperceptible to mundane guards or cameras for a scene, provided she does not

attack. This fits her infiltration background perfectly.

- **General Talent:** Petra takes **Flee the Scene** – gain +2 bonus dice to Agility when rolling explicitly to escape a conflict. A field operative who knows when to run lives longer than one who doesn't.

Step 6: Starting Statistics

Statistic	Value
Clearance Level	2
Corruption	0
Max Corruption Threshold	12

Steps 7-8: Division Item and Gear

Petra records the **Verdant Satchel** automatically. From the Recovery Kit she takes: .38 Special revolver (12 rounds), D-cell flashlight, field kit (rope, zip ties, chalk, crowbar), and field jacket. For her additional CL 2 item she selects a police scanner.

Step 9: Anchor

Anchor: A cassette tape – *Los Lobos, By the Light of the Moon, 1987*. Her brother Marco made it for her birthday. She keeps it in the inside pocket of her field jacket and hasn't listened to it since the Tucson raid.

Step 10: Dark Secret

Dark Secret: Petra's former DEA supervisor is now working for **The Vantablack Compact**. She has not reported this.

Step 11: Biography

"Petra Vasquez, former DEA Special Agent, six years in field operations before the Tucson Incident. The Covenant found her two days after the raid. She's never asked them how they knew."



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PART III – CORE MECHANICS

Classification: Unrestricted (Covenant Personnel Only)
Distribution: All Field Agents

CHAPTER 3. CORE RESOLUTION MECHANICS

The foundation of Project Neon Relic relies on the classic **dice-pool variant** of the Year Zero Engine, originally pioneered in *Mutant: Year Zero* and expanded in *Forbidden Lands* and *Alien*. While the step-dice variant utilized in *Blade Runner* and *Twilight: 2000* offers nuance, the dice-pool system is fundamentally better suited for visually representing escalating tension and resource attrition – key themes in analog horror.

3.1. The Anatomy of the Dice Pool

The core philosophy of the Year Zero Engine is that **rolling dice should only occur when the narrative outcome is uncertain and the consequences of failure are dramatic**. When a player character (PC) attempts a risky action, they construct a dice pool consisting of three distinct elements, which should be color-coded for immediate visual clarity at the gaming table:

Dice Type	Color	Source	Typical Range
Attribute Dice	White	Character's innate biological capability	1–5
Skill Dice	Green	Character's trained proficiency	0–5
Gear Dice	Black	Mechanical bonus from tools/weapons	0–3

To achieve a basic success, the player must roll at least one **6** across the entire dice pool. Multiple sixes are surplus successes that can be spent on **stunts** – extra narrative or mechanical benefits such as:

- Completing an action significantly faster
- Uncovering secondary hidden clues during an investigation
- Assisting an ally with their next roll
- Inflicting critical, debilitating injuries during combat

The elegance of this system lies in its speed; it produces immediate, decisive results by entirely removing post-roll arithmetic or target-number calculations.

3.2. The Push Mechanic and Attrition

The primary driver of suspense and narrative tension is the **Push** mechanic. If an initial roll yields no sixes (a failure), or if the player desperately needs additional successes for stunts, they may choose to **push** the roll – picking up and

re-rolling all dice that do not currently display a 6.

However, pushing represents the character exerting maximum physical, mental, or material effort, and it comes with severe risks:

- You immediately gain **+1 Corruption**.

Design note: *Corruption is the only push cost. There is no separate "Stress" track, no optional complication table. The Corruption system handles all forms of mental and supernatural pressure through a single unified resource – see [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#) for the full rules.*

The analog nature of 1980s technology perfectly complements this mechanical attrition. Pushing a gear-assisted roll might degrade the item – short-circuiting alkaline batteries or jamming mechanisms – effectively reducing its inherent bonus until it can be repaired during downtime.

3.3. Opposed Rolls

When two characters are directly working against each other – a guard watching for intruders while an agent tries to slip past, a witness resisting an interrogation, two agents in a grapple – a **standard roll is not sufficient**. Both sides have active stakes in the outcome. Use an **Opposed Roll**.

Procedure

1. Both characters construct their dice pools normally (Attribute + Skill + Gear).
2. Both roll simultaneously.
3. Count the number of **6s** each side rolled – these are their **successes**.
4. The side with more successes wins.

Tie-Breaking

Design Decision: *In Neon Relic, ties are resolved in favor of the active party – the character initiating the action.*

+ **Rationale:** *Neon Relic is an action-and-investigation game. Agents are protagonists taking risks. A tie should reward*

decisive action rather than passive defense. The threat of failure is already baked into the Corruption cost of pushing – we don't need the additional drag of defender-wins ties slowing down forward momentum. This differs from Vaesen (defender wins) and aligns more closely with the feel of Alien RPG.

If both sides roll zero successes, the outcome is **no change** – the situation remains unresolved, and the GM should advance the fiction in a direction that applies pressure (the confrontation escalates, time runs out, a third party notices, etc.). The acting character does **not** gain Corruption from a zero-zero tie.

Common Opposed Pairings

The following pairings arise most frequently in play. Either side may push their roll as normal, gaining +1 Corruption.

Active Roll	Opposing Roll	Situation
Sneak (AGI)	Investigate (WIT)	Agent moves silently past a watchful guard or suspicious bystander
Manipulate (EMP)	Psychoanalyze (EMP)	Convincing a witness – the target is actively trying to spot the lie
Command (EMP)	Manipulate (EMP)	Asserting authority vs. someone talking their way out from under it
Force (STR)	Endure (STR)	Trying to physically overpower or restrain another character
Brawl (STR)	Brawl (STR)	Contested grapple, disarm, or shove
Sleight of Hand (AGI)	Investigate (WIT)	Planting or pocketing an item without being noticed
Sneak (AGI)	Investigate (WIT)	Tailing a target without being made
Tech (WIT)	Tech (WIT)	Counter-hacking: both parties on the same BBS or mainframe simultaneously

Mismatched skills are allowed. If a situation calls for it,

the GM may permit any logical pairing. The table above is guidance, not a hard constraint.

Pushed Opposed Rolls

Either or both sides may push their roll (gaining +1 Corruption each). Pushes are declared **before** comparing results. If both sides push and the result is still a tie, the active party wins as normal.

3.4. Helping

Agents operating as a team can be more effective than any individual. When one agent attempts a roll and an ally is present and capable, that ally may **help**.

Who May Help

An ally may help if **both** of the following are true:

- They are present in the scene (Engaged or Close range – same room, same vehicle, actively coordinating).
- They have a **rating of at least 1** in the relevant skill, **or** they can provide a plausible narrative justification for how their own skill set contributes (GM approval).

The Helping Bonus

- Each helper adds **+1 die** to the active character's dice pool.
- A maximum of **2 helpers** may assist on any single roll.
- The helping dice are **Skill Dice** (green) – they can produce successes but are not pushed separately.

Maximum pool size: *With 2 helpers, a character's pool can be up to +2 dice above their normal maximum. This represents peak team coordination – beyond this, too many cooks.*

Helping and Corruption

- If the active character **pushes** the roll, helpers are **not** penalized – they lent their dice to the initial roll, not the push.

- Helpers do **not** gain Corruption when the active character pushes.

Helping in Combat

Helping during combat requires a **slow action** from the helper. A helper who assists a slow action during a combat round cannot take any other slow action that round.

3.5. Group Rolls

Some situations call for the **entire team to attempt the same action simultaneously** – crossing a dark chasm, navigating a treacherous building undetected before the guards change, deciphering a large number of documents before the contact leaves.

Procedure

1. Each character rolls their individual dice pool for the relevant skill.
2. Count how many characters **succeed** (rolled at least one 6).
3. Compare against the **Group Success Threshold** set by the GM:

Threshold	When to Use
All succeed	The action requires total team performance – a single failure has consequences (e.g., stealth approach; one noise ruins it for everyone)
Majority succeed	Most of the team needs to make it (e.g., climbing a fence before a gate locks)
At least one succeeds	The team needs one person to pull it off; others can assist if needed

Group Roll Failure

If the group fails to meet the threshold:

- The GM applies consequences to **all who failed**, not as individual failures but as a shared narrative setback.
- Individual characters who succeeded are not penalized – they did their part.
- Characters who failed **may push** as normal (gaining +1 Corruption each), independently.

Group rolls and Corruption: *Each character manages their own Corruption on a group roll independently. A group roll gone wrong – four agents all pushing, all gaining +1 Corruption – creates the kind of compounding pressure that makes the Corruption system matter.*

3.6. Worked Examples

Opposed Roll: The Tail Job

Situation: Agent Petra Vasquez (Recovery) is tailing a suspected Compact operative through a crowded airport. The operative gets a feeling he's being watched and starts scanning the crowd.

- **Petra rolls:** Sneak (AGI 4 + Sneak 3) = 7 dice. Rolls: 6, 5, 3, 3, 2, 1, 1 → **1 success.**
- **Operative rolls:** Investigate (WIT 3 + Investigate 2) = 5 dice. Rolls: 4, 4, 3, 2, 1 → **0 successes.**
- **Result:** Petra wins – she stays undetected and follows him to his contact.

If Petra had rolled 0 successes and the operative also rolled 0, the tail continues but something shifts – maybe Petra loses him in the crowd, or the operative ducks into a bathroom and the GM advances the clock.

Opposed Roll with Push: The Interrogation

Situation: Wayfinder Agent Reyes is interrogating a frightened historian who knows where the artifact is. The historian desperately doesn't want to cooperate.

- **Reyes rolls:** Manipulate (EMP 4 + Manipulate 2) = 6 dice. Rolls: 5, 4, 4, 3, 2, 1 → **0 successes.**
- Reyes decides to **push** (gains +1 Corruption, now at 1). Re-rolls all 5 non-6 dice: 6, 6, 3, 2, 1 → **2 successes.**
- **Historian rolls:** Psychoanalyze (EMP 3 + Psychoanalyze 1) = 4 dice. Rolls: 6, 4, 3, 2 → **1 success.**
- **Result:** Reyes wins (2 vs 1). The historian cracks. The extra success can be spent on a stunt – perhaps he volunteers more than just the location.

Helping: Cracking a Locked File Cabinet

Situation: Stack agent Kowalski is picking a government-grade lock. Sleight of Hand 2 (AGI 3 + skill 2 = 5 dice). Keep agent Osei has Sleight of Hand 1 and offers to hold the flashlight steady and narrate the tumblers. GM approves.

- Osei adds +1 die. Kowalski rolls **6 dice** total instead of 5.
- Result: 6, 6, 5, 3, 2, 1 → 2 successes. The lock opens, and the extra success means it opens fast – no time lost.

Group Roll: The Silent Entry

Situation: Four agents must all enter a research facility quietly before a guard completes his patrol. GM sets threshold: **all succeed** (failure means the guard hears movement).

- Petra (Sneak 3, AGI 4): 7 dice → 6, 4, 3, 2, 1, 1, 1 → **1 success** →
- Reyes (Sneak 1, AGI 2): 3 dice → 5, 4, 2 → **0 successes** →
- Osei (Sneak 0, EMP 3): 3 attribute dice → 6, 3, 1 → **1 success** →
- Kowalski (Sneak 2, AGI 4): 6 dice → 6, 6, 3, 2, 1, 1 → **2 successes** →

Reyes failed. Threshold not met. The GM rules the guard hears something from Reyes' direction and starts to turn. **Reyes pushes** (gains +1 Corruption): re-rolls 3 dice → 6, 4, 2 → **1 success**. The group just barely makes it – but Reyes is now at 1 Corruption and the tension meter has ticked up.

CHAPTER 4. ATTRIBUTES AND SKILLS

Characters are defined by **four core attributes**, representing their fundamental physical and mental foundations. In Project Neon Relic, these traditional YZE attributes are updated to fit the modern, investigative tone of an occult thriller:

Attribute	Description
Strength	Physical power, raw endurance, and fortitude against physical trauma.
Agility	Gross and fine motor skills, physical reflexes, balance, and precision.
Wits	Sensory perception, formal education, memory recall, and deductive reasoning.
Empathy	Raw charisma, social intuition, ability to read human behavior, and emotional resilience against psychological horror.

4.1. The Twelve Core Skills

The twelve core skills are mapped to these four attributes, tailored to support urban exploration, analog hacking, and occult research:

Attribute	Skill	Application in the 1980s Occult Setting
Strength	Force	Breaking down sealed bunker doors, forcing open containment chambers.
	Brawl	Hand-to-hand combat with cultists, wrestling cursed objects from hostile hands.
	Endure	Resisting the physical toll of harsh environments, toxic substances, or sustained injury.
Agility	Sneak	Infiltrating corporate research facilities, bypassing analog security systems.
	Sleight of Hand	Picking locks, pocketing small artifacts, disarming mechanical traps.
	Firearms	Utilizing period-accurate weaponry (.38 revolvers, pump-action shotguns).

Attribute	Skill	Application in the 1980s Occult Setting
Wits	Investigate	Searching crime scenes for anomalous evidence, analyzing forensic data.
	Tech	Operating 1980s mainframes, hacking BBS networks, repairing analog equipment.
	Lore	Decoding ancient occult texts, identifying mythological creatures and artifact origins.
Empathy	Manipulate	Bribing informants, deceiving rivals, leveraging secrets.
	Command	Directing panicked civilians, coordinating team actions under fire.
	Psychoanalyze	Reading psychological states, detecting deception through behavior, stabilizing traumatized witnesses.

Division Key Skill: *During character creation, each Division designates one Key Skill with a starting cap of 4 instead of the standard maximum of 3. See the Character Creation chapter for details.*

4.2. Skill Stunts

When you roll more 6s than the **minimum needed to succeed**, each extra 6 is a **Stunt Point**. You may spend Stunt Points to achieve effects beyond simple success.

Stunt Economy

- **1 extra 6 = 1 Stunt Point.**
- You must succeed first (at least one 6 to meet the Difficulty), then extras are stunt points.
- Stunt Points must be spent immediately – they do not carry between rolls.
- You may split stunt points across multiple effects if both are available on the same skill.
- On a **pushed roll**, stunt points still apply from the new result.

Cross-reference: *Combat stunts – spending stunt points during an attack roll – are defined in the Combat chapter (docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc). The stunt economy is the same.*

Generic Stunts (Any Skill)

The following stunts may be purchased on **any** successful skill roll:

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Faster	Accomplish the action in half the expected time. No narrative explanation needed – you just find the short path.
1	Quieter	Accomplish the action without leaving a detectable trace. The GM cannot use evidence of this action as a future complication.
1	Precise	Your result is exactly as intended – no collateral effects, no ambiguity, no partial outcomes.
1	Aid	Your success automatically assists an ally's next related roll this scene. They gain +1 die on it.
2	Extended Effect	The outcome of your action lasts an additional scene or at least one hour longer than it otherwise would.
2	Additional Target	Your action's results apply to one additional target in the same zone (the GM determines relevance).

Strength Skills

Force

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Controlled Break	You force open the door/lock/container without damaging the contents or triggering adjacent mechanisms. Finesse in violence.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Intimidating Display	Your feat of strength is visibly dramatic. One NPC present must make a Fear check (Fear Rating 1) or immediately comply with your next simple demand.
2	Clear the Room	A shove, flip, or sweep clears all loose objects from the zone simultaneously (useful for destroying a cultist's ritual setup, or just making a scene).

Brawl

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Stay Down	Target cannot stand up until the start of your next turn (they must spend a Slow Action to rise but simply cannot).
1	Weapon Strike	You've slapped or struck their weapon arm. Target suffers -1 die on all attack rolls until the end of the round.
2	Neck Crank	Target is Grappled (see Combat chapter) without requiring a separate maneuver roll. Counts as two stunts with one action.

Endure

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Grind Through	You complete the physical task despite having failed an earlier linked roll this scene (you were already exhausted but push through anyway).
1	Inspire	Your visible physical resilience gives allies heart. One ally in the scene recovers 1 point of Agility.
2	Unfazed	You succeed and take no Agility damage from whatever environmental or physical threat triggered the roll (extreme cold, sleep deprivation, toxic air).

*Agility Skills***Sneak**

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Shadow Step	You can take one additional move action as part of the same turn/scene phase without breaking your stealth. You haven't just crept in – you've repositioned perfectly.
1	Identify Exit	As you infiltrate, you map the fastest withdrawal route. You have +2 dice on any Sneak roll to leave this location later this scene.
2	Ghost Pass	Your passage leaves zero physical trace (no footprints, disturbed dust, or thermal record). Cannot be tracked from this location.

Sleight of Hand

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Undetected	The target of your pick-pocket, lift, or plant does not notice the action even after the immediate scene ends. They will assume the item was misplaced, not taken.
1	Speed Lock	You open a lock in seconds. No time resource is consumed; the GM cannot use the time you spent as a complication.
2	Perfect Plant	You plant an item on a target in a way that will implicate them credibly. Subsequent investigation will find the planted item and treat it as the target's possession.

Firearms

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Aimed Shot	The shot hits exactly the intended location (specific limb, lock, cable, tire). GM treats the result as precision even at range.
1	Suppression	Target is pinned behind cover until start of your next turn. They cannot move zones or fire back without losing their cover bonus.
2	Warning Shot	You visibly miss by design, close enough to be terrifying. Target immediately makes a Wits roll (Difficulty 2) or drops to ground and stays there for 1 round. No ammo die roll required.

Wits Skills

Investigate

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Pattern Lock	You not only find the evidence – you identify why it matters. The GM must tell you one piece of context about the object’s history or origin.
1	Clock It	You determine precisely when an event occurred (within the hour, or narrowed to a 30-minute window). Time is often as revealing as the event.
2	Hidden Compartment	You find something the scene intended to conceal – a room the blueprints don’t show, a file folder in a false wall, a trapdoor. GM must reveal one hidden element they had established but not yet disclosed.

Tech

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Trace	Successfully accessing a system also identifies who else accessed it recently – one account or one physical terminal is revealed.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Improvised Repair	The item you're repairing also gets a temporary improvement: a degraded weapon gets +1 Gear die this session; a damaged radio broadcasts on a sealed channel.
2	Ghost Session	Your access to a system leaves no log entry. No one can prove you were there.

Lore

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Deep Context	Your knowledge is not just what this thing is – you know what it was used for. GM provides one historical or ritual context detail beyond what would normally be available.
1	Weakness Identified	Your lore grants you tactical information: an entity type's vulnerability, an artifact's known failure condition, a ritual's interruption point. +1 die on the next relevant roll.
2	Primary Source	You recall a specific source – a text, a case file, a person – that would contain detailed operational information about this entity or artifact. The GM must confirm the source exists and tell you how to find it.

Empathy Skills

Manipulate

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Bought Silence	The target doesn't just comply – they will not mention this conversation to anyone for at least 24 hours. Your leverage persists.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Read the Room	Beyond this individual, you gauge how the wider group or faction feels about the situation. The GM tells you one faction-level attitude or intention.
2	Turned Asset	On an already-successful Manipulate, the target now actively wants to help you beyond the scope of your request. They will volunteer additional information or assistance once this session.

Command

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Rally	One Broken ally in the scene immediately acts on their next turn as if they had recovered – they can take their full action once before the impairment resumes.
1	Coordinated Action	Your directive enables two allies to act simultaneously on their initiative cards (they share the same slot this round only).
2	Hold the Line	All allies who can hear you gain +1 die on their next roll this round. The effect of strong leadership under pressure.

Psychoanalyze

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Pressure Point	You've identified something this person fears or desperately needs. The GM must reveal one personal vulnerability, driving motivation, or exploitable need.
1	Decompress	The person you're treating recovers 1 additional Wits or Empathy point beyond the normal healing (max to their normal maximum).

Cost	Stunt	Effect
2	Full Read	You have comprehensively understood this person’s psychological state. For the rest of the scene, you may treat all Psychoanalyze rolls against them as Difficulty 0 – you know them now.

CHAPTER 5. COMBAT

Combat in Neon Relic is fast, brutal, and consequential. Agents of the Covenant are capable individuals – but they are not soldiers. A prolonged firefight drains attributes that also serve as their sanity and stamina. Every round of violence is a resource you cannot easily recover before the next case.

Combat rules are designed for **investigation-first play**: most situations should be solvable without combat, combat should resolve quickly when it happens, and the aftermath (injury, Corruption, gear degradation) should matter as much as the outcome.

5.1. Initiative

At the start of any hostile confrontation, each participant draws an **Initiative Card** from a standard deck of playing cards (Ace through 10, face cards removed or kept – GM preference). Higher card value acts first. Ties are resolved simultaneously.

Initiative Card Draw

- Each participant – PC or NPC – draws one card from a shuffled deck.
- Participants act in **descending card order** (10 acts before 9, etc.).
- **Aces are low** (value 1) – drawing an Ace means you act last.
- Cards are discarded after the round. Reshuffle and redraw at the start of each new round.

Why cards? *The card draw creates genuine unpredictability without arithmetic. It also creates a sense of narrative suspense – drawing a 10 is a small victory; drawing an Ace before a firefight is quietly dreadful. In an investigation game where combat is exceptional, this ceremony matters.*

Initiative Modifiers

- **High Ground / Cover**: +2 to card value (draw, add 2; max 10).
- **Prone or Recovering**: -2 to card value.
- **Surprised**: Surprised characters draw **two cards** and keep the lower; they also cannot take a Fast Action on their first turn.

- **Ambush:** The ambushing side acts a full round before the ambushed side draws any cards. See Surprise below.

Surprise and Ambush

A **surprise** occurs when one side is unaware of the other at the moment combat begins.

- To attempt an ambush, the attacking side must succeed on a **Sneak (AGI)** roll opposed by the target's **Investigate (WIT)**. Use group roll rules if multiple ambushers are involved.
- If the ambush succeeds: the ambushing side takes a **free full round of actions** before initiative cards are drawn for anyone.
- If the ambush fails: draw initiative normally; no advantage granted.

5.2. Action Economy

Each character's turn consists of **one Slow Action** and **one Fast Action**, plus any number of **Free Actions**.

Slow Actions

A slow action represents a committed, focused effort requiring your full attention.

Slow Action	Description
Attack (melee or ranged)	Roll to hit and deal damage. Core offensive action.
First Aid	Use Heal skill to restore Strength or treat a Critical Injury (requires a First Aid Kit).
Reload	Reload a firearm that has run dry. No roll required; consumes ammo.
Use an Artifact	Activate an artifact's properties. Generates Corruption per artifact tier.
Activate Division Talent	Use your Division Talent (if it requires sustained effort).
Manipulate NPC	Attempt to talk someone down, issue commands, or negotiate during combat.

Slow Action	Description
Help an Ally	Add +1 die to an ally's next roll this round (must be present, skill ≥ 1).
Barricade / Fortify	Use Force to move heavy objects for cover or block a doorway.
Treat Broken Ally	Stabilize a Broken ally so they do not die (requires Heal roll).

Fast Actions

A fast action is a quick, reactive, or secondary effort.

Fast Action	Description
Move one zone	Move from your current zone to an adjacent zone.
Draw or holster a weapon	Ready a weapon you are carrying. Holstering allows you to pick up something else.
Take cover	Move into cover within your current zone (+2 Armor Rating bonus, see Cover rules).
Stand up	Rise from prone or from a knocked-down state.
Grab / pick up an item	Retrieve a dropped item or item at Engaged range.
Dodge	Reactive. See Reactive Actions below.
Use a quick item	Apply a stim, crack a light stick, or use a single-use item.

Free Actions

Free actions can be taken at any point during your turn, in any number.

- Speak briefly (one sentence or a shout)
- Drop a held item
- Look around / assess the situation (no roll)
- Toggle a device that is already in hand (safety off, flashlight switch)

5.3. Zones and Range

Combat space is divided into **abstract zones** rather than measured distances. A zone is any coherent area of space – a room, a corridor, an alley, a rooftop section. The GM defines zones when establishing a scene.

Zone Size and Movement

Moving **one zone** costs one Fast Action. Moving **two zones** (running) costs both your Fast Action and your Slow Action for the round – you forgo your attack.

Range Category	Definition
Engaged	Same zone; within arm's reach. Required for melee. Most melee weapons can only be used at Engaged range.
Near	Same or immediately adjacent zone. Close pistol range; thrown weapons; point-blank shotgun.
Short	1-2 zones. Standard pistol and shotgun range; melee not possible.
Long	3-4 zones. Rifle range; pistols at -1 die penalty.
Distant	5+ zones. Sniper range. Only applies to designated long-range weapons; everything else is out of range.

Zone Features

Every zone has optional **terrain features** the GM can invoke:

Feature	Mechanical Effect
Cramped (closets, crawlspaces, car interiors)	Long-armed weapons (rifles, shotguns) suffer -2 dice. All movement into/out of zone takes a Slow Action.
Rough (rubble, debris, slick floor)	Moving into this zone requires a Fast Action and an Agility roll (Difficulty 1). On failure, character is prone.
Dark	All Investigate, Firearms, and ranged attack rolls lose half their dice (round down) unless the character has a light source. Sneak rolls gain +2 dice.
Open (parking lots, fields)	No cover available in this zone. All ranged attacks against targets here gain +1 die.

Feature	Mechanical Effect
Elevated	Characters here gain +2 to their Initiative card value; ranged attacks against them suffer -1 die.

5.4. Melee Combat

Basic Melee Attack

Declare your target (must be at Engaged range). Roll your dice pool:

- **Heavy melee** (knife, crowbar, brawl against an armored target): **Force (STR)** + Weapon Gear Bonus
- **Fast melee** (unarmed strikes, quick knife work): **Brawl (STR)** + Weapon Gear Bonus

On a hit (at least one 6), deal the weapon's flat **Damage** value directly to the target's Strength. Armor intercepts first.

Extra successes (additional 6s) are **Stunt Points** – see Combat Stunts below.

Unarmed Combat

Unarmed attacks use the **Brawl** skill. Bare hands deal **1 Damage** on a hit.

For unarmed grapples, shoves, and disarms, see Special Melee Maneuvers below.

Special Melee Maneuvers

All maneuvers require a successful melee attack roll. If the attack misses (no 6s), the maneuver fails entirely.

Maneuver	Skill	Effect
Grapple	Brawl (STR) opposed by Force or Brawl (target's choice)	Target is grappled: they cannot move zones, use two-handed weapons, or take Slow Actions until they break free (costs their Slow Action, opposed Brawl/Force roll).
Shove	Force (STR) opposed by Endure (STR)	Target is pushed back one zone and is knocked prone. If target is already at a zone edge (stairs, window, rooftop), this may be lethal.

Maneuver	Skill	Effect
Disarm	Sleight of Hand (AGI) opposed by Force or Brawl	Target drops their held weapon. It lands at Engaged range on the floor.
Feint	Brawl (STR) opposed by Wits	No damage this turn. On success: target cannot Dodge your next attack this round. You gain +2 dice on your next melee roll against them.

5.5. Ranged Combat

Basic Ranged Attack

Roll **Firearms (AGI)** + Weapon Gear Bonus. On a hit, deal flat Damage to the target's Strength (armor applies).

Range Penalties

Weapon Type	Engaged	Near	Short	Long	Distant
Pistol (.38, 9mm)	¬1 die	–	–	¬1 die	Out of range
Shotgun	+1 Damage	–	–	¬2 dice	Out of range
Assault Rifle	¬2 dice	¬1 die	–	–	¬1 die
Thrown weapon	–	–	Out of range	Out of range	Out of range

Engaged penalty for pistols: *At arm's length, controlling a pistol one-handed while someone is grappling you is harder than a clean stance shot. The ¬1 die reflects that.*

Cover

A character **in cover** benefits from partial physical shielding.

- **Soft cover** (car door, wooden desk, drywall): +2 Armor Rating against ranged

attacks only.

- **Hard cover** (concrete pillar, stone wall, engine block): +4 Armor Rating against ranged attacks only.
- Taking cover requires a Fast Action (move into cover within the current zone).
- A character who fires from cover **loses the cover bonus** for any attacks made against them **that round** – you have to expose yourself to shoot.

Ammunition

Ammunition is tracked using a **Resource Die**. When you acquire a weapon or reload, set its ammo die:

Ammo State	Die	Notes
Full magazine	d8	Fresh load; most pistols and rifles
Half loaded	d6	Partially used
Low / scrounged	d4	Found ammo, emergency reload
Drum / extended mag	d10	Special acquisition (CL 4)

When do you roll the ammo die?

- After **pushing a Firearms roll** (you burned through rounds trying to compensate).
- After a **full auto burst** (M16 or equivalent – roll twice).
- At the GM's discretion when dramatically appropriate (long firefight, ambush, running chase).

Rolling the ammo die:

- Roll the current die. On a **1 or 2**, step the die down one size (d8→d6→d4→empty).
- On **empty** (die was d4 and rolled 1-2): weapon is dry. Reload costs a Slow Action.

5.6. Reactive Actions

Dodge

- **Type:** Fast Action (reactive – used on someone else's turn, not yours)
- **When:** After a melee or ranged attack is declared against you, before the attacker rolls.

- **Effect:** Add your **Agility** dice to your "defense pool." The attacker must beat both their own roll and your dodge roll (compare successes; attacker needs more than you).
- **Cost:** You lose your Fast Action on your **next** turn.
- **Limitation:** You cannot dodge if you have no Fast Action remaining this round (already spent), if you are prone, if you are Grappled, or if the attack was from ambush (surprise round).

Parry

- **Type:** Slow Action (reactive – used on someone else's turn)
- **When:** After a melee attack is declared against you, before the attacker rolls. Requires a held melee weapon.
- **Effect:** Roll **Brawl or Force** (your choice). If you match or exceed the attacker's successes, you take no damage. If you beat the attacker's successes, they lose their Slow Action next round (their weapon arm is numbed or they are off-balance).
- **Cost:** You lose your Slow Action on your **next** turn.
- **Limitation:** Cannot parry ranged attacks, unarmed shoves, or any attack from a weapon with Damage 4+.

5.7. Combat Stunts

Extra successes (6s beyond the first on any attack roll) are **Stunt Points**. Spend them from the table below. One stunt point = one effect unless listed otherwise.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Knock Prone	Target is knocked to the ground. They must spend a Fast Action to stand.
1	Disarm	Target drops their held weapon at Engaged range (without a full Disarm maneuver roll).
1	Target Limb	Attack hits a specific limb. GM applies a situational penalty (hobbled, one-armed, etc.) until treated.
1	Push Back	Target is forced one zone away.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Scare	Target must immediately make a Fear check (Fear Rating 1) even if no supernatural trigger is present. The violence itself breaks them.
2	Double Damage	Deal the weapon's Damage value twice instead of once.
2	Suppressive Fire	Target is pinned – they cannot move zones until the start of your next turn unless they succeed on a Wits roll (Difficulty 2).
2	Destroy Cover	Target's cover is destroyed or invalidated after this attack.
3	Critical Hit	Attack triggers a roll on the Critical Injury table (<i>Issue #4</i>), regardless of whether the target is Broken.

5.8. Chase and Pursuit

When one side is fleeing and the other is pursuing, use the following chase rules.

Chase Structure

A chase is divided into **chase rounds**. Each round, both the fleeing and pursuing party roll their relevant attribute + skill:

- **On foot:** Agility + Sneak (for stealth flight) or Agility + Endure (for pure sprint)
- **By vehicle:** Agility + Tech (operating the vehicle) – full vehicle rules are forthcoming (#21)

Chase Outcome Per Round

- Compare successes. The side with more successes **gains distance** (fleeing) or **closes distance** (pursuing).
- Track relative distance on a simple 5-step track: **Contact** → **Near** → **Far** → **Very Far** → **Escaped**.
- Start at Contact. Fleeing party wins a round → move one step toward Escaped. Pursuing party wins → move one step toward Contact.

Escape and Recapture

- The fleeing party **escapes** when they reach the Escaped position.
- During a chase, characters may still attack (at whatever range the current position represents) but do so at **-1 die** (distraction of movement).
- If the pursuing party reaches Contact: normal combat resumes.
- **Hiding:** If the fleeing party is at Far or Very Far and succeeds on a Sneak roll (Difficulty 2), they may break the chase entirely without reaching Escaped – they simply vanish into the environment.

5.9. Group Combat (Multiple NPCs)

When 3 or more combatants on the NPC side share a common purpose and act together, they may be treated as a **mob**.

Mob Rules

- A mob draws **one Initiative card** and acts as a single entity.
- A mob has a shared Strength pool equal to **3 × mob size** (3 per member, max 15).
- A mob attacks as one unit: roll dice pool equal to the **highest individual's pool** + bonus dice equal to mob members beyond the first (max +3).
- **Splitting a mob:** Area effects (full auto, explosive, fire) or AoE-capable stunts can split a mob, with the GM distributing Strength loss across members.

Mobs represent low-tier hostiles (cultist grunt, security guard, Compact foot soldier). Named or significant NPCs always act individually.

5.10. Ending Combat*Surrender*

An NPC surrenders when their Strength is reduced to 2 or when a **Manipulate (EMP)** roll is made against them while they are below half Strength (Difficulty 1). A surrendered NPC drops their weapon and complies with instructions.

Player characters may **always** choose to surrender – it is never forced mechanically.

Retreat and Withdrawal

A character may disengage from combat freely on their turn as long as:

- No enemy is Engaged with them (Engaged = melee), OR
- They succeed on an Agility roll (Difficulty 1) to break from Engaged contact.

After disengaging, they may move up to two zones in the same turn (spending their Fast Action and Slow Action on movement).

Broken in Combat

When an NPC's Strength reaches 0, they are **Broken** (incapacitated). The GM chooses: dead, dying, or surrendering based on context and the nature of the attack.

When a PC's Strength reaches 0, they are **Broken**:

- They collapse and are incapacitated.
- They must roll on the **Critical Injury table** (see Issue #4 – [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#)).
- They are out of the fight unless stabilized by an ally (Heal roll, costs a Slow Action, requires a First Aid Kit).
- An unstabilized Broken PC **dies** at the end of the scene unless treated.

Capture over kill: *The Covenant defaults to capturing hostile humans for interrogation. NPCs with relevant information are more valuable alive. GMs should give players narrative opportunities to take prisoners rather than mandating lethality.*

CHAPTER 6. SOCIAL CONFLICT

Investigation games are social games. Most of what agents do in Neon Relic is talk to people: witnesses who saw something and won't say it, cult members who believe what they're doing is righteous, informants who want to help but are terrified, supervisors who need to believe the cover story. The skill of the agent is reading people and moving them.

Social conflict in Neon Relic uses the **Disposition model** – a lightweight system that tracks where an NPC stands and shifts based on agent actions. It does not require rounds or "social HP." It uses the existing dice pool mechanics and resolves quickly.

6.1. NPC Disposition

Every NPC who is not immediately cooperative has a **Disposition** – a state describing their current openness to engagement. Disposition exists on a 5-point track:

Score	State	Behaviour
5	Open	The NPC wants to help. They volunteer information. No roll needed for basic cooperation.
4	Cautious	The NPC is willing to talk but holds back. They answer simple questions but hedge on anything sensitive.
3	Guarded	The NPC is resistant. They answer only what they must. Social rolls are Difficulty 2.
2	Hostile	The NPC is actively uncooperative. They may lie, deflect, or attempt to end the scene. Social rolls are Difficulty 3.
1	Closed	The NPC will not engage. They may call for help, alert others, or physically leave. Social rolls are Difficulty 4.

Starting Disposition

The GM sets starting Disposition based on the NPC's relationship to the agents and the situation. Suggested defaults:

- **Covenant superior with a legitimate inquiry:** 4 (Cautious)
 - **Cooperative civilian eye-witness:** 4 (Cautious) – usually wants to help but scared
 - **Rogue cultist in custody:** 2 (Hostile)
 - **Paid informant:** 3 (Guarded) if money is involved, 4 if a relationship has been built
 - **Hostile faction member:** 1 or 2 (Closed / Hostile) by default
 - **Mid-level Compact operative:** 2 (Hostile)
-

6.2. Shifting Disposition

Disposition shifts up (toward Open) or down (toward Closed) based on agent actions, NPC reveals, and roll outcomes.

Actions that Shift Disposition Up (+1)

- A successful Psychoanalyze roll (treating or reading the NPC)
- A successful Manipulate roll that makes the NPC feel their interests are served
- The agent voluntarily reveals information that helps the NPC (demonstrates good faith)
- The NPC is shown physical evidence that confirms what they suspected
- An agent successfully makes a roll to perform a service for the NPC before asking anything

Actions that Shift Disposition Down (-1)

- A failed Manipulate roll (the NPC sees through the attempt)
- The NPC catches an agent in a lie (GM's judgment, or a failed opposed Investigate roll from the NPC)
- An agent makes a physical threat or veiled threat while the NPC's Disposition is 3+
- A successful Psychoanalyze roll by the GM on behalf of the NPC (they read the agents – see NPC Social Defense below)
- An agent reveals information that endangers the NPC or confirms they are a target

Disposition Thresholds

- **Disposition 3 or higher:** The NPC will answer direct questions truthfully (though not necessarily fully). No roll required for general cooperation.
- **Disposition 2:** The NPC requires a successful social roll to answer even basic questions. They will lie by default.
- **Disposition 1:** The NPC is done with the scene. They must be brought back to 2 before any social rolls are possible. Physical containment is required for continued interrogation.

6.3. Social Rolls in Practice

Social rolls use the normal dice pool (Attribute + Skill), difficulty set by current Disposition. You are always rolling against the NPC's **current state**, not their willpower or an abstract resistance.

Manipulate (Empathy)

Used to deceive, persuade, bribe, leverage, or appeal to self-interest. Manipulate specifically targets the NPC's **wants and fears** – it works through the gap between what they want the world to be and what it is.

- **On success:** NPC complies with the specific request, AND Disposition shifts +1 (they feel the interaction was productive, even if later they're not sure why).
- **On failure:** Request denied. Disposition shifts -1. The NPC has clocked the attempt.
- **On a pushed failure:** As above, but Disposition shifts -2. The NPC is now certain they are being worked, and they know by whom.

Command (Empathy)

Used to assert authority, direct behavior under pressure, or coordinate. Command does not persuade – it **compels through confidence and force of presence**. It works when the NPC is uncertain what to do, when the agents represent a legitimate authority, or when the situation is dangerous enough that someone taking charge feels like relief.

- **Command does not work at Disposition 2 or lower.** An NPC who is already hostile cannot be commanded – you have no authority in their frame.
- **On success:** NPC complies fully for the immediate scene. No Disposition shift.

- **On failure:** NPC fails to comply. No Disposition shift, but the failed authority assertion may have social consequences at the GM's discretion.

Psychoanalyze (Empathy)

Used to read, understand, or heal. In social conflict, Psychoanalyze has two modes:

Reading: You are trying to understand the NPC's underlying state – what they need, what they fear, what they're not saying.

- On success: GM must reveal one true thing about this NPC's psychological state, motivation, or deception. Disposition is not directly shifted, but the information can be used to inform subsequent Manipulate rolls (advantage: +1 die on the next Manipulate against this NPC if the revealed information is used).

Stabilizing: You are treating an NPC's fear, trauma, or distress to make them more communicative.

- On success: Disposition shifts +2 (the NPC feels seen and safe). Difficulty equals the source of distress (supernatural encounter: Difficulty 3; mundane fear: Difficulty 1).
- On failure: Disposition shifts -1 (you probed and made it worse).

6.4. NPC Social Defense

NPCs can also read agents. A canny NPC may actively attempt to read or manipulate the agents in return. The GM may call for:

- **Opposed Psychoanalyze roll:** GM rolls on behalf of the NPC. On NPC success, Disposition shifts are reversed for that action, OR the NPC identifies a specific agent as the social focal point (they will now direct deflection at that agent).
- **Lie detection:** The GM may roll NPC Wits (no skill) against an agent's Manipulate roll. On NPC success, the deception is detected and Disposition shifts -1 immediately.

These are at GM discretion, not every NPC has this capability. Social defense is for NPCs with relevant training: intelligence operatives, therapists, con artists, experienced detectives.

6.5. Consequences of Failed Social Scenes

When a social scene ends badly (Disposition reaches 1, or the agents leave having gained nothing), the GM applies one or more consequences:

Consequence Type	Example
Closed source	The NPC will not speak to the agents again this mission. The information they held may be inaccessible.
Alert raised	The NPC warns someone – their employer, their family, The Compact. Agents' activities are now known to a new party.
Physical escalation	The scene tips into violence. The NPC or their contacts move against the agents.
Faction response	A rival faction learns that the Covenant is investigating. Their own response begins accelerating.
Trust erosion	A Covenant contact or superior is told about the agents' approach. Standing within the Covenant takes a hit for the current case.

6.6. Social Pressure and Fear

Social encounters with entities, artifacts, or cult members may cross into supernatural territory. When the content of a conversation triggers a Fear check:

- **Direct supernatural revelation during a Manipulate scene** (the NPC says something that cannot be explained naturally): Fear check, Fear Rating 1 or 2.
- **Psychoanalyze roll on a contaminated NPC** (someone who has long-term artifact exposure): Roll Psychoanalyze as normal. On any failure, the agent picks up a psychic echo – immediate Fear check, Fear Rating 2. On success, the agent gets the information but gains +1 Corruption.

See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#) for full Fear check rules.

6.7. Worked Example: Interrogating a Cultist

Setup: The agents have detained Brother Elias – a mid-level member of The Ember Accord cult – in the back of a van. He believes the artifact they recovered is a holy relic and resents being treated as a criminal.

Starting Disposition: 2 (Hostile). He's in zip ties. He's praying under his breath. He won't look at the agents directly.

Round 1: Agent Petra Vasquez attempts Psychoanalyze (Read) – she wants to understand what Elias actually believes before making any demands. The GM sets Difficulty 2 (his Disposition).

Petra rolls Empathy 3 + Psychoanalyze 2 = 5 dice. Rolls: 6, 4, 3, 2, 1 – one success.

GM reveals: Elias genuinely believes the artifact protected his sister during a cancer diagnosis two years ago. He is not performing faith. He is terrified that if it leaves his possession, she will relapse. He is not lying about any of this.

Round 2: Using that information, Agent Marcus Osei attempts Manipulate. He doesn't argue about the artifact being dangerous – he asks about the sister. Where is she? Is she still safe? The agents can make sure she stays that way.

Manipulate roll: Empathy 4 + Manipulate 3 = 7 dice. Difficulty 2. Rolls: 6, 6, 5, 3, 2, 1, 1 – two successes (one extra = 1 Stunt Point).

Success: Elias answers the question about the sister (she's in Providence, she's fine). Disposition shifts to 3.

Stunt Point spent: Bought Silence – Elias will not tell the Accord that the agents know about his sister.

Round 3: Disposition is now 3 (Guarded). Direct questions are possible. The agents ask who gave Elias the artifact to begin with.

Another Manipulate roll at Difficulty 2 (they're now at 3). Marcus rolls: 6, 5, 4, 4, 2, 2, 1 – one success.

Elias gives the name: a fence named Talvez, operating out of a pawn shop on the East Side. He works for several clients. Elias doesn't know who.

Outcome: The scene ends having extracted the key information. Disposition is still 3 – Elias is not exactly cooperative, but he's no longer hostile. The agents have a lead and a lever (the sister) if they need him again.

6.8. Cross-References

- Skills in context: [docs/chapters/04-attributes-skills.adoc](#)
- Fear checks during social scenes: [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#)
- Using Manipulate stunts: [docs/chapters/04-attributes-skills.adoc](#) (Skill Stunts)

- NPC Faction relationships: [docs/chapters/17-rival-factions.adoc](#)

CHAPTER 7. HEALTH, DAMAGE, AND ARMOR

In the Year Zero Engine, characters do not possess a traditional, escalating pool of "Hit Points." Instead, your **four core Attributes directly serve as your health pools**.

7.1. Damage Types

Every source of damage specifies its type and target attribute. The attack defines the damage, not the defender.

Damage Type	Target	Sources
Physical	Strength (violence, toxins, falls) or Agility (exhaustion, prolonged exertion)	Weapons, environmental hazards, physical traps, mundane combat
Mental	Wits (terror, confusion, psychic assault) or Empathy (grief, guilt, emotional manipulation)	Failed Fear checks (Wits only), supernatural abilities, psychological attacks, social betrayal
Corruption	Corruption track directly	Pushing rolls, activating Division Talents, occult exposure, artifact activation/feedback, specific creature attacks

Damage Type Rules

1. **The source specifies the damage type and target attribute.** The defender does not choose.
2. **Combination attacks** are possible: a supernatural creature might deal Physical (STR) + Corruption damage in the same attack. Both are applied.
3. **Weapon stat blocks** list: Damage value, Damage Type, Target Attribute. Example: *Knife – Damage 2, Physical (STR)*.
4. **Creature stat blocks** list damage per attack. Example: *Shadow Tendril – Damage 2, Mental (WIT) + 1 Corruption*.
5. **Broken state** triggers when any attribute reaches 0, as before. Physical Broken (STR/AGI = 0) → Physical Critical Injury table. Mental Broken (WIT/EMP = 0) → Mental Critical Injury table.

What Determines STR vs AGI / WIT vs EMP

- **Physical attacks** default to **STR** unless the source is specifically about exhaustion, fatigue, or overexertion (then AGI).
- **Mental attacks** default to **WIT** unless the source is specifically emotional, social, or empathic (then EMP).
- The GM does not adjudicate this per-attack. The weapon, creature, or event definition states the target.

7.2. The Broken State

If any Attribute is reduced to **0**, your character becomes **Broken**:

- The character is immediately **incapacitated**.
- They must roll on a **Critical Injury table**, which can result in lethal consequences or permanent maiming depending on the severity of the attack.

7.3. Death and Dying

Being **Broken** is not the same as being dead. Death is a separate, subsequent event – probabilistic, not automatic – that occurs if a Broken character does not receive care in time.

The Three States

State	Status	What It Means
Broken / Unconscious	Any Attribute = 0. Critical Injury rolled.	Character is incapacitated. They can still be saved.
Dying	Broken with a Death Check Critical Injury (result marked †) – and the Death Check has not yet been resolved, or was survived but the underlying injury is active (Bleeding, Guttled).	The window for stabilization is closing. An untreated Dying character will die.

State	Status	What It Means
Dead	Death Check rolled and failed, OR a specific instant-death result triggered, OR Dying window expires without treatment.	The character is gone.

The Death Check

A **Death Check** is a single d6 roll. It is required whenever a Critical Injury is marked with †.

- Roll one d6.
- **1–2:** The character dies.
- **3–6:** The character survives – the Critical Injury still applies and must be treated, but they cling to life.

Medical Training Talent (Keep): An ally with Medical Training may spend a Slow Action to make a **Heal (WIT) roll (Difficulty 2)** before the Death Check is rolled. On success: the dying character rolls d6+2 instead of d6 (death only on 1, and only if the Heal roll succeeded). On failure: no change; Death Check proceeds normally.

The Stabilization Window

A Broken character who has rolled a Death-Check result (†) has a limited window in which an ally can stabilize them before death becomes inevitable:

- **Within the same scene:** An ally may attempt to stabilize the Dying character (see First Aid below).
- **End of scene without treatment:** The character must roll their Death Check unmodified. No ally assistance.
- **Instant Death exceptions:** Critical Injury result **66 (DOA)** requires an immediate Death Check – there is no window. The Heal roll to influence it must be attempted within the same round (not the same scene).

First Aid: Stabilizing a Dying Character

To stabilize a Dying ally during the stabilization window:

- **Skill:** Heal (WIT)

- **Action:** Slow Action
- **Requirements:** A First Aid Kit must be present. Without one, the roll is made at -2 dice.
- **Difficulty:** 2 (normal), 3 (if Gutted or Arterial Strike), 4 (if DOA attempted mid-round)
- **On success:** The Dying state is resolved. The Critical Injury remains. The character is Broken/Unconscious but no longer dying. They need rest and proper medical care, but they will live.
- **On failure:** Stabilization attempt failed. The character may try again if time permits (same scene). Each failed attempt reduces the character's current Strength by 1 (the effort causes further distress).

Instant Death

Two Critical Injury results bypass the Death Check entirely:

- **Result 66 (DOA) with automatic failure:** This death check cannot succeed – there is no roll. If the Heal roll (Difficulty 4, same round) is not made in time, the character dies. There are no further attempts.
- **Result 55 (Shattered Will), 46 (Catatonic Episode)** – mental death:* Mental Death Checks work the same way; success or failure has the same probability (d6, 1-2 = retirement). These represent permanent catatonia, not physical death – but the character is retired from play regardless.

Design note: *Instant physical death (result 66) is rare and requires an enormous attack to reach the worst end of the D66 table. It represents an overwhelmingly lethal event. Most character deaths will come from failed Death Checks, not from this result.*

Character Death and Continuity

When a character dies:

1. **Gear returns to Stack.** Division equipment, the Division Signature Item (Verdant Codex, Warden's Bracer, etc.), and all Covenant-issued gear are logged and returned at the end of the Case File.
2. **Covenant notification.** The character is officially listed as **Fallen in the Line of Duty**. The circumstances are filed – truthfully or not, at the surviving team's discretion.

3. **Dark Secrets.** A dead character's Dark Secrets may surface posthumously. If an NPC knew the secret, the GM may still play that complication forward with remaining PCs (the secret outlives the character).
4. **Character replacement.** A new character enters play at the start of the next Case File. They begin with the same XP total as the lowest-XP surviving member of the team (minimum starting values). They arrive as a new Covenant recruitment – briefed, equipped, and nervous.
5. **Legacy.** The deceased character's player chooses one lasting effect: a significant item the new character carries (with GM permission), an NPC connection inherited, or a reputation within the Covenant that precedes them.

Corruption Death vs. Physical Death

Physical death and Corruption-threshold death are distinct retirement paths:

- **Physical death:** Any Attribute at 0 → Critical Injury → possible Death Check failure. The character dies with their body intact enough for others to note.
- **Corruption death:** Corruption exceeds 10 + Empathy → permanent catatonia. The character exists but is unreachable – institutionalized, catatonic, or simply lost. Technically still alive, but gone from play.

Corruption death is in many ways worse. Physical death is clean. Corruption death means your colleagues have to keep making decisions about someone they knew, who is now a stranger in a hospital bed.

7.4. Critical Injuries

When a character is **Broken** (any Attribute reduced to 0), they immediately roll on the appropriate Critical Injury table. The table used depends on **what type of damage Broke them**:

- **Physical (Strength = 0):** Roll on the Physical Critical Injury table.
- **Exhaustion (Agility = 0):** Roll on the Physical Critical Injury table (the body has failed).
- **Mental (Wits = 0):** Roll on the Mental & Emotional Critical Injury table.
- **Emotional (Empathy = 0):** Roll on the Mental & Emotional Critical Injury table.

How to Roll D66

Roll two d6. The first die is the **tens digit**, the second is the **units digit**. A result of 3 on the first die and 4 on the second = **34**.

Death Checks

Some results are marked † (Death Check). When you roll one, roll a single d6:

- On a **1-2**: Your character dies.
- On a **3-6**: You survive – barely. The Critical Injury still applies.

A character with **Medical Training** (Keep talent) may spend a Slow Action making a **Heal (WIT)** roll (Difficulty 2) to give a dying ally **+2 to their death check die** before it's rolled (effectively making death only on a 1).

Physical Critical Injury Table (D66)

Roll when Broken by **Strength or Agility** damage.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
11	Wind Knocked Out	No actions next turn; Strength returns to 1.	Recovers automatically end of scene.
12	Bad Fall	Agility reduced by 1 permanently.	Requires Keep medical facility (downtime).
13	Bloody Nose	-1 die on Investigate rolls until treated.	First Aid Kit (Difficulty 1) restores.
14	Cracked Ribs	-1 die on all Force rolls; any violent action costs 1 additional Strength.	Bed rest (1 downtime phase).
15	Sprained Wrist	Cannot use two-handed weapons. -1 die on all AGI rolls.	Splint + 1 downtime phase.
16	Grazed	Strength returns to 1. Scar remains (cosmetic).	No treatment needed.
21	Concussion	Wits reduced by 1 until treated. Disorientation: must succeed on Wits roll (Diff 1) to use Slow Actions.	Heal roll + 24 hours rest.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
22	Shoulder Dislocation	Dominant arm useless. -2 dice on all STR rolls.	Heal check (Difficulty 2); 1 downtime phase.
23	Torn Knee	Movement costs double (2 Fast Actions per zone instead of 1).	Surgery (Keep facility) + 1 downtime phase.
24	 ringing Ears	-1 die on all WIT-based rolls for rest of session.	No treatment needed – fades by next session.
25	Fractured Hand	-2 dice on all AGI rolls. Cannot wield weapons requiring grip.	Splint + 2 downtime phases.
26	Severe Bruising	-1 Strength maximum until healed (cannot be healed above 3).	Heal roll (Difficulty 2) + 1 downtime phase.
31	Deep Laceration	Bleeds 1 Strength per round until treated (First Aid, Difficulty 1).	Bandaging stops bleed; full recovery = 1 downtime.
32	Fractured Arm	Non-dominant arm: useless. Dominant arm: -2 dice STR.	Cast + 2 downtime phases.
33	Broken Nose (Insight)	+1 die on Intimidate rolls forever (you look dangerous now).	No mechanical healing needed. Defect: cosmetic disfiguration.
34	Shattered Kneecap	Movement speed halved permanently (1 zone costs Slow Action). Surgery can restore.	Keep surgical facility + 2 downtime phases.
35	Punctured Lung	-2 dice on all STR and AGI rolls. Strenuous action triggers Endure roll (Difficulty 2) or collapse.	Heal roll (Difficulty 3) + 2 downtime phases.
36	Blinding Strike	One eye damaged: -1 die on all ranged attack and Investigate rolls permanently. Insight: +1 die on Empathy rolls (you understand fragility now).	Cannot be fully healed; monocle/patch is acquired (CL 1).
41	Severed Tendon	Permanently -1 Agility.	Keep surgical facility restores -1 penalty only.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
42	Trauma Shock	Frozen for 1d6 rounds. No actions possible. Strength returns to 1 after unfreezing.	Recovers on its own; stimulants (Fast Action) end it immediately.
43	Broken Vertebra	Agility reduced by 2. Risk of paralysis: any further STR/AGI damage to 0 triggers death check without rolling.	Keep surgical facility (requires 2 downtime phases, Difficulty 3 Heal check).
44	Organ Damage	Strength maximum reduced by 2 permanently.	Keep surgical facility can restore 1 point.
45	Severed Ear	Permanent -1 die on Investigate rolls. Insight: +1 die on Empathy rolls (you listen more carefully now).	Cosmetic only; scar remains.
46	Gutted †	Bleeding: lose 1 Strength per round. Death check after 3 rounds if untreated. Heal (Difficulty 3) stops bleeding.	Emergency surgery (Keep facility) required; 2 downtime phases.
51	Broken Jaw	Cannot speak coherently. Cannot use Manipulate or Command skills until treated.	Surgical wire (Keep) + 1 downtime phase.
52	Nerve Damage	Permanently -1 Agility. Occasional muscle spasms: on any die roll of all 1s, drop what you're holding.	Cannot be healed.
53	Severe Burns	-2 dice on all STR/AGI actions. Unbandaged burns: lose 1 Strength per scene from infection.	Keep medical facility; 2 downtime phases.
54	Spinal Injury	Agility reduced to 1 until treated. No running (cannot move two zones).	Keep surgical facility (Difficulty 4); 3 downtime phases.
55	Arm Blown Off †	Dominant arm severed. Death check. Surviving: permanently one-armed. All two-handed weapons require improvised rig or aid.	Cannot regrow. Prosthetic possible (Issue #21, CL 5).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
56	Skull Fracture †	Death check. Surviving: Wits permanently reduced by 1. Severe headaches: -1 die on Investigate for 1 month.	Keep facility; 1 downtime phase after death check survival.
61	Chest Shot †	Death check. Surviving: Strength maximum reduced by 1 permanently.	Emergency surgery (Keep facility required immediately).
62	Leg Blown Off †	Death check. Surviving: movement reduced to 1 zone per Slow Action, permanently.	Cannot regrow. Prosthetic possible (Issue #21, CL 5).
63	Multiple Wounds †	Death check. Surviving: roll twice more on this table (ignoring further †).	As per rolled injuries.
64	Arterial Strike †	Bleeding 2 Strength per round. Death check must be made within 2 rounds or automatic death.	Tourniquet (Fast Action, CL 1) buys 1 extra round; Heal (Difficulty 4) fully stabilizes.
65	Head Shot †	Death check. Surviving: permanently remove 1 from Wits AND Empathy. Insight: +2 dice on Psychoanalyze forever (near-death clarity).	Cannot be healed. Persistent migraines (permanent).
66	DOA †	Automatic death check (no bonus). Surviving: character is clinically dead for 1d6 rounds before CPR-equivalent revives them. All Attributes return to 1. Permanent: +3 Corruption, Empathy -1.	See Corruption chapter.

Mental & Emotional Critical Injury Table (D66)

Roll when Broken by **Wits** or **Empathy** damage. Mental criticals always gain Corruption – the occult has left its mark.

All mental criticals: Gain +1 Corruption upon rolling this table, in addition to any listed in the individual result.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
11	Shaken	-1 die on all WIT and EMP rolls until end of scene. Wits or Empathy returns to 1.	Rest or reassurance (Empathy roll, Difficulty 1).
12	Distracted	Cannot push rolls until the end of scene (mind can't sustain the effort).	ends automatically with scene change.
13	Tremors	Fine motor control impaired: -1 die on Sleight of Hand and Firearms this session.	No treatment needed – fades by next session.
14	Dissociation	Character acts on autopilot: GM narrates their next turn's actions.	Psychoanalyze check (Difficulty 1) by ally to snap them out early.
15	Paranoid Flash	Character immediately acts on the nearest perceived threat (GM chooses target – may be an ally).	Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 1) ends it; 1 Empathy cost to the treating ally.
16	Acute Anxiety	All Difficulty ratings increase by 1 for rest of scene.	Scene change ends it automatically.
21	Night Terrors	Between sessions: character does not benefit from sleep-based recovery. Agility Broken recovery is halved.	Psychoanalyze session (downtime, Difficulty 2) clears it.
22	Intrusive Visions	-1 die on Investigate whenever concentration is needed (GM's discretion).	Psychoanalyze session (downtime, Difficulty 2).
23	Fugue State	Miss one scene entirely (treated as absent). Character wanders or freezes; ally must spend a Slow Action per round to keep them moving.	Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2) by an ally to restore presence.
24	Emotional Numbing	Empathy reduced by 1 until treated. Cannot Manipulate others – no connection is felt.	Downtime scene of roleplay connection + Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
25	Hypervigilance (Insight)	Permanently: +1 die on Investigate rolls (always watching). Permanent: -1 die on Empathy-based social rolls (you don't trust anyone).	No recovery needed – rewired.
26	Compulsion	Character develops a specific compulsion (GM and player define together: counting objects, checking door locks, avoiding red cars). Each scene, must make Wits roll (Difficulty 1) or act on compulsion before other actions.	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases, Difficulty 3) to suppress.
31	Sensory Flashback	Triggered by a GM-defined stimulus (a smell, a sound). When triggered: lose Fast Action that round as flashback fires.	Psychoanalyze campaign (2 downtime phases, Difficulty 2).
32	Social Withdrawal	-2 dice on all Empathy-based rolls. Character refuses social complexity.	Downtime social scene (roleplay) + Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2).
33	Survivor Guilt	If any ally takes damage within the scene, character suffers 1 Empathy damage (involuntary).	Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2) + meaningful roleplay scene.
34	Paranoid Ideation	Character believes a specific NPC or faction is surveilling them (GM chooses). Act on it: +1 die on Sneak actions. Suffer it: -1 die on Empathy rolls involving the believed threat.	Psychoanalyze campaign (2 downtime phases).
35	Dissociative Identity Trigger	+1 Corruption (additional). GM introduces an alternate behavioral state – twice per session, at dramatic moments, rolls a d6: 1-2 = alternate state this scene.	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases, Difficulty 3).
36	Rage Episodes	When Empathy falls below 2, character must succeed on Wits roll (Difficulty 2) or attack nearest person (ally or foe).	Psychoanalyze campaign (2 downtime phases, Difficulty 3).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
41	Artifact Corruption (Insight)	+2 Corruption (additional). Permanent: +1 die on all artifact interaction rolls (you opened a channel). Permanent: -1 Empathy.	Cannot be recovered – this is the artifact's mark.
42	Phobia	New phobia defined (GM and player): when triggered, automatic Fear check at Fear Rating 3.	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases, Difficulty 3) reduces to Fear Rating 1.
43	Waking Hallucinations	Wits reduced by 1 permanently. Once per session, character perceives a supernatural intrusion that may or may not be real (GM only knows).	Keep's Empathy specialist can reduce severity; Wits loss is permanent.
44	Emotional Bleed	Permanently -1 Empathy. Character becomes emotionally numb – all social skill rolls suffer -1 die for the remainder of the campaign.	Cannot be healed.
45	Fracture Point	Corruption threshold reduced by 2 (permanently). Max Corruption = 8 + Empathy instead of 10 + Empathy . The exposure has cracked something fundamental.	Cannot be reversed.
46	Catatonic Episode †	Death check (mind, not body – failure = permanent catatonia, character retirement). Surviving: Wits and Empathy each reduced by 1. +2 Corruption immediately.	Intensive Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 4, Keep facility) over 2 downtime phases to stabilize.
51	Obsessive Documentation	Character must document everything (Insight: +2 dice on Investigate when reviewing notes from current mission). Compulsion: spends all available time writing; -1 die on social rolls (distracted).	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases) to reduce compulsion; Insight remains.
52	Broken Empathy	Permanently -2 Empathy. All social skills lose 2 dice.	Cannot be healed – the connection is severed.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
53	Artifact Imprint	+3 Corruption (additional). Character begins hearing the artifact that Broke them. GM may use this as a plot hook: the artifact calls them back.	Containment ritual (Issue #15) can suppress the call but not eliminate the imprint.
54	Veil Burn	+2 Corruption. Wits permanently -1. Insight: +1 die on all artifact detection rolls (you can feel them now).	Cannot be healed – the Veil has scorched your perception permanently.
55	Shattered Will †	Death check (mind). Surviving: Wits and Empathy max permanently reduced by 1 each. +2 Corruption. Cannot push rolls for remainder of campaign arc until psychological breakthrough (GM milestone).	Keep Psychoanalyze program (4 downtime phases, Difficulty 4).
56	Cosmic Revelation †	Death check (mind). Surviving: character learns something true and terrible about the Covenant's mission or the nature of artifacts. +3 Corruption, -2 Empathy permanently. Insight: +2 dice on all Lore-type rolls forever (Wayfinder skill equivalent). GM defines the revelation – it should reshape how the character sees the world.	Cannot be unlearned. Roleplay is mandatory.
61	Memory Dissolution	Permanently -1 Wits. Character loses one specific skill memory (GM chooses a skill at rank 1-2; it drops to 0).	Cannot recover lost skill without retraining (requires downtime advancement, Issue #2).
62	Identity Crisis	Character's Division Allegiance wavers. For 1 campaign arc, they cannot use their Division Talent.	Major roleplay scene with Covenant superior + Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 3).
63	Veil Madness	+4 Corruption immediately. Roll on this table again (ignore result 63 on reroll).	As per second roll result.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
64	Prophetic Fugue †	Death check (mind). Surviving: +3 Corruption. Character enters a trance broadcasting the Covenant's location to hostile artifact entities until a Wayfinder performs a Shielding ritual (Issue #15).	Ritual seals the broadcast; Corruption remains.
65	Ego Death †	Death check (mind). Surviving: character personality fundamentally alters. Player rewrites one Drive and one aspect of their biography. +3 Corruption. Insight: +2 dice on all Empathy rolls (dissolution breeds radical compassion – or fearlessness).	Cannot be undone. Roleplay the new self.
66	Unraveling †	Automatic mind death check (no bonus). Surviving: +4 Corruption, -1 to every Attribute permanently, character retires at end of current mission (they cannot continue as an operative). Final scene before retirement should be played.	Retirement is farewell – play it well.

Cross-References

- **Corruption gain** from mental criticals is applied immediately (see [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#)).
- **Healing in the field:** First Aid Kit, Heal skill, Psychoanalyze skill – see [Healing Corruption](#).
- **Downtime recovery:** Between-mission phases and Keep medical access – see [docs/chapters/12-headquarters.adoc](#).
- **Death and dying procedure:** Full death check rules with autopsy and Covenant notification – see (*Issue #13*).
- **Artifact Imprint and Veil Burn:** Interaction with artifact containment rituals – see [docs/chapters/11-artifacts.adoc](#) (*Issue #9*).

7.5. *Armor Mechanics*

To survive lethal encounters, agents utilize armor (such as concealed Kevlar vests or tactical riot gear):

1. When you suffer physical damage, roll a number of **Gear Dice** equal to the item's **Armor Rating**.
2. Every **6** rolled absorbs **1 point** of incoming damage before it reduces your Strength.
3. **Degradation:** If you roll any **1s** on an armor save, the Armor Rating is permanently reduced by 1 until repaired by Stack during downtime.

CHAPTER 8. CORRUPTION, FEAR, AND HEALING

Corruption is Neon Relic's signature mechanic – a single ascending number that tracks the cumulative psychic toll of occult exposure, supernatural exertion, and sheer human desperation. It functions as an "inverse hit points" system: every push, every artifact activation, every encounter with the unnatural ratchets the number higher, and there is no coming back from the top.

8.1. The Corruption Track

Corruption starts at **0** and increases from there. It is gained directly from its sources and reduced (slowly) by its methods – there is no buffer, no cascade, and no shortcut.

Maximum Corruption Threshold = **10 + Empathy score**

When a character's Corruption **exceeds** their threshold, their mind permanently fractures. The character enters a catatonic state and is **immediately removed from the campaign**.

8.2. Sources of Corruption

Trigger	Corruption Gained	Description
Pushing a Roll	+1	Exerting your absolute limits invites psychic static.
Activating a Division Talent	+1	Talents that tap the supernatural exact a cost.
Occult Exposure	+1 to +3	Witnessing entities, reading forbidden tomes, or being targeted by anomalous phenomena. GM sets severity.
Artifact Activation	+1 to +3	Utilizing an artifact's supernatural properties. Cost varies by artifact tier.
Fear Check (any 1s rolled)	+1	The mind cracks trying to process the unprocessable. See Fear rules below.
Failed Fear Check	+1	On top of any 1s penalty. See Fear rules below.

8.3. Corruption Effects

Corruption	Stage	Mechanical & Narrative Consequence
1–3	Nosebleeds / Migraines	Intense intracranial pressure. Occasional bleeding and severe headaches. The character maintains control.
4–6	Auditory Hallucinations	Distinct whispers from the void – voices of the dead or entities from beyond.
7–9	Eldritch Tremors	Anomalous energy violently courses through the nervous system. Noticeable physical twitches develop.
10–12	Reality Distortion	The localized environment physically warps. Lights shatter, shadows stretch, electronics fry in the character's presence.
13–14	Fugue States	A nearby entity or latent force begins seizing control of the character's motor functions. Lost time and memory gaps.
Exceeds Threshold	Catatonic Revelation	The character's mind completely breaks upon perceiving the underlying, terrifying geometry of the universe. Permanent catatonic state. Immediately removed from the campaign.

8.4. Healing Corruption

Because Corruption naturally builds toward lethal levels, characters must actively seek to heal their psychological wounds.

Methods of Recovery

Method	Effect	Requirements
Anchor Scene	Heal 1d4 Corruption	Once per session. Dedicate a scene to interacting with your Anchor.
Full Rest (24 hours)	Heal Corruption equal to Empathy score	Full 24-hour cycle resting in a secure, non-anomalous location (e.g., Covenant HQ).

Method	Effect	Requirements
Healing Talents	Varies by talent	See Division Talents and General Talents marked with <i>(Healing)</i> .

Design note: *Corruption healing is intentionally slow. An agent with Empathy 3 heals 3 Corruption per full day of rest – but gaining 3+ Corruption in a single scene is easy. The economy is deliberately asymmetric: you gain faster than you heal, and the only way to stay safe is to make fewer desperate choices.*

Anchors

Every character begins with an **Anchor** – a tangible, physical object linked to a core humanizing memory (e.g., a cassette tape recording of a lost spouse’s voice). In a moment of quiet downtime, a character can dedicate a scene to interacting with their Anchor. This grounded roleplay provides powerful mechanical healing.

Random 1980s Memento / Anchor Table (Roll d66)

Roll	Memento	Roll	Memento
11	A severely chewed, red Bic pen belonging to a missing sibling.	41	A blood-stained matchbook from a notorious neon-lit nightclub.
12	A Polaroid photograph of a figure that no one else remembers.	42	A high school varsity jacket smelling faintly of cheap cologne and ozone.
13	A mixtape cassette labeled "Do Not Play" in your mother’s handwriting.	43	A digital Casio watch with an alarm set for a time that doesn’t exist.
14	A heavily worn silver Saint Christopher medal on a broken chain.	44	A half-empty bottle of expensive 1970s scotch saved for a special occasion.
15	A dog-eared paperback copy of a pulp sci-fi novel with cryptic margin notes.	45	A pocket-sized, battery-operated arcade game that occasionally glitches.

Roll	Memento	Roll	Memento
16	A tarnished Zippo lighter that sparks with an unnatural blue flame.	46	An unmarked VHS tape containing 15 seconds of deeply unsettling footage.
21	A collection of arcade tokens from a venue that mysteriously burned down.	51	A pair of aviator sunglasses with one cracked lens.
22	A ticket stub from a 1984 rock concert you attended with a dead friend.	52	A Rubik's Cube that you nervously solve and scramble to calm your nerves.
23	A dented police badge belonging to a disgraced former partner.	53	A Walkman with a broken rewind button and a single classical music tape.
24	A crumpled handwritten letter promising a reunion that never happened.	54	A military dog tag from the Vietnam War belonging to your father.
25	A plastic action figure missing its left arm.	55	A crumpled receipt for a pawned wedding ring.
26	A heavy set of brass keys to a property you have never been able to locate.	56	A faded newspaper clipping detailing a tragic "accident."
31	A leather-bound diary with the last fifty pages violently torn out.	61	A cracked makeup compact with a mirror that reflects a younger you.
32	A heavy, gold-plated class ring from a prestigious ivy-league university.	62	A brass compass that occasionally points towards the nearest anomalous entity.
33	A 35mm film canister containing undeveloped negatives you are afraid to process.	63	A faded "Dungeons & Dragons" character sheet from a childhood friend.
34	A switchblade knife with an intricately carved bone handle.	64	A heavy iron coin depicting a two-faced Roman emperor.
35	A woven friendship bracelet that has survived a decade of wear and tear.	65	A battered tin flask containing ash instead of liquor.

Roll	Memento	Roll	Memento
36	A cracked pager that occasionally receives numerical codes from unknown numbers.	66	A pristine, sealed action figure in its original 1980s blister pack.

8.5. Fear Mechanics

The Corruption track governs the long arc of psychological decay. **Fear** governs the acute, in-the-moment terror of direct supernatural confrontation – the thing that happens to your body and your mind in the next thirty seconds when the entity looks at you.

Fear and Corruption are directly linked: Fear checks that produce 1s on the dice generate Corruption, and failed Fear checks generate additional Corruption plus a panic response. A single terrifying encounter can spike Corruption in a way that takes days of rest to undo.

What Triggers a Fear Check

The GM calls for a Fear check when a character directly confronts a source of genuine supernatural horror. Not everything unusual triggers one – strange sounds, unusual smells, or reading an old text do not. A Fear check requires **direct sensory confrontation** with something that violates the natural order.

Trigger	Examples
Encountering a supernatural entity	Seeing a bound entity, a possessed human, or a manifestation for the first time this scene
Artifact activation failure	An artifact the character is handling detonates, tears reality, or emits a vision that cannot be explained
Witnessing violent supernatural death	An ally or bystander is killed or consumed by occult means in front of the character
Occult revelation	Irrefutable proof of something the human mind cannot accommodate – a genuine miracle, an impossible geometry, a speaking dead
Sustained entity presence	For each additional round a character remains within Engaged range of an active, hostile entity (after the initial check)

One check per trigger: *If the same entity is already known to the character from a prior session and has been observed before, no new Fear check is required merely for seeing it again – only for new escalations (it doing something new, getting closer, attacking).*

The Fear Check Procedure

1. The GM calls for a Fear check when a character directly confronts supernatural horror.
2. Roll dice equal to your current **Wits** attribute (no skill modifier – Fear is instinctual, not trained).
3. **One or more 6s = success.** You hold it together.
4. **Any 1s rolled (one or more) = +1 Corruption.** Only one Corruption regardless of how many 1s. This applies whether the check succeeded or failed.
5. **No 6s = failure.** Gain +1 Corruption AND roll d6 on the **Panic Table**.

Fear checks **cannot be pushed**. Fear is involuntary – there is no "trying harder" against the absolute horror of the unnatural.

Four Outcomes

Rolled 6s?	Rolled 1s?	Result
Yes	No	Clean pass. No consequence.
Yes	Yes	Pass, but +1 Corruption. The exposure marks you.
No	No	Fail. +1 Corruption + Panic Table.
No	Yes	Worst case. +1 Corruption (from 1s) + 1 Corruption (from failure) = +2 Corruption + Panic Table.

Why Wits? *Fear strikes the rational, pattern-recognizing mind first. The brain tries to **explain** what the eyes are seeing – and fails. Empathy governs emotional horror (grief, bargaining, despair); that comes later, through the Corruption track.*

The Panic Table

On a failed Fear check (no 6s), roll **d6**:

Roll	Response	What Happens
1	Fight	Attack nearest creature (ally or foe) with bare hands this round. Cannot use weapons.
2	Flight	Run at full speed away from the source. Drop held items.
3	Freeze	Paralyzed. Cannot move, speak, or act. Allies can move you (Slow Action).
4	Denial	Treat the supernatural as mundane for rest of scene. Cannot acknowledge entity as real.
5	Compulsion	Locked in repetitive behavior. Cannot take meaningful action until ally Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2).
6	Fugue	GM takes character sheet. GM narrates character for rest of scene. Player regains control next scene.

Fear Ratings

Fear Rating is a **narrative tool** for the GM – it classifies how terrifying a creature or event is on a 1–5 scale and appears in Bestiary stat blocks. It does **not** mechanically modify the Fear check roll. The GM uses it to decide **when** to call for a check and how to frame the fiction.

Rating	Threat Level	Examples
1	Unsettling	A shadow that moves wrong. A sound that shouldn't exist. A photograph with an extra figure.
2	Disturbing	A possessed civilian. A minor entity (shadow-form, bound spirit). A fresh, inexplicably ritualistic death scene.
3	Horrifying	A mid-tier entity fully manifested. An artifact consuming a living person. A Covenant vault breach in progress.
4	Shattering	A major entity (ancient, named, deliberate). An artifact performing an impossible act of scale (restructuring a room, erasing a person).

Rating	Threat Level	Examples
5	Annihilating	A Class-5 entity. A tear in physical space. Direct contact with whatever the artifacts are for .

Fear Ratings are a property of supernatural **entities** and **events**, not of individual characters. Add the Fear Rating stat to entity stat blocks in the Bestiary ([docs/chapters/19-bestiary.adoc](#)).



CLASSIFIED

PART IV – THE WORLD OF NEON RELIC

Classification: Secret – Clearance Level 2+ Required
Distribution: Restricted – Need-to-Know Basis

CHAPTER 9. COVENANT DIVISIONS AND DEPARTMENTS

In Project Neon Relic, players are sworn members of **The Verdant Covenant**. Because no single person possesses the brains, brawn, network, and magical guardianship required to hunt dangerous artifacts, players choose a **Division** (their core class) which dictates their starting attributes, skills, and Clearance Level (CL).

Within that Division, players select a **Department** background. During creation, they may select one of the 5 unique **Division Talents**. These Talents operate similarly to magic systems – they guarantee a supernatural or highly specialized effect but cost +1 Corruption to activate, feeding directly into the game’s risk-reward loop.

9.1. Division 1: The Wayfinder

"What is found must be known."

The Wayfinder Division serves as the primary investigative arm of the Covenant. Wayfinders are scholars, hackers, and researchers whose directive is uncovering the existence and historical locations of lost artifacts before rival factions do. They work to assemble and preserve knowledge from historical records, archaeological reports, religious texts, folklore, academic publications, government archives, museum collections, and contemporary news reporting.

Wayfinder Key Stats

Key Attributes	Wits, Empathy
Favorite Attribute	Wits
Key Skills	Investigate, Lore, Tech, Psychoanalyze
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Lore
Starting Clearance Level	3

The Verdant Codex (Division Item)

All Wayfinders bear the **Verdant Codex**, an enchanted field journal for recording discoveries. The Codex provides the following benefits:

- Writing in the Codex secures knowledge in the memory of the author
- Maintains historical records in an organized and cataloged fashion

- Assists in decoding languages and symbols
- Automatically preserves documents placed within its pages
- Stores large scrolls without damage
- Faintly glows near ancient magic
- Contains a living map lining that slowly reveals artifact locations

Wayfinder Departments

Department of Research

The Department of Research is responsible for the discovery, documentation, and verification of artifacts. Research personnel identify artifacts before they are lost, misused, or fall into the possession of hostile actors.

- **Research Desk Analyst** – Focuses on research within Covenant archives and partner repositories. Studies historical documents, translates ancient texts, analyzes cultural and religious records, and monitors scholarly publications. Desk Analysts maintain artifact catalogues, cross-reference historical reports, and identify patterns indicating the presence of significant artifacts.
- **Research Field Analyst** – Conducts investigative work outside Covenant facilities. Visits archaeological sites, examines ruins, conducts interviews with scholars or local witnesses, and verifies Desk Analyst intelligence. Gathers firsthand observations, photographic documentation, and environmental intelligence.



Research personnel do not retrieve artifacts. Once an artifact's existence and location have been confirmed, the Department prepares a formal assessment and forwards the case to the Recovery Division.

Department of Counterintelligence

The Department of Counterintelligence protects the Covenant from external threats and preserves the secrecy of the organization's existence, operations, and holdings. The Department maintains continuous surveillance of known and emerging groups with an interest in relic acquisition, including rival secret societies, criminal networks, illicit antiquities traffickers, extremist religious movements, and private collectors.

- **Counterintelligence Desk Analyst** – Monitors global communications, public records, academic publications, and intelligence reports for indications that artifacts have been discovered, trafficked, or targeted. Maintains profiles of known rival organizations, tracks patterns of artifact-related activity, and compiles threat analyses.

- **Counterintelligence Field Analyst** – Operates outside Covenant facilities to investigate threats directly. Duties include surveillance of suspicious organizations, infiltration of groups seeking artifacts, observation of illicit antiquities markets, and disruption of activities that could expose the Covenant. Field Analysts may be authorized to engage hostiles, albeit infrequently.



Through the vigilance of the Department of Counterintelligence, the Covenant ensures that what is known remains contained, and that those who would misuse the past are stopped before they can act.

Wayfinder Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
The Antiquarian's Eye	+1 Corruption	Instantly identify an artifact's primary activation trigger and base effect without a Lore roll.
Ghost in the Machine	+1 Corruption	Use Tech to directly interface with electronic devices jammed or possessed by anomalous entities.
The Hunch	+1 Corruption	Ask the GM one yes/no question about a crime scene or NPC's motive. The GM must answer truthfully.
Academic Grounding (Healing)	–	Spend an hour researching an entity and framing it in academic terms. Heal 1 Corruption for yourself or one ally.
Eldritch Empathy	+1 Corruption	Sense the immediate emotional state, hunger, or primary intent of an invisible or disguised supernatural entity.

9.2. Division 2: The Recovery

"What is known must be contained."

The Recovery Division serves as the field arm of the Verdant Covenant. Where the Wayfinders uncover knowledge and the Keep guards what has already been secured, the Recovery Division is responsible for bringing artifacts safely into Covenant custody.

Recovery agents operate in the world beyond the Covenant's halls, traveling wherever relics are rumored to exist. They investigate ruins, ancient vaults, forgotten temples, private collections, corporate archives, black markets, and the

holdings of religious or political institutions. Their mandate is simple and absolute: **recover the object and return it to the Covenant.**

Recovery agents are trained to operate in a wide variety of environments. Some recover artifacts from abandoned ruins and dangerous landscapes. Others negotiate with collectors, institutions, or governments. At times, they must retrieve relics from those who knowingly misuse them or seek to exploit their power. Characters here often come from military or law enforcement backgrounds.



Unlike other Divisions, the Recovery Division has **no internal departments or specializations**. Every member shares the same purpose and authority. Instead, agents are distinguished by their **operational background**.

Recovery Key Stats

Key Attributes	Strength, Agility
Favorite Attribute	Agility
Key Skills	Force, Brawl, Firearms, Sneak
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Firearms
Starting Clearance Level	2

The Verdant Satchel (Division Item)

All Recovery agents carry the **Verdant Satchel**, a specially enchanted field bag designed to safely transport relics. The Satchel provides the following benefits:

- Suppresses the magical aura of items placed inside
- Warns when nearby artifacts become unstable
- Allows temporary sealing of cursed items
- Contains a small dimensional containment compartment
- Produces useful tools on demand (rope, chalk, spikes, vials, etc.)
- Enchantment of Warding obscures any magical object placed inside from detection

Recovery Backgrounds

Choose one background that defines your agent’s prior experience:

Background	Description
Ex-Agency Operative	Former intelligence or special forces. Trained in infiltration, extraction, and covert operations.
Heavy-Hitter (Brawler)	Brute-force specialist. Comfortable in direct violent confrontation above all else.
Acquisition Specialist (Thief)	Expert in bypassing security, stealing valuable objects, and getting in and out unseen.

Recovery Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Conditioned Mind	–	Once per session, entirely ignore the Corruption point generated from pushing a roll.
Unstoppable Force	+1 Corruption	Your next successful melee or unarmed attack inflicts +2 damage.
Shadow Walker	+1 Corruption	Become entirely imperceptible to mundane guards or cameras for a scene, provided you do not attack.
Adrenaline Junkie	–	When you have a –1 penalty to Strength, gain +2 bonus dice to all Agility rolls.
Gallows Humor (Healing)	–	Once per session, after surviving a combat encounter, crack a dark joke. You and all allies who hear you heal 1d4 Corruption.

9.3. Division 3: The Keep

"What is contained must be guarded."

The Keep serves as the custodial authority of the Verdant Covenant. Once artifacts have been recovered and delivered to Covenant custody, responsibility for their handling, documentation, containment, and protection is transferred to the Keep.

Members of the Keep are entrusted with the stewardship of the Covenant's most sensitive holdings. Their work ensures that artifacts – whether magical, religious, occult, or culturally significant – are properly cataloged, secured, and prevented from causing harm.

Keep Key Stats

Key Attributes	Empathy, Wits
Favorite Attribute	Empathy
Key Skills	Lore, Command, Endure, Heal
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Command
Starting Clearance Level	3

The Warden's Bracer (Division Item)

All Keepers wear the **Warden's Bracer**, marking them as guardians of the Covenant's vaults. The Bracer symbolizes that the Keeper is bound to guard what others must never wield. It provides the following benefits:

- Suppresses artifact magic in close proximity
- Warns the wearer if containment fails
- Allows safe handling of cursed objects
- Absorbs Corruption (soaks 1 Corruption per session)
- Grants **+1 to Armor Rating**

*Keep Departments***The Department of Catalogers**

The Catalogers are responsible for the documentation, classification, and containment planning of all artifacts. Every item recovered by the Recovery Division is delivered first to the Catalogers for formal intake. They maintain the Covenant's master artifact registry – detailing origin, cultural context, physical properties, historical significance, and known risks for each artifact in custody.

The Department also designs containment chambers tailored to each artifact's characteristics: sealed vaults, protective casings, environmental stabilization systems, isolation chambers, or other specialized safeguards. Catalogers conduct periodic inspections to verify that artifacts remain secure and containment measures remain effective.

The Wardens

The Wardens serve as the defensive arm of the Keep. They are responsible for the physical protection of Covenant facilities, personnel, and artifact vaults. Primary

duties include:

- Guarding headquarters, satellite facilities, and vault complexes
- Enforcing access protocols and escorting authorized personnel through sensitive areas
- Responding to security incidents
- Coordinating with Counterintelligence on infiltration threats
- Conducting field operations to disrupt hostile activities or recover stolen property when credible threats emerge



Through the actions of the Wardens, the Verdant Covenant ensures that what is contained remains guarded, and that those who would misuse the relics of the past are prevented from doing so.

Internal Counterintelligence

Working in coordination with the Wayfinder Division's Department of Counterintelligence, Internal CI agents investigate individuals or groups seeking to infiltrate the Covenant, steal artifacts, or expose the organization. They safeguard the Covenant's secrecy by identifying information leaks, preventing public exposure of operations, and ensuring that knowledge of sensitive artifacts remains tightly controlled.

Keep Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Containment Protocol	+1 Corruption	Quickly improvise a ward using mundane materials (salt, copper wire). Any supernatural entity must make a Hard (-2) roll to cross it.
Shield of the Covenant	+1 Corruption	When an ally within Engaged range is attacked, automatically step in front of the blow. Take the damage but halve its severity.
The Inquisitor's Gaze	+1 Corruption	While conversing with someone, instantly know their current Corruption score and whether they are possessed.
Sanctuary Master	—	When inside Covenant HQ, automatically succeed on any Wits (Lore) roll regarding the history of a contained artifact.

Talent	Cost	Effect
The Confessor (Healing)	–	Spend a quiet moment listening to an ally confess their Dark Secret. Both you and the ally heal 1d4 Corruption .

9.4. Division 4: Stack (Logistics)

"Queue up, agents."

The Department of Logistics sits organizationally within the Keep, but its unique expertise and operational independence justify its treatment as a separate playable Division. Informally known as "**Stack**," the department is composed of technicians, quartermasters, archivists of equipment, engineers, and inventors who maintain the Covenant's stores of specialized gear.



Origin of the name: During the global espionage boom of the 1970s, younger Recovery agents began jokingly referring to Logistics as the "Q Department," a nod to the famous James Bond armorer. Given the notoriously long requisition lines outside the Logistics offices, the nickname evolved into "Queue." Over time, Covenant humor shortened it further, and the department became known as **Stack** – a name that has endured ever since.

Stack agents design, modify, and distribute the tools used by Covenant agents – from standard field supplies to experimental devices developed specifically for artifact recovery and containment. Though rarely leaving Covenant facilities themselves, Stack agents ensure that when Recovery teams enter the field, they do so properly equipped for whatever dangers await.

Stack Key Stats

Key Attributes	Wits, Agility
Favorite Attribute	Wits
Key Skills	Tech, Sleight of Hand, Investigate, Craft (<i>specialized sub-skill for building/repairing gear</i>)
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Tech
Starting Clearance Level	4

Stack Departments

Department	Description
The Quartermaster	Manages the Covenant's equipment stores. Expert in acquisition, logistics, and knowing exactly what's available.
The Retro-Engineer	Specializes in modifying and repairing existing technology. Can coax impossible performance from aging hardware.
The Paratech Inventor	Designs entirely new experimental devices that blend analog technology with paranatural principles.

Stack Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Requisition Expert	+1 Corruption	During the Equipping Phase, automatically acquire any one non-artifact item, bypassing the CL roll entirely.
Jury-Rig	+1 Corruption	Immediately restore a broken or degraded piece of gear to maximum bonus during combat or a high-tension scene.
Prototyper	+1 Corruption	Grant a piece of mundane gear an Artifact Die (d8) for a single skill roll. The item is permanently destroyed immediately after.
Duct Tape & WD-40 (Healing)	–	Spend a Shift at base tinkering. Automatically repair all degraded gear for the entire party without a roll, and heal 1 Corruption.
Experimental Shielding	+1 Corruption	Once per session, completely ignore the degradation penalty of rolling a 1 on a Gear Die.

CHAPTER 10. 1980S EQUIPMENT AND ANALOG GEAR

Navigating the neon-lit streets and abandoned industrial sectors of the 1980s requires specialized equipment. Items provide a **Gear Bonus** (extra black d6 dice) to specific skill rolls. Pushing a roll can cause the item to break, temporarily reducing its bonus.

To reflect the covert nature of the Covenant, characters do not use personal cash. Instead, they utilize their **Clearance Level (CL)** during the Equipping Phase to requisition supplies from Stack. Items are categorized by their required CL.

10.1. Investigative & Paranormal Tech

Item	Gear Bonus & Effect	Enc.	CL
Heavy-Duty Maglite	+1 to Investigate/Scout in the dark. Can act as blunt weapon (Damage 1).	½	1
Micro-Cassette Recorder	+1 to Psychoanalyze. Captures EVPs (Electronic Voice Phenomena).	½	1
Polaroid SX-70 Camera	+2 to Lore when studying a crime scene. Produces instant evidence.	1	2
Air Ion Counter	+1 to Investigate. Bulky spirit detector measuring static drops.	1	2
Acoustic Coupler Modem	+1 to Tech. Interface with remote mainframes via payphone.	1	2
P-SB7 Spirit Box Prototype	+2 to Lore when deciphering entity motives. Sweeps radio frequencies.	1	3
Thermal / Infrared Camera	+2 to Scout. Heavy early-80s tech. Spot invisible entities via cold spots.	2	4

10.2. Standard Tools & Survival Gear

Item	Gear Bonus & Effect	Enc.	CL
Basic First Aid Kit	+1 to Heal. Bandages, antiseptics, painkillers.	1	1

Item	Gear Bonus & Effect	Enc.	CL
Lockpick Kit	+2 to Sleight of Hand when bypassing mechanical locks.	½	2
Crowbar / Bolt Cutters	+2 to Force when breaking through chains or sealed doors.	1	2
Long-Range Walkie-Talkies	Communication over a few miles (no supernatural interference).	½	2
Trauma Surgical Kit	+3 to Heal. Sutures, adrenaline, blood-clotting agents.	2	3

10.3. 1980s Weaponry

Weapons provide a Gear Bonus (added to Firearms or Brawl) and a flat Damage rating. All mundane weapons deal **Physical (STR)** damage unless noted otherwise.

Weapon	Gear Bonus	Damage	Type	Range	Special Traits	CL
Brass Knuckles	+1	1	Physical (STR)	Engaged	Concealable.	1
Switchblade	+1	2	Physical (STR)	Engaged	Concealable; puncture criticals.	1
Stun Gun / Taser	+2	Stun	Physical (STR)	Engaged	Target loses their next Slow Action (stunned).	2
.38 Snub-nose Revolver	+2	2	Physical (STR)	Short	Reliable – ignore first 1 when pushing.	2
9mm Semi-Auto Pistol	+2	2	Physical (STR)	Short	High capacity; split successes to hit multiple targets.	3
Pump-Action Shotgun	+3	3	Physical (STR)	Short	+1 Damage at Engaged range. Loud and bulky.	3
M16 Assault Rifle	+2	3	Physical (STR)	Long	Full auto – can push twice, consumes extra ammo.	4

10.4. Armor

Armor	Rating	Special	CL
Concealed Kevlar Vest	3	Wearer passes as civilian at distance.	3
Tactical Riot Armor	6	Bulky; -2 penalty to Agility rolls.	4

10.5. Consumables and Resource Dice

Consumable supplies – ammunition, medical gear, batteries, and rations – are tracked with **Resource Dice**. A Resource Die is a single die (d4, d6, d8, d10, or d12) that represents how much of a supply remains. Larger dice mean more supply. When supply runs low, the die steps down.

How Resource Dice Work

When to roll: After each scene in which a consumable is meaningfully used – not for every bullet fired, but for every fight involving firearms, every Heal action using a medical kit, every device run on battery power for an extended period.

The roll: Roll the current Resource Die:

- **Result 1-2:** Supply is diminishing. **Step the die down one size** (d12-d10-d8-d6-d4).
- **Result 3+:** Supply is adequate. No change.

At d4, a result of 1-2: The supply is **depleted**. Remove the resource from the character's gear. The activity is completed (if mid-scene), but no more uses remain.

Die	Supply Level
d12	Fully stocked – fresh from Stack.
d10	Well supplied – no concerns yet.
d8	Adequate – a couple of heavy uses left.
d6	Running low – ration carefully.
d4	Critical – final uses. Do not count on it.

Die	Supply Level
Depleted	Gone. Cannot be used.

Restocking

Supplies can be restocked:

- During the **Equipping Phase** (Phase 3 of each Case File): any supply can be restocked to its starting die size at no cost (subject to CL restrictions).
- During a **Case File**, at a credible source: a hospital supply room, a hardware store, an abandoned military cache. The GM determines availability; resupply takes time and may require a Tech or Sleight of Hand roll (Difficulty 1-2) to access without authorization.
- **HQ Underground Field Medic** (Personnel): once per Case File, restocks any medical supply to d8 automatically.

Supply Categories

Supply	Starting Die	CL	Notes
Pistol Ammunition (.38, 9mm)	d10	2	Roll after any firefight. Full auto or suppressive fire: roll twice.
Shotgun Shells	d8	3	Roll after any firefight. Pump-action: each shot is a meaningful use.
Rifle Rounds (M16, .308)	d8	4	Roll after any firefight. Full auto or suppressive fire: roll twice.
Basic First Aid Kit	d10	1	Roll after each Heal roll that consumes supplies (bandages, antiseptic, splints). Does not roll for passive access checks.
Trauma Surgical Kit	d8	3	Roll after each surgical Heal action (treating Critical Injuries, field surgery). High consumption.

Supply	Starting Die	CL	Notes
Battery Pack (general electronics)	d8	1	Roll after each scene in which an electronic device (flashlight, radio, recording device) is used continuously for more than 30 minutes. Devices operated briefly do not trigger a roll.
Specialized Battery (thermal camera, IR devices)	d6	3	These batteries are expensive, proprietary, and hard to replace in the field. Roll after each scene of active use.
Field Rations	d8	1	Only tracked on extended journeys (overnight+) or during prolonged operations without a hot meal. Roll once per day in the field. Not required for standard Case Files.
Artifact Components (optional)	d6	–	Ritual components, containment salts, reactive chemicals. Roll after each artifact interaction requiring preparation materials. GM may waive this for simple artifact containment.

Ammo in combat: *The combat chapter tracks ammunition with an Ammo Resource Die by weapon class (see docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc). The values there override these defaults for in-combat rolls. The values above apply to **scene-level** tracking – they are rolled at the end of a fight, not per shot.*

Scarcity in the 1980s Field

In the 1980s, certain supplies are significantly harder to replace in the field:

- **Specialized batteries** (lithium, proprietary formats for early specialist equipment) may not be available at the nearest grocery store – a Tech roll (Difficulty 2) to substitute or a Contact call to track one down.
- **Trauma medical supplies** require pharmacy or hospital access – risky in circumstances where the team is operating off the books.

- **Rifle ammunition** requires a gun shop or military supply – not every rural area has one, and a city purchase is traceable.

The GM should use scarcity as an atmospheric element, not a mechanical trap. Resource depletion should create pressure and decision points, not dead ends.

10.6. Encumbrance

Every agent can carry a limited amount of gear before it slows them down. Encumbrance (**Enc.**) is listed for each item in the equipment tables above.

Encumbrance Scale

Enc.	Examples
½	Small concealable items: a pocket recorder, lockpick kit, walkie-talkie.
1	Standard field gear: first aid kit, camera, crowbar, pistol.
2	Heavy or bulky gear: trauma surgical kit, thermal camera, shotgun.
3+	Oversized or special items: heavy weapons, large artifact containment cases.

Carry Capacity

An agent's carry capacity is **Strength × 2** Enc. points.

Wearing armor adds its CL to your total Enc. (Concealed Kevlar = +1; Tactical Riot Armor = +2).

Encumbered

If your total Enc. exceeds your carry capacity, you are **Encumbered**:

- -1 die on all Strength and Agility rolls.
- Moving to a new zone costs a **Slow Action** instead of a Fast Action.

You remain Encumbered until your load drops back within capacity – drop gear, stash it in the car, or pass it to a teammate.

Overloaded

If your Enc. exceeds **Strength × 3**, you are **Overloaded**:

- You **cannot move to a different zone** at all.
- At the GM's discretion, you cannot take Fast Actions for movement.
- You must drop excess gear before you can move.

Overloaded is a hard stop. You simply cannot move until weight is reduced.

Clearance Levels (CL) and Requisition

Every item lists a **Clearance Level (CL)** requirement. Agents requisition gear during the **Equipping Phase** between Case Files through their Division's Stack contact. Your character's current CL determines which items you can request:

CL	Who Can Access
1	All agents – basic field supplies.
2	Agents with at least one completed Case File, or Division default.
3	Agents with field commendations or specific Division clearance.
4	Senior agents and Warden rank – restricted hardware and experimental tech.

Clearance is a **narrative resource** – the GM may escalate or revoke access based on the agent's standing with the Covenant (see Division Standing rules).

10.7. Vehicle Rules

Vehicles are field assets – tools to get there, get away, and occasionally get between a colleague and a bullet. They are not invulnerable, and the 1980s makes every breakdown feel earned.

Vehicle Stat Block Format

Each vehicle has five stats:

- **Speed:** A relative rating – Slow, Medium, Fast, or Very Fast. Sets the Difficulty

modifier on chase pursuit rolls (see Chase Rules below).

- **Armor Rating (AR):** Damage reduction against attacks targeting the vehicle directly (ramming, gunfire). Characters inside an armored vehicle use the vehicle's AR in place of worn armor while they remain inside.
- **Reliability:** Starting Wear track (Max 5). Each instance of vehicle damage or a pushed vehicle roll adds 1 Wear. At 3 Wear: -1 die on all vehicle rolls. At 5 Wear: the vehicle stops.
- **Handling:** A bonus or penalty applied to all pursuit and evasion rolls (Wits or Agility depending on maneuver type). Represents how nimble the vehicle is.
- **Capacity:** Number of occupants (passengers + driver) and approximate cargo Enc.

1980s Vehicle Roster

Vehicle	Speed	AR	Reliability	Handling	Capacity & Notes
Ford Crown Victoria (Government Sedan)	Medium	1	5	+0	4 passengers, 25 Enc. Inconspicuous government plate – blends at police scenes. Standard Covenant pool car.
Chevrolet Caprice Classic (Full-Size Sedan)	Medium	1	5	+0	4 passengers, 25 Enc. Common, forgettable. The correct answer to most field transport needs.
Dodge Van / Econoline (Panel Van)	Medium	1	4	-1	6 passengers, 50 Enc. Roomy but noticeable. Residential areas trigger 1 Investigate check from neighbors. Good for equipment transport.

Vehicle	Speed	AR	Reliability	Handling	Capacity & Notes
Ford F-150 (Pickup Truck)	Medium	0	5	+0	2 cab + bed (40 Enc.). Rural credibility. Bed cargo visible. Excellent in unpaved terrain – no Difficulty penalty off-road.
Ducati 900 SS Motorcycle (or equivalent)	Fast	0	3	+2	1 rider, 10 Enc. Best pursuit vehicle in urban terrain. -2 dice in rain or snow. Rider is exposed – no AR benefit from the vehicle.
Chevrolet Camaro Z28 (Muscle Car)	Fast	0	4	+1	2 passengers, 10 Enc. Fast in a straight line. -1 die on tight-turn pursuit rolls. Loud and memorable – witnesses notice it.
UH-1 Iroquois Helicopter ("Huey")	Very Fast	2	3	-1	8 passengers, 30 Enc. Conspicuous, loud, and expensive. Requires a Contact or CL 4 requisition. Cannot land on most urban rooftops safely.
Cessna 172 (Light Prop Plane)	Very Fast	0	4	-1	3 passengers (cramped), 15 Enc. For long-distance intercontinental rapid response only. Requires a licensed pilot (NPC contact or PC with Tech 3+).

Vehicle	Speed	AR	Reliability	Handling	Capacity & Notes
Zodiac Inflatable Boat (Motorized)	Medium	0	4	+0	4 passengers, 40 Enc. Coastal/river access. Cannot be followed by road vehicles. Night operations: -1 die on all navigation rolls without instruments.

Vehicle Conflict – Actions and Chase Rules

Vehicle conflict follows the same chase structure as foot chases ([docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc](#)), with vehicle-specific modifications.

Chase Structure

A vehicle chase uses a **Contact Track** – a 5-step range:

Position	State
1	Rammed / Contact – vehicles are adjacent; ramming and boarding are possible.
2	Following – pursuing vehicle is directly behind; gunfire from rear positions is possible.
3	Closing – pursuit is active; the gap is narrowing or holding.
4	Widening – the pursued vehicle has gained distance; gunfire at Long range only.
5	Escaped – the pursuer has lost visual contact. Chase ends.

The **pursued vehicle** wins by moving to position 5. The **pursuing vehicle** wins by moving to or holding position 1-2.

Chase Roll

Each round of a chase, both drivers make a roll:

- **Driving (WIT):** The primary chase skill. Represents reading traffic, anticipating routes, and making calculated maneuvers.

- **Evasion (AGI):** Used when attempting sudden unpredictable movement – cutting through a building site, reversing against traffic, going off-road. Higher risk, higher reward.

Both sides roll simultaneously. The side with more successes moves the Contact Track one position in their favor. Ties: no position change.

Speed modifiers:

- Each speed tier above the opponent's: +1 die on the chase roll.
- Each speed tier below the opponent's: -1 die on the chase roll.
- Handling bonus/penalty applies directly to the roll.

Pushing a chase roll: +1 Corruption as normal. The vehicle also takes 1 Wear immediately (the driver is wringing everything out of it).

Vehicle Maneuvers

Declare before rolling. No cost unless noted.

Maneuver	Skill	Effect
Ram	Force (WIT)	Only available at Contact. Roll Force opposed by opponent's Driving. On success: both vehicles take 1-3 damage (equal to Force successes); Contact Track does not change; occupants of both vehicles take 1 Agility damage (thrown around). Cannot ram a vehicle more than two speed tiers faster.
PIT Maneuver	Driving (WIT) Difficulty 3	Available at Contact only. On success: target vehicle spins – they lose their next action and the pursuer moves to Contact. On failure: the maneuvering driver's vehicle takes 1 Wear.
Gunfire from Vehicle	Firearms (standard roll)	Available at Following or closer. -1 die on all shooting rolls from a moving vehicle unless the shooter has the Stable Platform talent. A passenger shooting from a moving car is at -1 die; a driver shooting is at -2 dice.

Maneuver	Skill	Effect
Off-Road Break	AGI Difficulty 2	Drive off the paved route. On success: move one position on the Contact Track toward Escaped. On failure: vehicle takes 1 Wear and no position change. If in a vehicle with off-road penalty (Motorcycle in rain, Van, Helicopter equivalent): add +1 Difficulty.
Blending In	WIT (Sneak) Difficulty 2	Abandon the direct chase and disappear into traffic or terrain. On success: move directly to Escaped (skip the track). On failure: no change and opponent moves one step toward Contact.

Vehicle Damage

When a vehicle takes damage (from ramming, gunfire, or environmental hazard):

1. Roll damage as normal. Subtract the vehicle's AR.
2. Remaining damage is applied as **Wear** (not as Strength damage to occupants, unless the damage is extraordinary).
3. At 5 Wear: vehicle stops. Characters inside may take 1 Agility damage from the sudden stop (Endure Difficulty 1 to avoid).
4. **Structural damage:** At GM discretion, a catastrophic hit (4+ damage after AR) may cause a specific system failure: blown tire (–2 die Handling), cracked windscreen (blindness penalties for driver), fuel leak (vehicle stops at end of scene unless repaired).

Repairing Wear:

- Tech roll (Difficulty 2) + 30 minutes + access to tools: clear 1 Wear.
- Full garage repairs (overnight, proper tools): restore to starting Reliability.
- Field repairs without tools: Tech Difficulty 4, clears 1 Wear, cannot reduce below 3.

Vehicle Breakdown

When Reliability reaches 5 Wear, the vehicle stops. Roll d6:

Roll	Breakdown Type
1-2	Total Failure. Engine seized. Not repairable in the field. Needs a tow and a full day of garage work (restore to 2 Wear, 4 hours minimum).
3-4	Serious Fault. Driveable at Slow speed only. Tech (Difficulty 3) to clear in field; otherwise full garage repair.
5-6	Inconvenient Failure. Battery, tire, or small component. Tech (Difficulty 1) to address in 15 minutes. 1 Wear remains after fix.

A breakdown during an active chase is resolved immediately: the broken-down vehicle is treated as **Contact** on the next round (the pursuer closes automatically).

10.8. Crafting and Repair

Gear breaks. In the 1980s, that means hunting down parts, improvising solutions, and relying on whoever in your cell knows which end of a soldering iron is hot. Stack Division agents are the backbone of field readiness – but any experienced agent can manage a field fix if the situation demands it.

Gear Degradation Recap

Every piece of equipment with a **Gear Die** risks degradation when that die rolls a **1**. Gear degrades one step down the die chain (d12 → d10 → d8 → d6 → d4 → Broken). A **Broken** item cannot be used until repaired.

*Stack Division Talent **Jury-Rig** can restore a broken item mid-scene at the cost of +1 Corruption. Formal repair rules below handle everything else.*

Repair Rules

Repairing gear requires **time**, **parts**, and a **Craft** roll.

The Repair Roll

Attribute	Wits (WIT)
Skill	Craft (<i>Stack signature skill</i>)
Base Difficulty	Varies by condition (see table below)
Time Required	Varies (see table below)
Tools Required	Basic toolkit (most repairs); specialized kit for electronics/artifacts

Condition	Gear Die	Repair Diff	Time Required
Degraded (d10-d4)	Any step below max	1	Quick Repair: 15 minutes (1 scene)
Broken (non-electronic)	–	2	Full Repair: 1 Shift (~4 hours)
Broken (electronic/mechanical)	–	3	Full Repair: 1 Shift; requires Power Tools
Combat-Damaged Vehicle	Reliability die	3	Full Day; requires Auto Repair kit
Artifact-Adjacent Damage	–	4	Requires Occult Lab or Wayfinder consult

Success: Each success restores the Gear Die one step (up to its maximum). A single Quick Repair roll can only ever restore to the step **above** Broken – a Broken item must be fully repaired before it can be used again.

Failure: The repair attempt fails but does not make things worse. **Complication (Pushed roll only):** A pushed Repair roll that fails delivers a Complication roll on the [Breakdown Table](#).

Parts Requirements

Every repair requires at minimum a **Junk Die** (d6 Resource Die representing scavenged or on-hand parts). Roll the Junk Die after completing repairs:

- **3+:** Parts hold; no step-down.

- **1-2:** Parts ran short; step the Junk Die down one.
- **Junk Die Exhausted:** No spare parts of that type remain. Acquire more (see [Component Sourcing](#)).

Parts Category	Resource Die	Used For
Junk / Scrap	d6	Field repairs, improvised items, basic mechanical fixes
Hardware Components	d8	Electronics, communications gear, vehicle parts
Medical Supplies	d10	See Resource Dice table in Consumables section
Specialized Parts	d6	High-tech, rare, or artifact-adjacent repairs only – not scavengeable
Covenant Cache Parts	d12	HQ-supplied; best quality; no acquisition roll needed

Component Sourcing

Not everything is sitting in a Covenant armory. Field agents must scavenge, requisition, or improvise.

Scavenging

When in a setting that plausibly contains usable materials (hardware store, junkyard, abandoned building, mechanic’s garage), an agent may spend a **Slow Action** or **Free Move** to scavenge. Roll **Investigate** (WIT), Diff 1.

- **Success:** Find d6 uses worth of Junk/Scrap (or roll on Scavenge table below).
- **Extra Successes (2+):** Upgrade the find to Hardware Components instead of Junk.

Scavenge Location	Typical Find (d6)
Hardware / Home Improvement Store	1-3: Junk; 4-5: Hardware Components; 6: Power Tools (counts as Specialized Parts)
Auto Repair Shop / Junkyard	1-2: Junk; 3-5: Hardware Components; 6: Vehicle-rated Specialized Parts

Scavenge Location	Typical Find (d6)
Office Building / University	1-3: Junk; 4-5: Electronics (Hardware Components); 6: Lab-grade Specialized Parts
Abandoned Farmhouse / Rural Site	1-4: Junk; 5: Hardware Components; 6: Firearms Parts (Hardware Components)
Government / Military Facility	1: Junk; 2-4: Hardware Components; 5-6: Specialized Parts
Active Household	1-5: Junk only; 6: Hardware Components (medical kit, power tools)

HQ Requisition

Any non-scavengeable part (Specialized Parts, Covenant Cache Parts) requires a Covenant requisition. Use the standard CL system (see [\[requisitioning-gear\]](#)). Specialized Parts have CL 3. Covenant Cache Parts are CL 4+ and require approval from the Keep.

Stack Advantage: Stack Division agents treat Specialized Parts as CL 2 when requisitioning (their workshop connections reduce red tape).

Improvised Items

When time is short and a proper tool isn't available, agents can construct improvised weapons and tools from scavenged materials. Improvised items function at reduced effectiveness and carry a higher risk of failure.

Crafting Improvised Items

Roll **Craft** (WIT), using the difficulty from the table below. Requires at minimum a **Junk Die (d6)** as parts; step it down after crafting.

Improvised items begin with a **d8 Gear Die** (never start at d10 or d12 – they're held together with duct tape and prayer).

Improvised Item	Craft Diff	Time	Notes
Club / Makeshift Bludgeon	1	1 minute	Damage 1, Slow. No Gear Die – it's a pipe.

Improvised Item	Craft Diff	Time	Notes
Shiv / Field Knife	1	5 minutes	Damage 1, Fast. Gear d8. Breaks on 1-2.
Molotov Cocktail	1	10 minutes	Blast 1, Fire. No Gear Die – single use.
Improvised First Aid Kit	2	20 minutes	Functions as Basic First Aid (d8). Gear d8.
Signal Jammer	2	1 hour	Blocks comms in zone. Gear d8. Electronics.
Tripwire / Alarm Trap	2	30 minutes	Spend; triggers on intruder entry. Single use.
Garrote Wire	1	5 minutes	Grapple-linked attack. No Gear Die – simple tool.
Lockpick Set (crude)	3	1 hour	Sleight of Hand -1 die compared to proper picks.
Improvised Bug Detector	3	2 hours	Detect surveillance; -1 die vs. professional gear.
Field Radio Booster	3	2 hours	Extend comms range by 1 zone. Gear d8. Electronics.

*Improvised items cannot be upgraded with proper parts after the fact – once improvised, always improvised. The exception is Stack Division agents with the **Prototyper** talent, who may treat any improvised item as fully professional for one roll before it is destroyed.*

Improvised Item Failure

When a Gear Die on an improvised item comes up **1**, it does not simply degrade – roll on the following table:

d6	Improvised Item Failure
1	Catastrophic Break. Item is destroyed instantly. If a weapon, the wielder takes 1 damage.

d6	Improvised Item Failure
2	Jams or Jams Shut. Item is unusable this scene. Can be cleared with a free action next round.
3	Splinters / Shrapnel. Item breaks; nearest ally in zone rolls AGI Diff 1 or takes 1 damage.
4	Power Surge. Electronic items: short circuit, sparks. Clear by spending a Slow Action.
5	Reduced Function. Item still usable but provides no bonus die (treat as no item).
6	Quick Fix. Roll was a near-miss – item is stable. Gear Die stays at current step.

Stack Division: Crafting Signature

Stack agents aren't just better at repairs – they have a different relationship with gear entirely. Training in Covenant workshops, maintaining equipment under operational conditions, and sourcing parts through a network of trusted contacts gives Stack agents mechanical advantages no other Division matches.

Advantage	Effect
Craft Bonus	Stack agents add +1 die to all Craft rolls (repair and improvised item creation).
Faster Repairs	Quick Repairs take 5 minutes instead of 15. Full Repairs take 2 hours instead of a full Shift.
Parts Economy	Stack agents never step down a Junk Die on a successful repair – only failed repairs consume parts.
Known Contacts	Once per case, a Stack agent can source Hardware Components (d8) without a Covenant requisition (a contact comes through).
Workshop Access	At HQ, Stack agents may use the Covenant Armorer facility at no additional cost, even before it is fully built. They improvise the bench themselves.

Cross-reference: *Stack Division full description, background options, and Talents (including **Jury-Rig**, **Prototyper**, **Duct Tape & WD-40**) are in [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).*

CHAPTER 11. ARTIFACTS OF POWER AND DOOM

In an occult thriller setting, artifacts are fundamentally dangerous – objects of immense, unknowable power that exact a heavy toll on the human mind and physical reality. Project Neon Relic leans heavily into the "**Artifact of Doom**" narrative trope, ensuring that utilizing magic is always a terrifying gamble.

11.1. The Mechanics of Occult Artifacts

Within the YZE system, mystical objects are classified as **Occult Artifacts**. They often appear entirely mundane – a vintage Polaroid camera, a rusted World War I trench lighter, a tarnished silver coin – but are imbued with intense paranatural energy.

To utilize an artifact, a character must trigger its specific **activation condition** (e.g., speaking a phrase in a dead language, feeding it a drop of blood, or playing a specific frequency). Artifacts function in two interdependent ways:

1. **Overwhelming Power** – The artifact allows an action far outside normal human capability: viewing past events, turning invisible, commanding the undead, or dealing massive unblockable damage to supernatural entities.
2. **The Psychological Toll** – Every activation immediately generates **+1 to +3 Corruption** (by artifact tier), pushing the user closer to the Corruption threshold.

Furthermore, when invoked, the player rolls a specific **Artifact Die** (d8, d10, or d12). If the roll results in a **1**, the artifact's internal metaphysical structure fractures – it may break, go dormant, or trigger a horrific localized side-effect.

11.2. Catalog of 1980s Occult Artifacts

Artifact	Mundane Appearance	Effect	Cost & Fracture (on 1)
The Betamax of St. Jude	Degraded Betamax tape in unmarked black sleeve.	Displays the immediate 10-minute future when played on a VCR. Auto-success on any opposed Wits or Agility roll in the current scene.	2 Corruption. VCR combusts; user temporarily blinded by visions of their own death.

Artifact	Mundane Appearance	Effect	Cost & Fracture (on 1)
The Obsidian Walkman	Heavy, modified Sony cassette player with stone-like casing.	Hear the ambient frequencies of the dead. Communicate with spirits to discover hidden clues or bypass Investigation rolls.	1 Corruption. User deafened by psychic static; gains permanent phobia of silence.
The Oppenheimer Lens	Aviator sunglasses with fused desert-glass lenses.	See the true monstrous forms of entities hiding in human guises. Pierce all supernatural illusions.	1 Corruption. Lenses shatter; shards cause 1 permanent Agility damage.
The Judas Coin	Heavy silver denarius, unnaturally warm.	Target overwhelmed by greed or guilt during social interaction. Auto-success on Empathy (Manipulate).	2 Corruption. Coin burns through user's flesh (1 physical damage); target becomes violently hostile.
The Chronos Polaroid	Polaroid SX-70 camera smelling of ozone.	Photographs a location as it appeared 24 hours prior. Bypasses tracking or forensic analysis.	1 Corruption. Flash acts as beacon, alerting nearest supernatural entity to party's exact location.

11.3. Artifact Carry Weight and Corruption Pressure

Artifacts are not merely heavy objects – they exert **metaphysical pressure** on the agent carrying them. This interacts with the Encumbrance system in two ways:

Physical Weight

Each artifact has a baseline Encumbrance value equal to its **Corruption cost tier**:

Artifact Tier	Enc.	Notes
Low (1 Corruption)	1	Small objects: a coin, a cassette tape, an old photograph.

Artifact Tier	Enc.	Notes
Medium (2 Corruption)	2	Larger objects: cameras, walkmen, instruments.
High (3 Corruption)	3	Bulky or imposing objects: weapons, mirrors, bound volumes.

Active Artifact Pressure

Carrying an artifact that has been **activated at least once this Case File** imposes **+1 Enc.** above its base value for the remainder of the session. The artifact's metaphysical structure is disturbed – it pushes back.

- This additional Enc. is invisible to standard detectors – only characters with the **Lore** skill or Wayfinder training can sense something is off.
- If an active artifact's pressure pushes the carrier into the **Encumbered** state, they also gain **+1 Corruption** at the start of each scene while carrying it (the corruption leaks passively).

Stacking Artifacts

Carrying more than one artifact simultaneously is permitted but discouraged:

- **Two artifacts:** Both active pressure rules apply independently.
- **Three or more artifacts:** The GM triggers a Corruption Cascade – all carried artifacts leak corruption into the carrier simultaneously. Each artifact applies its Corruption cost at the end of the scene, even if none were used.

Lore check (Difficulty 2): *An agent who succeeds on a Lore roll after picking up an artifact can sense its tier and whether a previous carrier activated it. Failure means the agent is unaware of the added pressure until they notice they are Encumbered or start gaining unplanned Corruption.*

11.4. Creating Artifacts (GM Guidelines)

Every Neon Relic campaign arc should have a unique artifact at its heart – a specific, dangerous object with a history, a hunger, and consequences that ripple through the case file. The catalog above provides examples, but GMs need a

structured framework for designing originals.

The rules below use a **Corruption Budget** system: the power of an artifact's effect is always proportional to the psychological and physical cost of using it. No free rides. No safe artifacts.

The Artifact Template

Every artifact needs five defined components. Fill in each section before introducing the artifact to players.

Component	What It Defines	Design Prompt
Origin	Where did this come from? Why does it have power?	"A Civil War surgeon's bone saw used in a field hospital during a thunderstorm that struck the tent. Three hundred deaths witnessed through its blade."
Form	What does it look like? What mundane object is it?	Must appear entirely ordinary. No glowing runes. The horror is the mundane hiding the monstrous.
Effect	What does activating it do?	State the mechanical benefit clearly: what roll it replaces, what it grants, what threat it neutralizes.
Corruption Cost & Tier	How much Corruption does activation generate?	1 Corruption = Tier 1. 2 Corruption = Tier 2. 3 Corruption = Tier 3. See budget guidelines below.
Fracture Condition	What happens when the Artifact Die rolls 1?	Should be thematically linked to the origin. A surgeon's tool might inflict wounds; a musical instrument might silence the user.

Containment Profile (*optional sixth component*): What physical or procedural conditions keep this artifact dormant in transport? What inadvertently activates it? See [Containment Profiles](#) below.

Corruption Budget System

An artifact's Corruption cost is not arbitrary – it flows directly from the power of the effect. Use this framework to set Corruption cost and choose the Artifact Die.

Tier	Corruption Cost	Artifact Die	Effect Power Level
1 – Uncanny	1 Corruption	d8	Grants an automatic success on a single skill roll, or reveals information that would require a Diff 2 roll. No direct combat effect. Minor sensory or perceptual ability.
2 – Threatening	2 Corruption	d10	Replaces a full skill roll with guaranteed success, or grants a significant combat advantage (extra dice, forced complication on enemy). Affects one target in zone.
3 – Catastrophic	3 Corruption	d12	Transcends normal human action entirely – massive unblockable damage, reality alteration, mass psychic attack, temporal displacement of a scene. Cannot be replicated by any mundane skill roll.

Effect Design Rules

These rules prevent artifacts from becoming "I win" buttons:

- One effect only.** Artifacts do one thing. They do it perfectly. They do not do anything else.
- No healing.** Artifacts cannot restore Stress, Corruption, or physical Damage. *(They can transfer damage – a Tier 2 artifact might push one agent's wounds to another – but cannot eliminate harm from the fiction.)*
- Always costs something.** Even on a "successful" fracture-free roll, the Corruption cost is paid. The artifact does not become safer with use.
- Fracture scales with Tier.** Tier 1 fractures are painful and personal. Tier 2 fractures affect the party or scene. Tier 3 fractures threaten the location or the case.

Containment Profiles

Containment is half the job. Before introducing an artifact, define how it is kept inert during transport and what triggers it inadvertently.

Containment Type	How It Works	Example Trigger (Inadvertent Activation)
Physical Isolation	Wrapped in lead foil, stored in a Faraday cage, or sealed in salt-packed containers.	Unwrapped within 5 meters of a powered device.
Ritual Quiescence	A spoken phrase, symbol, or specific handling order keeps the artifact dormant.	Touched without the quiescence rite being performed within the last 24 hours.
Environmental Suppression	Requires specific temperature, darkness, or absence of electromagnetic fields.	Brought into a brightly lit space, or exposed to radio frequencies.
Proximity Restriction	Cannot be within a defined range of another artifact.	Two artifacts stored in the same vehicle for more than 1 hour.
Temporal Lock	Dormant only during specific hours, phases of the moon, or calendar dates.	Activation window opens during a case – may force a ticking-clock constraint.
Cognitive Anchor	Requires a holder with a specific psychological trait (fear, grief, obsession) to remain passive.	Carried by a Corrupted agent (any Corruption stage 2+) – activates involuntarily.

Stack Division Note: The *Covenant Armorer* HQ facility and the Keep's Corruption Dampening Vault provide structural support for containment. Without them, field containment relies on improvised measures and Wayfinder knowledge.

One-of-a-Kind vs. Replicable Artifacts

Most artifacts are **unique** – imbued with power because of specific historical events, blood spilled, or metaphysical convergence that cannot be replicated. The GM should treat these as irreplaceable campaign assets.

Replicable artifacts are the exception. They occur when:

- A formula or ritual is rediscovered (Wayfinder research arc)
- A factory or workshop was unknowingly producing cursed items at scale
- A Fragment entity has seeded multiple objects simultaneously

Replicable artifacts follow the same template but have the **Replicable** tag appended. They may appear in multiple instances throughout a campaign.

Artifact Decay (Optional Rule)

As agents study, handle, and contain an artifact over multiple sessions, its metaphysical coherence may weaken. This is a feature, not a bug – it means containment is working.

Decay Track: Each artifact has a hidden Decay score from 0–5. The GM advances it when:

- The artifact is successfully studied by a Wayfinder (roll Lore, success = +1 Decay)
- A containment ritual is performed correctly (+1 Decay per ritual)
- The artifact fractures (Artifact Die = 1) and the PC survives (+1 Decay)

Decay Score	Artifact Die	Status
0	Full die (d8/d10/d12)	Active and fully dangerous
1–2	Step down one die	Effect weakened; Corruption cost reduced by 1 (min 1)
3–4	Step down two dice	Barely active; only works on activation rolls of 5–6
5	–	Inert. Artifact is neutralized and safe for permanent containment. Case closed.

Decay is the core loop of a well-run Neon Relic campaign. Each case should advance decay on the primary artifact by at least 1. A multi-session arc is complete when the artifact reaches Decay 5.

Worked Example: The Stethoscope of Dr. Morrow

To illustrate the framework in practice:

Origin: In 1943, Dr. Eli Morrow performed an experimental surgery in a research hospital outside Chicago. During the procedure, a corruption event – origin unknown – caused Morrow to hear the deaths of everyone in the building simultaneously. He died at the operating table. His stethoscope absorbed the event.

Form: A 1940s-era Sprague Rappaport stethoscope, worn black tubing, chestpiece engraved with initials E.M. Appears old but functional.

Effect (Tier 2, d10): When pressed to any living person's chest, the user hears not the target's heartbeat but their greatest fear – precise, immersive, and exploitable. Grants automatic success on any Empathy (Manipulate) or Investigate (interrogation) roll against that target for the rest of the scene.

Corruption Cost: 2 Corruption.

Fracture Condition (on 1): The user hears their **own** death – vivid, detailed, inevitable. They gain +2 Corruption immediately and cannot take Slow Actions until end of scene (paralyzed by the vision).

Containment Profile: Physical Isolation – wrapped in surgical gauze treated with saline solution. Activates involuntarily if placed against skin without first spoken: "**Morrow rests.**"

Artifact Decay: Begins at 0. Each Wayfinder analysis session can push this toward inert at Decay 5.

CHAPTER 12. HEADQUARTERS MANAGEMENT

In YZE games, a persistent base of operations is a fundamental pillar of long-term campaign play. In *Mutant: Year Zero* it's the Ark; in *Forbidden Lands*, the Stronghold; in *Vaesen*, Castle Gyllencreutz. In Project Neon Relic, the **Headquarters** serves as a mechanical anchor, a psychological safe haven from Corruption, and an economic resource sink giving players ownership over the world.

12.1. The Covenant Safehouse

At campaign onset, players acquire a default headquarters representing a localized branch of the Covenant. Thematically appropriate locations include:

- An abandoned 1970s underground civil defense bunker
- A defunct mall arcade operating as a front
- A decommissioned subway maintenance station

Initially, the space is entirely derelict. Access to deeper subterranean levels, sealed vaults, or secure storage rooms requires the expenditure of **Development Points (Dev Points / DP)**, awarded collectively for completing Case Files and securing artifacts.

Earning Development Points

The team earns DP collectively during **Phase 8: The Aftermath** of each Case File:

Trigger	DP Earned
Case File fully resolved (mystery closed)	3
Artifact securely contained and logged with the Covenant	1
Named Threat neutralized (not just driven off)	1
Primary objective completed under Countdown escalation (clock reached Stage 3+)	1
Agent rescued from rival faction custody	1

DP is spent immediately during downtime (Phase 8) or banked for future Case Files. There is no cap on banked DP.

12.2. HQ Upgrade Tree

Upgrades are organized into three tiers. Higher-tier upgrades require specific lower-tier facilities to be built first.

Tier 1 – Base Infrastructure

Tier 1 upgrades have no prerequisites. Any can be built from the start of the campaign.

Facility	DP Cost	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Secure Communications Room	2	Encrypted landline bank, reel-to-reel tape vault, scrambled HAM radio array. No one outside the Covenant can track calls to or from this room.	+1 die on Command rolls when coordinating with Covenant contacts between Case Files. One free contact call per downtime (no CL requirement).
Basic Medical Bay	2	Field triage table, locked pharmaceutical cabinet, sterilized instruments. Not elegant, but it keeps people alive.	During downtime, each character recovers 2 additional Attribute points (beyond normal rest). One character may also attempt to clear a non-lethal Critical Injury (Heal Difficulty 2; success removes the injury without Attribute loss).
Safeguard Protocol	1	A reinforced back room, a false-wall escape hatch, and a single-use alarm linked to a trip-wire perimeter. Not a fortress – a head start.	If the HQ is attacked, the team gains +1 die on the initiative roll during the first round of any HQ defense scene. One random NPC contact (if any recruited) survives even if the HQ falls.

Tier 2 – Operational Support

Tier 2 upgrades each require at least one Tier 1 facility to be built first. Prerequisites listed per upgrade.

Facility	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
The Microfiche Archive	3	Secure Communications Room	Wall-to-wall collection of newspaper records, police reports, and occult journals on microfilm. A full-time archivist – never seen without reading glasses and cigarettes – maintains the stacks.	Permanent +2 Gear bonus to Wits (Lore) rolls when researching prior to departure. Also grants access to one free Historical Contact per Case File (a scholar, librarian, or researcher who owes the Covenant a favor).
The Occult Laboratory	3	Basic Medical Bay	Sterile environment with chemical analysis tools, EMF meters, and purpose-built containment vessels. Smells permanently of ozone and burnt copper.	Safely identify unknown artifact triggers without risking accidental activation. Lore roll to identify artifact tier is Difficulty 1 here (instead of 2). Failed identification rolls do not trigger the artifact.

Facility	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
The Black-Market Armory	3	Safeguard Protocol	Reinforced vault with analog combination locks, stocked through underground contacts the Covenant officially denies knowing. The manifest is updated by hand.	+1 CL to all characters during the Equipping Phase of each Case File. High-capacity weapons no longer consume an extra DP to requisition repeatedly.
The Faraday Cage	4	Secure Communications Room	Lead-lined room sealed against electromagnetic and supernatural interference. No phones work inside. No spirits answer. Silence like the inside of a safe.	One character per downtime can heal up to 4 Corruption . Requires a full day inside – the character is unavailable for other downtime activities that day.

Tier 3 – Advanced Operations

Tier 3 upgrades require at least two Tier 2 facilities to be built. Prerequisites listed per upgrade.

Facility	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Field Intelligence Network	5	Microfiche Archive + Secure Communications Room	A distributed network of informants, dead drops, and off-the-books government contacts who feed intelligence to the Covenant. Managed by a rotation of cutout contacts to maintain deniability.	During Phase 2 (The Invitation), the team receives one free additional clue about the Case File's central threat before departure. +1 die on Investigation rolls to identify rival faction involvement.
Covenant Armorer	5	Black-Market Armory	A former Special Forces armorer gone ghost – works out of the armory back room, asks no questions, and charges only in favors and whiskey.	Once per Case File, one item in the team's loadout can be permanently upgraded: +1 Gear Bonus to the item's listed value. The item also gains the Reliable trait (ignore the first 1 when pushing).

Facility	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Corruption Dampening Vault	6	Faraday Cage + Occult Laboratory	A reinforced sub-chamber within the Faraday Cage, retrofitted with seven-layer lead shielding, hand-drawn containment circles, and rotating salt-line maintenance. Costly to maintain and terrifying to enter alone.	Store up to 3 active artifacts without passive corruption leaking to carriers. Artifacts in the vault do not add Enc. pressure (see docs/chapters/11-artifacts.adoc). Vault must be re-consecrated after 3 Case Files (Lore Difficulty 2; failure = 1 random artifact "wakes up").

Facility	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Safe House Network	6	Secure Communications Room + Safeguard Protocol	A constellation of bolt-holes, friendly business fronts, and sympathetic innkeepers spread across the region – pre-loaded with emergency cash, clean IDs, and a single burner phone.	The team always has a fallback safe house available in any new investigation city, no setup required. Removes all "no safe place to rest" environmental penalties while away from HQ. On failure during the HQ Compromise event, one safe house absorbs the breach instead of HQ itself (one-time use; must rebuild, 3 DP).

12.3. Personnel Recruitment

Beyond infrastructure, the team can recruit individual **contacts and specialists** using Development Points. Personnel provide passive benefits between Case Files and can be called upon during active missions at the GM's discretion.

Personnel are not combatants. If the HQ is directly attacked, they flee or hide – they do not fight to defend the base.

Personnel	DP Cost	Who They Are	Benefit
Station Dispatcher (Police)	2	A civilian 911 dispatcher who owes the Covenant a significant debt. Passes case-relevant police radio traffic when it crosses their desk.	Once per Case File, request police incident records, scanner traffic intercepts, or a 10-minute window of police non-response in one location.
Underground Field Medic	2	A struck-off physician – too many questions asked, too many bullet wounds treated no-questions-asked. Brilliant in a crisis.	During downtime, one character may be treated for a non-fatal Critical Injury (removes the injury without Attribute loss if a Heal roll at Difficulty 2 succeeds). Does not replace the Basic Medical Bay; stacks with it.
Black-Market Fence	3	A procurement specialist with connections to military surplus, private security disposals, and the occasional Consortium dropout.	Once per Case File, requisition one CL 4 item without burning the team's CL. The request takes 48 hours in-game. Item arrives at HQ; no trail.
Covenant Scholar	3	A former academic – history, linguistics, or theology – recruited (or blackmailed) into the Covenant's extended network. Corresponds by mail only.	+1 die on pre-mission Lore rolls when the scholar is consulted (same city or via correspondence). Can translate dead languages overnight (remove the "ancient language" investigation obstacle without a roll).

Personnel	DP Cost	Who They Are	Benefit
Signals Technician	4	An ex-NSA field tech – burned, paranoid, and very good at making equipment do things it shouldn't.	Once per Case File, plant a real-time audio tap on a rival faction's communication line (Investigate Difficulty 2; success = one scene of intercepted intel). Also: +1 die on all Tech rolls within HQ.

12.4. HQ Compromise and Attack

The safehouse is not invulnerable. Rivals, government black-ops, and supernatural entities may target it directly.

The Threat Meter

The GM tracks a hidden **Threat Meter** ranging from 0 to 6. When it reaches 6, the safehouse is directly targeted.

The Threat Meter increases by 1 when:

- The team uses explosives or automatic weapons fire in a populated area
- A rival faction agent escapes alive with knowledge of the team's base location
- The team fails to contain a corruption leak (active artifact left unsecured overnight)
- A deceased agent's civilian identity is linked to the Covenant by law enforcement
- The team's Countdown Clock expires (any severity) during a Case File

The Threat Meter decreases by 1 at the end of any Case File in which the team was completely covert (no civilian witnesses, no law enforcement contact, no corruption incidents).

Compromise Event

When the Threat Meter hits 6, the GM triggers a **Compromise Event** before the next Case File begins. Roll d6:

Roll	Compromise Type
1-2	Surveillance – A rival team has a long lens on the safehouse. The HQ is not breached, but the Threat Meter resets to 4 (not 0). All Tier 2+ facilities are temporarily offline until the surveillance is identified and dealt with (a mini-investigation, 1 session).
3-4	Break-In – Evidence of entry, triggered sensors, one personnel contact goes missing. One randomly determined facility is trashed (unavailable until repaired at half DP cost). Threat Meter resets to 3.
5	Direct Assault – A hostile team hits the safehouse hard. Run a full HQ defense scene (see below). One facility destroyed on failure; none if the team holds. Threat Meter resets to 2.
6	Burned – The safehouse is fully compromised. The team must relocate (lose all Tier 1-2 facilities; Tier 3 facilities survive only if the Safe House Network is built). Threat Meter resets to 0. All banked DP intact; team starts rebuilding at new location.

HQ Defense Scene

If the compromise event results in a direct assault (rolls 5-6), run it as a structured conflict:

- The GM establishes attacker strength (Grunt × team size or Elite × half team size from the Bestiary).
- Safeguard Protocol gives +1 die on the team's first initiative roll.
- Characters who are **Broken** during an HQ defense scene and not stabilized before the scene ends immediately suffer the Dying state (no stabilization window extension).
- If the attackers are driven off or destroyed: Threat Meter resets to 2; HQ is undamaged.
- If the team retreats: roll on the Compromise Event table again (once) to determine collateral damage.

Optional – Named Threats: *If the Threat Meter has recently been driven up by a specific rival faction, the GM may assign a Named Threat as the assault leader. This escalates the scene but awards +2 DP if the Named Threat is captured or killed.*

12.5. Covenant Standing (Reputation System)

Covenant Standing is a per-cell meta-progression score that measures how the Verdant Covenant perceives your cell's effectiveness, discretion, and reliability. It is not glamour – it does not mean fame. A cell with high Standing is one that has been trusted with increasingly sensitive operations because they **do not leave messes**.

Standing is tracked as a single score from **0 to 20**, shared by the entire cell. It never applies to individual agents – the Covenant evaluates teams, not heroes.

Standing Ranks

Score	Rank	What It Means
0–4	Unknown	The cell is new or unproven. Covenant resources are minimal; access is limited to Tier 1 upgrades and standard CL 1–2 requisitions.
5–9	Acknowledged	The cell has delivered results. Wayfinder and Keep division contacts treat the cell as credible. CL 3 requisitions become available.
10–14	Trusted	The cell handles significant cases. The Covenant routes priority case files through them. CL 4 access opens. Keep reinforcements available.
15–19	Honored	The cell has operated at the highest levels. Named contacts within Covenant leadership. Access to Classified Archive and Covenant assets.
20	Covenant Elite	Fewer than a dozen cells in history have reached this. The Covenant treats the cell as irreplaceable. No resource limits. Legacy recorded.

Gaining Standing

Standing increases at the end of a case when specific outcomes are achieved. All gains are cumulative – multiple criteria can apply in a single case.

Trigger	Standing Gain	Notes
Successful containment of primary artifact	+2	Artifact recovered and secure in transport or HQ
Zero civilian exposure (no witnesses, no media)	+1	Bonus on top of other gains; lost if any civilian knowledge confirmed
Rival faction neutralized (operative captured/fled)	+2	Does not apply if rival escaped with artifact
Tier 3 artifact recovered intact	+3	Replaces standard containment +2 for Tier 3 cases
Cold case resolved (artifact dormant 10+ years)	+1	Bonus; applies when case origins predate the cell
Covenant agent rescued from hostile custody	+2	Applies once per arc, not per session
Case resolved without casualties (any side)	+1	Bonus; Covenant prefers clean operations
Named Threat operative captured (not just fled)	+3	Rare; named threat must be confirmed Covenant-file target

The maximum Standing gain in a single case is +6 (containment + zero exposure clean resolution, for example). Avoid banking on Tier 3 cases to push the track – those cases are designed to hurt.

Losing Standing

Standing losses are immediate and cannot be avoided by narrative justification. The Covenant knows. It always knows.

Trigger	Standing Loss	Notes
Confirmed civilian casualties	-2 per casualty	Witnesses who survive and go public count as -3 instead

Trigger	Standing Loss	Notes
Supernatural event reported in media	-3	Any press coverage of supernatural phenomena linked to a case
Artifact lost to rival faction or enemy	-3	Lost in the field, stolen post-recovery, or destroyed improperly
Agent compromised, turned, or gone rogue	-4	Applies whether the agent is caught or simply disappears
Case abandoned mid-operation	-2	Cell withdrew without artifact containment or Covenant approval
HQ location exposed to non-Covenant entities	-4	Does not require an attack; exposure alone is the failure
Cover story collapsed (public incident attributed to cell)	-3	Any incident where the cell is publicly connected to supernatural events

Standing cannot go below 0. The Covenant does not formally execute cells with low Standing – it simply stops routing cases to them and begins reassigning their contacts. Effective retirement.

Standing Rewards

Standing unlocks access to resources, upgrades, and Covenant infrastructure that cannot be purchased with Development Points alone.

Reward	Min. Standing	Effect
Tier 2 HQ Upgrades Unlocked	5	Cell may begin purchasing Tier 2 facilities (see [hq-upgrade-tree]). DP cost unchanged.
CL 3 Requisition Access	5	Standard CL 3 gear is available without special authorization.

Reward	Min. Standing	Effect
Keep Reinforcements	10	Once per arc, request a second Covenant cell for 1 session of operational support. They arrive equipped; they do not share Standing.
Tier 3 HQ Upgrades Unlocked	10	Cell may begin purchasing Tier 3 facilities. DP cost unchanged.
CL 4 Requisition Access	10	High-tier equipment (specialized surveillance, artifact containment casings, prototype weapons) available via formal request.
Classified Archive Access	15	Wayfinder Division shares files on cold cases and artifact history normally restricted to senior analysts. +2 dice on Lore and Investigate rolls during Phase 2 (Research).
Covenant Asset Call-In	15	Once per campaign arc, the Covenant deploys a named asset – insider at a government agency, black-market arms contact, demolitions specialist – to assist directly.
Legacy Standing Bonus	20	When a cell member retires or dies, their Keeper (xp replacement PC) begins play with 3 Standing already gained toward the cell total.
Unrestricted HQ Upgrade	20	Once per arc, build any single HQ upgrade for 0 DP. The Covenant funds it directly.

Standing and HQ Upgrade Gates

Some HQ facilities already require specific prerequisites (DP investment and prior facilities). **Standing gates** apply on top of those prerequisites for the most sensitive upgrades. These upgrades cannot be built regardless of DP until the Standing threshold is met.

Facility	DP Cost	Min. Standing
Microfiche Archive (Tier 2)	3 DP	5
Occult Laboratory (Tier 2)	4 DP	5

Facility	DP Cost	Min. Standing
Faraday Cage (Tier 2)	3 DP	5
Field Intel Network (Tier 3)	5 DP	10
Corruption Dampening Vault (Tier 3)	6 DP	10
Safe House Network (Tier 3)	4 DP	15
Covenant Armorer (Tier 3)	5 DP	10

Design Note: *Standing gates exist because Tier 2 and 3 facilities represent the Covenant extending significant trust to a cell. An unproven cell does not get access to the Occult Laboratory or the Corruption Dampening Vault. They have to earn it.*

Rival Cells (Optional Rule)

At campaign start, the GM may establish a rival Covenant cell operating in the same region. Rival cells compete for case priority, Covenant resources, and Standing.

Roll on this table during the first session:

d6	Rival Cell Relationship
1	Allied. The rival cell is cooperative. Shared cases award both cells +1 Standing if resolved successfully. Loss is shared too.
2	Indifferent. The rival cell operates on different case types. They will not interfere – unless cases overlap.
3	Competitive. The rival cell is racing the player cell on at least one case per arc. First to contain gains +1 Standing; second gains nothing.
4	Hostile (Institutional). The rival cell has filed a formal complaint against the player cell with Covenant leadership. The PC cell's next Standing gain is reduced by 1.

d6	Rival Cell Relationship
5	Compromised. The rival cell has a mole. They do not know. The player cell may – do they report it and lose a potential ally, or use it?
6	Shadow. The rival cell does not officially exist. Their operations leave no records. When their cases intersect with the player cell, nothing is as it seems.

Rival Cell Standing: Track the rival cell's Standing separately. If a rival cell reaches a Standing tier higher than the player cell's, the Covenant begins routing priority cases to the rival – the next case the player cell receives is a leftover (roll Complication twice, keep both results).

12.6. Dark Secrets

A **Dark Secret** is a specific fact from your character's past – something true, hidden, and consequential. It is not a personality flaw or a general backstory. It names something: an event, a decision, a relationship that **someone wants to remain buried**.

Dark Secrets serve two purposes in the game:

1. **Roleplay device.** They give the GM a hook. When the investigation points toward your secret – when the evidence room comes up, when the contact's name surfaces – things get complicated. That's the point.
2. **XP question.** At the end of each session, the GM asks: "**Did your Dark Secret complicate the mission?**" If yes: +1 XP. That is the entirety of the mechanical system.

There are no rules for voluntary activation, mandatory exposure, or faction consequences. If your secret surfaces, play it. Whether it surfaced because you chose to bring it in or because the GM did, the XP question applies the same way. Everything else is fiction.

Choosing a secret: *Pick one from your Division's example list below, or write your own. The only requirement: it must be specific enough that the GM can look at it and ask "what happens if the investigation goes here?"*

Wayfinder Dark Secrets

Secret	Details
The Fabricated Report	You submitted a field analysis that was false. You buried evidence linking a recovered artifact to a civilian casualty event. The truth is in a file somewhere. The file has a reference number. You know it.
The Missing Informant	You cultivated a civilian informant for three years – a librarian with a genuine gift for pattern recognition. When the case closed, they disappeared. You did not report them missing. You don't know what happened, but you fear you do.
Unauthorized Correspondence	You have been communicating with a researcher outside the Covenant – someone who reached out through channels that shouldn't exist. Their information has been accurate. You have told them more than authorized. You don't know who they work for.
The Siphoned Archive	You copied a restricted section of the Verdant Codex and hid the transcription in a dead drop you maintain. Your reason was professional – there were patterns in the restricted material that connected to an active case. Your superior has since died. Nobody else knows about the copy or the dead drop.
The Wrong Conclusion	Your analysis on the Alderman Acquisition (Case File #7 – or whatever year's equivalent the GM sets) directly caused the team to misidentify and release a contained artifact. What they released hurt three people. The official record says the release was accidental. You know it followed your recommendation.

Recovery Dark Secrets

Secret	Details
The One You Left	You extracted a target from a hostile situation and got the artifact out clean. But you left someone behind who could have survived with ten more minutes. You made a judgment call. They did not make it out. They had a name. You remember it.
The Side Deal	You negotiated a private arrangement with a civilian who held an artifact: they handed it over, you gave them something in return. Not money – something Covenant. A name. A suppressed report. A real asset. The covenant doesn't know the trade terms.

Secret	Details
The Competing Employer	Early in your career – before the Covenant – you did contract work for a private intelligence firm. You never fully severed the relationship. They knew about you when you were recruited. You have not told anyone. At least one person at the firm knows you are Covenant now.
The Planted Evidence	On a recovery that was politically complicated, you placed evidence at a scene to close a civilian case that was getting too close to the truth. An innocent person was charged. The case was closed. You closed it deliberately.
The Kept Artifact	You found a secondary artifact on a site – smaller, overlooked. You logged the primary. The secondary is in a fireproof box in your apartment. You tell yourself you're studying it. That has been true for sixteen months. You have not told anyone.

Keep Dark Secrets

Secret	Details
The Unauthorized Transfer	You moved an artifact between vault cells without clearance – you believed its listed containment protocol was incorrect. You were probably right. But the transfer created a window during which something influenced three junior staff members. The behavioural anomalies are in the health records. You signed the transfer log as routine maintenance.
The Suppressed Incident	Fourteen months ago, containment in your section failed briefly. Nothing escaped. But a visitor was present – a civilian consultant who should never have been in that corridor. They survived. You suppressed the incident log entry. The consultant now returns your calls with a very specific kind of urgency.
The Loyalty Debt	You owe a significant personal debt to someone who is a member of The Compact – the rival faction. The debt predates your Covenant service. You have not acted on it, but you have also not reported the contact. The debt is the kind that has a due date.

Secret	Details
The Copyist	You maintain a personal archive – transcribed containment protocols, artifact property notes, Warden’s Bracer readings – for a project you tell yourself is academic. The project is not approved. The archive exists on paper, in your handwriting, in your home. You know what happens if it’s found.
The Broken Warden	A trainee under your supervision suffered a containment exposure event eighteen months ago. The official report says they resigned for personal reasons. They are alive, institutionalized under a false name you arranged, and the Covenant does not know they exist. You visit them every few weeks. They are getting worse.

Stack Dark Secrets

Secret	Details
The Off-Books Supply Chain	You have a procurement network that the Covenant doesn’t know about. It operates faster and quieter than official channels. You trust it because you built it. Two of your suppliers have connections you would struggle to explain cleanly.
The Substitution	When a mission-critical component was unavailable, you substituted something that looked right, worked in the moment, and was not what you logged it as. Nothing went wrong. But the mission notes, the equipment manifest, and the Covenant’s records all describe gear that was not actually used.
The Blackmail File	You stumbled onto something about a senior Covenant official during a logistics audit. You photographed the document. You have not used it, have not shown it to anyone, have no plan to. But you kept the photograph. It is in a very safe place.
The Freelance Job	Before – or possibly overlapping with – your Covenant service, you completed contract work for private clients that was unambiguously not sanctioned. The work involved resources and knowledge that came from your Covenant position. You were careful. You do not think you were seen.

Secret	Details
The Faulty Log	The inventory manifest for the last six months has an inconsistency – a recurring item that is always logged as consumed but which you know was not always needed. Someone above you in the logistics chain is running a parallel set of numbers. You have not reported it because you’re not certain you are not also implicated.

CHAPTER 13. ADVANCEMENT AND GENERAL TALENTS

Experience Points (XP) are awarded at the end of each Case File through a structured debriefing. The GM asks the group a series of questions – for every "yes," each player receives **1 XP** (maximum **5 XP per session**):

#	Debriefing Question
1	Did you participate in the session? (<i>Automatic +1 XP</i>)
2	Did you risk your life for a fellow Covenant member or an innocent civilian?
3	Did your Dark Secret complicate the mission, or did you heavily interact with your Anchor?
4	Did the team successfully secure or contain an Occult Artifact?
5	Did you learn something new and significant about the supernatural threat or rival factions?

13.1. Spending XP

Upgrade	XP Cost	Limit
Increase a Skill by 1	5 XP	Maximum rating of 5
Purchase a new Talent	6 XP	General Talent or additional Division Talent

13.2. General Talents

General Talents are specialized abilities available to **any character**, providing mechanical exceptions or situational bonuses:

Talent	Effect
Street Medic	Restore 2 physical Attribute points instead of 1 when successfully using Heal.
Cathartic Release (<i>Healing</i>)	Once per session, dedicate a moment to breaking down, screaming, or venting. Heal 1 Corruption.

Talent	Effect
Hair-Trigger	Draw a weapon as a free action instead of a fast action. Critical edge in ambushes.
Paranormal Intuition	When entering a room, roll Wits (Scout). On success, the GM must tell you if a supernatural entity has been here in the last 24 hours.
Heavy Packer	Carry items equal to twice your Strength without becoming encumbered.
Skeptic's Shield	Once per session, outright ignore a minor supernatural effect by rigidly refusing to acknowledge the impossible.
Night Owl	Ignore all penalties from sleep deprivation. Operate perfectly in the dark.
Chain Smoker (Healing)	Consume a scarce resource (cigarette, specific 80s junk food) during stress. Heal 1 Corruption.
Analog Junkie	Gain +2 Gear dice when using period-accurate 1980s technology (ham radios, acoustic couplers, microfiche).
Grit Your Teeth	Once per session, ignore a -1 Attribute penalty for a single critical roll.
Desensitized	Gain +1 bonus die to all Empathy rolls when dealing with horrific or gruesome crime scenes.
Lucky Coin	Once per session, ignore a 1 rolled on a Gear die, preventing item degradation.
Iron Will (Healing)	Land the killing blow or banish a supernatural threat? The rush of victory heals 1 Corruption.
Brawler	Unarmed strikes inflict base damage of 2 instead of 1.
Flee the Scene	Gain +2 bonus dice to Agility when rolling explicitly to escape a conflict.



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PART V – THE DIRECTOR

Classification: Top Secret – Director Eyes Only
Distribution: Game Director Materials – Do Not Distribute to Players

CHAPTER 14. GM GUIDANCE

Running Neon Relic well means understanding what kind of game it is trying to be: an **investigation horror** game where the real terror is not the monster in the vault, but the agents' growing awareness that the Covenant cannot fully protect them from what they're being asked to do.

This chapter gives you the tools to prepare and run individual cases, develop mysteries that hold together under player pressure, and handle the unexpected. Use it as a working reference, not a rulebook.

14.1. What Makes Neon Relic Work

Before the mechanical tools, three design priorities that should inform every session you run:

1. **Clues are discoverable, not gateable.** Players should never feel stupid for missing something. Every site has multiple paths to the same revelation. The players will find it. Your job is to make the finding feel earned.
2. **The Covenant is not infallible.** Headquarters, the Verdant Codex, and the Division protocols exist in tension with the facts in the field. Let them be wrong sometimes. Let the players be right when the institution isn't.
3. **The artifacts are not neutral.** Every artifact has a trajectory – a direction it pulls the world. Make sure some of that pull lands on the agents. Corruption is not just a penalty; it is the story.

14.2. Session Zero

Before the first case, run a **Session Zero** – a short scene-setting conversation, not a game session. Cover:

Tone and Content Agreement

Ask the group:

- **How much body horror is on the table?** (Explicit physical description of injury vs. suggested.)
- **How much psychological horror?** (Creeping dread, invasive thoughts, direct mind-violation?)

- **NPC deaths:** Are named characters who feel important safe, or is everyone at risk?
- **1980s specificity:** How much do players want analog friction (payphones, limited travel, no GPS) to create problems?

Safety Tools

Recommend one or both:

- **Lines and Veils** – Lines are content never happening, even off-screen. Veils happen but are not described in detail. Ask each player individually.
- **X-Card** – Tapping a card (real or virtual) means the current scene cuts or rewrites, no questions asked.

Finding the Hooks

Ask each player: **Why is your character Covenant?** The answer should involve something personal – not ideology alone. The Covenant fills a need for them. Knowing what that need is tells you how to make the game hurt in the right ways.

14.3. The Five-Element Mystery

Every Case File (mission) is built on five elements. You don't need all five fully developed before play – you need the skeleton, then you let the players fill in the rest.

Element	Question	Design Note
Location	Where is this happening?	One specific place – a town, a building, a neighborhood. Not a region. One gas station in rural Wyoming. One hospital. One concert venue. The 1980s location should feel tactile and era-specific.
Artifact	What is the sourcebook item?	The thing that caused events to spiral. Every case has one artifact. Define its Tier (1-4), its apparent property (what it seems to do), and its real effect (what it actually does to the world around it).

Element	Question	Design Note
Threat	What is the immediate danger?	The presenting problem: the entity, the cultist cell, the MJ-12 investigation, the cover-up. This is what the Covenant is responding to.
Rival Faction	Who else wants the artifact?	Even low-stakes cases should have a second party. The Compact, a private collector, a true believer. Rival factions create competing agendas and prevent simple extraction.
Complication	What makes it personal?	One element that connects to a PC's Dark Secret or Division. If the complication never lands, the case is professional. If it lands, it's personal. Build for personal.

The Mystery Statement

Write one sentence that describes the full case:

"A [Tier X artifact] has surfaced in [Location], attracting [Threat]. [Rival Faction] is already present. The complication: [personal element]."

Example: "A Tier 2 artifact has surfaced in a shuttered Ohio psychiatric hospital, attracting Echoing Remnants that have begun killing the urban explorers who found the site. The Hellfire Consortium has purchased the property and has a crew inside. The complication: one of the explorers is the sister of Agent Castellano's disappeared informant."

If your mystery statement doesn't fit in one sentence, you have too much. Cut.

14.4. Clue Web Design

The Iron Rule: Every piece of critical information must be findable via **at least three different paths**. If information is available only through one NPC, one physical location, or one specific skill roll, the case will break the moment players miss it.

How to Build a Clue Web

1. **Identify the critical revelations.** What must the players learn to understand the case? Typically 3–5 things: the artifact's true nature, the faction's plan, the event that started everything, and the solution (or route to containment).

2. **For each critical revelation, write three paths.** One path should reward Investigate/Lore (physical search, forensic analysis, document study). One path should reward social skills (witness, NPC confession, Manipulate). One path should come through action (confrontation reveals the fact in dialogue, or artifact activation reveals the truth).
3. **Allow forward movement from partial information.** Players who know **something is wrong in the basement** should be able to proceed even if they don't know **exactly what**. Structure facts so that each revelation suggests the next action, even if the players haven't pursued all paths.

The Dead End Test

Before play, look at each NPC and location and ask: **If this was skipped entirely, would the case still be solvable?** If the answer is "no," you have a single-point-of-failure. Fix it.

When Players Go Wrong

Players will occasionally pursue a lead that goes nowhere – or miss the lead that was obvious to you. When this happens:

- **Yes, And:** Agree with what they're doing ("Yes, you search the kitchen") and add a connection ("And you find an Ember Accord symbol inside a cabinet – someone was here before you").
- **No, But:** Deny what they hoped for, but give movement ("The file room is locked and you can't get in right now, but you notice someone has been watching this building from across the street").
- **Never:** "Nothing happens. The search turns up nothing." This is the only forbidden outcome. Something always happens, even if it's the wrong thing.

14.5. Countdown Clocks

Every case has at least one **Countdown Clock** – a track that advances as time passes or key events occur, representing escalating stakes.

Clock Structure

A Countdown Clock has:

- **A name** (what it represents: "Compact Extraction Team Arrives," "Second Civilian Found Dead," "Artifact Corruption Threshold Reached")

- **4-6 clock stages**, each with a defined event
- **Trigger conditions** that advance the clock one step

Example Clock

Clock Name: The Hospital Burns Down (the Consortium will destroy the evidence – and the Remnants – when they've extracted what they need)

Stage	Event	Advance Trigger
1	Consortium team enters the hospital.	Session begins.
2	Consortium arcane specialist completes first survey.	2 real-time hours of in-game activity without confrontation.
3	Consortium team locates the artifact.	Players fail to reach artifact site first, OR artifact site is found without contest.
4	Elimination order issued – the urban explorers are now a liability.	Players have direct contact with the Consortium.
5	Fire is set. Building begins to burn. Remnants are released from their anchor into the street.	Players do not confront the Consortium by end of Day 2.
6	Hospital collapses. Remnants disperse into the city. Consortium escapes with artifact.	Case failure.

Multiple Clocks

High-stakes cases may have two or three simultaneous clocks. Keep them on different timers so players can interrupt one without the others automatically resolving. Multiple clocks also mean that a "successful" case may still end with one clock completing – which is often the more interesting outcome.

14.6. NPC Motivation Design

Every significant NPC needs three things: a **secret**, a **goal**, and a **connection to the artifact**.

Component	Design Note
Secret	Something the NPC is hiding from the agents. Not necessarily sinister – a witness might be hiding that they trespassed, not that they’re a cultist. The secret creates the reason they don’t just tell the agents everything at the start.
Goal	What the NPC is actively trying to accomplish right now. Not a background motivation – a current action. They are doing something during this case.
Artifact connection	How did this NPC encounter the case’s artifact, and what effect has that proximity had on them? Even tangential NPCs should have a small Corruption consequence (nightmares, strange certainty about things they can’t know).

The Motivated NPC Test

Ask: **If the agents were not present, what would this NPC do?** If the answer is nothing – if the NPC only exists as a information dispenser – cut them or give them a clock. NSPCs with active agendas create situations. Situation creators make sessions run.

14.7. Supernatural Entity Behavior

Supernatural entities in Neon Relic do not think the way humans do. Avoid playing them like slow, dangerous people. Use these behavioral templates:

Entity Type	Behavior Pattern
Echoing Remnant	Acts on memory, not will. Repeats actions associated with its final emotional state. An Echoing Remnant from a violent event will reenact something about that event – not attack intelligently. Agents who understand the echo can sometimes avoid it entirely.
Shard Construct	Single-directive: protect the artifact. No curiosity, no self-preservation beyond mission, no social engagement. Cannot be persuaded or manipulated. Can be outmaneuvered (if you aren’t between the Construct and the artifact, it doesn’t care about you).

Entity Type	Behavior Pattern
Bound Entity	Has a will, has a history, has something it wants. Bound Entities can be communicated with through Lore and Psychoanalyze (not Manipulate – they see through human social mechanics). They respond to truth, to acknowledgment of what happened to them. They can be bargained with.
Manifest Presence	A high-tier supernatural intrusion: an entity that has begun to impose its logic on local reality. Does not fight – it redefines the situation . Agents trying to act normally in its presence find that normality is no longer available. These entities are solved through removing their anchor (the artifact) or performing a Wayfinder containment ritual, not fought.

14.8. Improvisation Guidelines

When players go somewhere you didn't prepare:

1. **You don't need to have everything ready.** You need to know the five elements and the clue web. Everything else can be invented.
2. **Names first.** The moment you name an NPC, they become real. Have ten era-appropriate names ready (female and male, surname-friendly for 1980s Midwest America or wherever your game is set).
3. **Establish geography.** "You pull into the parking lot of a strip mall. One end is a closed sporting goods store. The other end is still lit – a late-night laundromat." Specificity creates presence.
4. **Every new location has one strange thing.** Not necessarily supernatural. One thing that's slightly off. This makes the world feel watched, even when nothing is watching.

14.9. 1980s Investigation Complication Table (D12)

Roll when you need an unexpected complication mid-case, when a scene is going too smoothly, or to generate pre-session texture.

D12	Complication
1	The key witness has already spoken to MJ-12. Their story has been changed. They are now afraid of the agents.

D12	Complication
2	A news crew is covering a tangentially related story. They saw something they shouldn't have. They are currently in their van, developing film.
3	The physical evidence the team collected has a fingerprint trace that leads to a Covenant asset who should not be connected to this case.
4	The local police are investigating the same location. They are incompetent but present. Their cruiser is in the way.
5	A pay phone at a critical location rings as the team arrives. The call is from someone who knows the team's names.
6	It's raining. This matters: the evidence site is compromised, the getaway is slower, the team's electronics are at risk, visibility is the wrong kind of limited.
7	A civilian has bonded with the artifact without knowing what it is. They are treating it as a lucky object. It has begun affecting them. They are protective and confused by their protectiveness.
8	The rival faction's operative is not hostile – they are also following orders and they are also scared. They want to talk. Their faction doesn't know they made contact.
9	The building's owner is on-site for unrelated maintenance. They are nosy, unhelpful, and will remember the team's faces.
10	A secondary artifact – unrelated to this case – has been stored in the same facility. It has interacted with the primary artifact. Both are behaving unexpectedly.
11	The extraction vehicle has been reported stolen. The team's transportation is being tracked by a local detective who has no idea what he's looking for but is very thorough.
12	The case's solution requires a resource that Stack misclassified three months ago. The item exists; it is in the wrong vault. Getting it takes the rest of the session, minimum.

14.10. Cross-References

- Case File structure (8-phase structure, Countdown mechanics): [docs/chapters/15-case-file.adoc](#)
- Artifact properties and Tiers: [docs/chapters/11-artifacts.adoc](#)
- Rival faction behavior and agendas: [docs/chapters/17-rival-factions.adoc](#)
- Entity stat blocks and Fear ratings: [docs/chapters/19-bestiary.adoc](#)
- Corruption consequences: [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#)

CHAPTER 15. THE CASE FILE: PROCEDURAL MYSTERY STRUCTURE

To maintain consistent narrative flow and emulate the pacing of a detective serial, Project Neon Relic adopts the episodic mystery structure native to *Vaesens*. This procedural structure paces investigations effectively, preventing analysis paralysis while ensuring easy GM session preparation.

A standard game session – a "**Case File**" – follows eight phases:

15.1. Phase 1: The Prologue

The session begins with brief, roleplayed vignettes detailing the characters' daily lives. This grounds the characters in 1980s reality, establishing their humanity and interpersonal drama before the horror begins.

15.2. Phase 2: The Invitation

The characters receive the narrative hook. In the 80s setting, this could be:

- A panicked, distorted call on an encrypted HAM radio
- A cryptic VHS tape delivered via courier
- A clandestine briefing from a shadow-broker in a neon-lit diner
- A coded message on a BBS bulletin board

15.3. Phase 3: Preparation & Equipping (The Stack)

Conducted at the player's Headquarters:

1. **Research** – Players use base facilities to research the entity or artifact.
2. **Equipping** – Players visit Stack to acquire gear. Roll a pool of dice equal to your **Clearance Level (CL)**. Every 6 allows you to requisition one item equal to or lower than your CL rating. Standard items (CL 1) are given freely within reason.
3. **Supply Acquisition** – All consumable supplies (ammunition, medical kits, batteries, rations) reset to their **starting die size** at no cost during this phase. See [docs/chapters/10-equipment.adoc](#) for the Resource Die system and per-category die sizes.

15.4. Phase 4: The Journey

The GM describes travel to the location. Players can roleplay interactions and roll a survival or navigation skill to gain an **Advantage** – a floating +1 bonus die

usable at any critical point during the mystery.

15.5. Phase 5: Arrival

The team arrives at the macro-location (a sprawling abandoned shopping mall, a remote fog-shrouded logging town, etc.). The GM orients the players and introduces local NPCs holding peripheral clues.

15.6. Phase 6: Places (The Investigation)

The core gameplay loop. Players investigate a node-based network of micro-locations (typically three distinct sites). During this phase, the GM initiates a **Countdown** – a hidden clock that escalates the supernatural threat as time passes, forcing decisive action.

See **Countdown Mechanics** below for the full rules.

15.7. Phase 7: The Confrontation

The climax. Players must synthesize gathered clues to:

- Enact a banishment ritual
- Utilize an opposing artifact to neutralize the threat
- Engage in desperate, lethal combat with the anomaly or rival cultists

15.8. Phase 8: The Aftermath

Survivors return to base. During this phase:

- All requisitioned gear is returned to Stack
- Players undergo debriefing and answer XP questions
- Characters attempt to heal accumulated Corruption
- Check if Critical Injury effects require ongoing treatment
- Initiate new Headquarters upgrades

During the Aftermath, the team earns **Development Points (DP)** based on their performance and spends them to build or expand the Headquarters upgrade tree (see [docs/chapters/12-headquarters.adoc](#) for the full upgrade tree, costs, and prerequisites). The Threat Meter is also updated – if the team was fully covert, it decreases by 1.

15.9. Countdown Mechanics

The Countdown is a **hidden tension clock** that tracks how far a threat has progressed during investigation. Players know the clock exists – the Covenant has briefed them that time is limited – but they do not know exactly how many steps remain.

Clock Structure

Every Countdown has **5 stages**, named by their escalation level. Not every case uses all 5 – a one-session case might compress to 3 stages; a multi-session arc might stretch to 6. The stage names are standard; the specific events at each stage are GM-defined per case.

Stage	State	What It Means	Typical Narrative Effect
1	Dormant	The threat is latent. The artifact is present but not yet destabilizing.	Investigation can proceed without urgency. NPCs may be anxious but not in immediate danger.
2	Stirring	The artifact is beginning to resonate. Minor anomalies are visible to those who know what to look for.	Environmental strangeness. One NPC has been affected. The rival faction has been alerted.
3	Active	The artifact is unstable. An entity manifests or the situation escalates visibly.	Direct danger begins. Civilian NPCs may be harmed. The rival faction is moving.
4	Escalating	The threat is pursuing the agents or actively threatening HQ assets. Containment window is closing.	Enemy reinforcements arrive. Key locations become inaccessible. Agents gain +1 Corruption (environmental saturation – this is not optional).
5	Crisis	No more investigation time. The threat forces confrontation now.	Forced confrontation scene. If the agents do not act, see Clock Expiry below.

Advancing the Clock

The GM advances the clock **one stage** when one of the following triggers occurs:

Trigger Type	Example
Time-based	A full in-game day passes (or a shorter GM-defined interval for fast-burning cases). Time passage is the default trigger that runs in the background of all investigation.
Loud action	The team makes significant noise – fires weapons in a public-ish area, confronts the rival faction directly, causes a scene that draws attention to their presence.
Failed roll at a key site	A Pushed failure on a critical investigation or containment roll has consequences beyond the immediate scene. The clock advances as a result.
Missed window	The GM had a grace window where the clock held (players were close to a resolution). The window passed.
Artifact activation	A PC or NPC directly interacts with the artifact in an uncontrolled way. This advances the clock by 2 if the activation was accidental.

Slowing and Pausing the Clock

The clock can be **slowed** (the next tick is delayed) or **held** (one stage does not advance despite trigger) by specific agent actions:

Action	Effect
Successful Lore roll (Difficulty 3) – agents identify the specific activation condition and prevent it from occurring	Clock held for one trigger cycle (one "free" trigger before it advances).
Secure a secondary occult source – removing a contributing artifact, sealing a ritual circle, or disrupting the rival faction's preparations	Clock advance delayed by one full phase (in-game).
Full containment of the artifact	Clock stops advancing. The immediate threat is on hold until the artifact is removed from containment.

Reversing the Clock

The clock **cannot typically be reversed** – once a stage is reached, its effects persist. However:

- A successful **Wayfinder Division ritual** can reduce Stage 4 back to Stage 3 (the escalating corruption is pushed back).
- Eliminating the rival faction's active presence at a location may reduce Stage 3 back to Stage 2 for that location only (the faction was accelerating the threat independently).

These require significant resources, time, and usually a Lore roll at Difficulty 3 or 4. They are not guaranteed.

Clock Expiry (Crisis Without Resolution)

If the **Crisis** stage is reached without the agents in position for the confrontation, the case does not end – it gets worse:

- One named NPC connected to the case is immediately killed, captured, or permanently Broken.
- The artifact performs its **worst-case activation** (GM reveals what the artifact's threshold effect actually is – it happens now).
- The rival faction secures a strategic advantage they did not have before.

The agents can still succeed, but the cost has increased permanently. **Clock expiry is not a game over** – it is a consequence.

Calibration Guide

Session Length	Recommended Stages	Advance Rate
One-shot (3–4 hours)	3 stages	1 advance per major scene (roughly every 45–60 minutes of play)
Standard session (4–5 hours)	5 stages	1 advance per 2 investigation sites visited, plus time-based advances
Multi-session arc	5–6 stages	1 advance per session, plus triggered advances

Faster clocks create urgency but reduce investigation time. Slower clocks allow thorough exploration but may reduce tension. Adjust based on player style – investigators who want to solve everything cleanly need a slower clock; players who enjoy pressure need it fast.

Sample Clock: The Meridian Hotel (One-Shot: 3 Stages)

Premise: A Tier 1 artifact (the "Meridian Mirror") has surfaced in the penthouse of a decommissioned hotel scheduled for demolition. A journalist is already inside, investigating a cold-case disappearance. The Compact has a team on the way.

Stage	State	Trigger	Effect
1	Dormant	Session open; clocks begins ticking	The journalist is alive and unaware. The Compact team is 2 hours out. The Mirror is in the penthouse.
2	Stirring	Team spends more than 1 hour investigating without reaching the penthouse, OR fires a weapon anywhere in the hotel	The Mirror activates. An Echoing Remnant manifests in the corridor between the team and the penthouse. The journalist has seen it and is hiding. The Compact team is now 30 minutes out.
3	Crisis	Team has not secured the Mirror and Remnant is still active when the Compact team arrives	The Compact team enters the building. The journalist's camera captures the Remnant – the team must now deal with both the Compact operatives AND the Remnant AND contain the journalist. The Mirror's corruption field is saturating the top two floors. All agents in the top two floors gain +1 Corruption per scene.

15.10. Cross-References

- GM guidance for building and calibrating Countdown clocks: [docs/chapters/14-gm-guidance.adoc](#)
- Corruption gain mechanics: [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#)
- Wayfinder Division rituals: [docs/chapters/17-rival-factions.adoc](#) (and Issue #15)

15.11. Case File Generator Tables

The 8-phase Case File structure is the backbone of every Neon Relic session. The tables below give GMs a fast oracle system for building a functional case in under 15 minutes. Roll on each table in sequence or pick entries that fit your campaign

arc.

d66 Artifact Type

Roll two d6s: the first die is the tens digit, the second is the units digit.

d66	Form	Nature
11	Cassette tape	Recordings of events before they happen; playback causes hemorrhaging
12	Pocket watch	Stops time in a 5-meter radius for d6 rounds; user ages accelerated
13	Hospital chart	Accurate medical diagnosis of anyone named in it; reading causes symptoms
14	Photograph	Shows what the subject fears most; viewing drives Fear check
15	Book (journal/diary)	Compels reader to continue until finished; knowledge is real and dangerous
16	Vinyl record	Music causes compliance in listeners within earshot; player is compelled too
21	Military dog tags	Reveals the moment of death of anyone who held the tags
22	Children's toy	Locates any child within a mile; toy speaks in the missing child's voice
23	Radio receiver	Picks up transmissions from parallel timelines; maddening incoherence
24	Compass	Points toward the nearest supernatural entity regardless of direction
25	Mirror (compact or full)	Shows true form of all entities reflected; cannot be looked away from
26	Surgical instrument	Wounds inflicted by it cannot be healed by normal medicine

d66	Form	Nature
31	Film reel	Footage shows crimes not yet committed; watching causes +1 Corruption
32	Blueprint or schematics	Construction following these plans creates a corrupted space; builders don't survive
33	Coin (antique)	Payment seals bargains metaphysically; collection agent is always a monster
34	Key (iron or bone)	Opens any locked door; what waits behind is never what was expected
35	Hand tool (hammer, wrench)	Objects struck retain kinetic energy indefinitely; environment becomes hostile
36	Lighter or matchbook	Fire summoned is cold and black; burns only the guilty
41	Eyeglasses / goggles	Sees through all deception, illusion, and disguise; wearer cannot close eyes
42	Gloves (leather or rubber)	Touch transmits the last emotion felt by any object's previous owner
43	Briefcase / attaché	Contents preserved in stasis; time inside does not pass
44	Telephone handset	Connected to lines that shouldn't exist; callers are always threatening
45	Medication / pill bottle	Suppresses supernatural perception entirely – including warning senses
46	Painting or portrait	Subject watches through it; communicates, manipulates, hungers
51	Typewriter	Text typed on it becomes true; reality reconfigures to match
52	Map (hand-drawn)	Accurate to a location that doesn't exist – yet
53	Clock (grandfather or wall)	Slows time in a building-sized area; those inside age normally

d66	Form	Nature
54	Syringe / vial of fluid	Injection grants a specific ability; dependency forms within 24 hours
55	Musical instrument	Performance compels specific emotional response; player loses control
56	Weapon (pistol, knife)	Kills what cannot be killed; user marked for retaliation by its kind
61	Wristwatch	Vibrates when the wearer is about to make a fatal mistake
62	Handcuffs or restraints	Anyone bound cannot lie; binding marks disappear but effects persist
63	Tape recorder	Previous owner's last words loop at danger peaks; cannot be erased
64	Newspaper (dated ahead)	Next day's events described accurately; handling causes +1 Corruption per reading
65	Wallet or purse	Holds exactly what is needed in any situation; contents are never explained
66	Mundane item (GM choice)	Appears entirely ordinary; effect is not discovered until a Fracture

d6 Inciting Incident

How does the cell first become aware of the case?

d6	Inciting Incident
1	Missing Person Report – A Covenant contact is digging into a disappearance that connects to a known occult signature. They need field backup before the trail goes cold.
2	Anonymous Tip – An unsigned letter arrives at a cell dead drop, containing specific details only an insider could know. Who sent it – and why now?

d6	Inciting Incident
3	Police Report (Redacted) – A Keep archivist intercepts a law-enforcement file referencing phenomena that match an active artifact. The police don't understand what they have. The cell does.
4	Field Acquisition Gone Wrong – A previous Recovery team retrieved an artifact but never checked in. Their last known position is on the map. Their radio is silent.
5	Covenant Intelligence Briefing – Wayfinder Division has been tracking an occult energy spike for weeks. The spike has stabilized. Something has been activated and is being used.
6	Civilian Exposure – A non-Covenant civilian witnessed something they cannot explain. The Covenant's disinformation infrastructure is moving to contain the story – but the artifact is still out there.

d6 Location

Where does the case take place?

d6	Location
1	Urban Apartment / Residential Block – Dense housing, suspicious neighbors, minimal cover. The artifact has been in someone's home for years. They think they know what it is. They are wrong.
2	Research Laboratory – University or corporate facility. Security protocols, locked sample rooms, and at least one obstructive bureaucrat. Someone on staff is already compromised.
3	Rural Property – Isolated farmhouse, hunting cabin, or failed commune. No witnesses. No backup. Distance means a 45-minute response time if things go wrong.
4	Government Facility – Federal archive vault, military depot, or municipal records building. Covenant cannot officially exist here. Federal jurisdiction complicates everything.
5	Industrial Site – Active factory, rail yard, or chemical plant. Environmental hazards. Shift workers everywhere. The artifact is somewhere in the noise.

d6	Location
6	Transient Space – Bus station, motel strip, or truck stop. People flow through constantly. The artifact is being moved, and the window to intercept it is closing.

d6 Complication

What makes this case harder than it should be?

d6	Complication
1	Rival Faction Interest – Another organization (intelligence agency, criminal syndicate, or rogue occultist network) has tracked the same artifact. They are already on-site or arriving within the hour.
2	Civilian Entanglement – Someone innocent – a family member, a local witness, a bystander – has handled the artifact and is already exhibiting corruption symptoms. The clock on their degradation has started.
3	Media Attention – A local journalist is following the same trail for completely mundane reasons. Their story goes to press in 48 hours whether the cell intervenes or not.
4	Internal Complication – One of the cell's Covenant contacts has gone quiet. A Wayfinder briefing contains an inconsistency. Something in the chain of command is compromised.
5	Containment Failure – A previous version of this artifact was thought neutralized. It wasn't. Two instances of the same occult signature are active simultaneously.
6	Escalating Entity – The artifact has attracted or generated a supernatural entity that has been active in the area for days before the cell arrived. It is not the primary target – but it will interfere.

d6 Named Threat (Optional)

If the campaign calls for a recurring antagonist, determine their involvement:

d6	Named Threat Angle
1	The Named Threat is three steps ahead – the artifact was already moved before the cell arrived.
2	An operative working for the Named Threat is on-site, posing as a civilian, law enforcement, or utility worker.
3	The Named Threat wants the artifact contained just as badly as the Covenant does – for entirely different reasons.
4	The Named Threat has already activated the artifact once. The Fracture condition has triggered. The threat is managing fallout.
5	The Named Threat is watching the cell specifically. They have a file on at least one agent.
6	The Named Threat is not involved – but they will learn about this case. Increase the Threat Meter by 1 after resolution.

Quick Case Build (15-Minute Prep Guide)

Use this procedure to run from nothing to a playable case in one pass:

1. **Roll d66 on the Artifact Type table.** This is your MacGuffin. Name it, give it a mundane appearance, and confirm its tier (Tier 1 if the effect description is minor; Tier 3 if it bends reality).
2. **Roll d6 on Inciting Incident.** This determines how the session opens. Brief the players in 2 sentences at the table. Do not explain the artifact yet.
3. **Roll d6 on Location.** This determines where 80% of the case takes place. Sketch a rough map with 3–4 meaningful zones.
4. **Roll d6 on Complication.** Layer this into the location. It does not need to be introduced immediately – complications should emerge from play.
5. **Name one NPC the players will meet in the first 15 minutes.** This person either has information the cell needs, or is the first obvious lead. Give them a name and a motivation (they want something that has nothing to do with the artifact).
6. **Define the clock.** What happens if the cell does not act within 1–2 sessions? The artifact is moved, activated, or a civilian dies.
7. **Use the 8-phase structure.** The tables populate Phases 1 (Intelligence Brief) and 2 (Research and Preparation). Everything else emerges from play.

Worked Example: "The Holbrook Frequency"

Rolled: d66 = 23 (Radio receiver – parallel timeline transmissions). **Incident:** 5 (Covenant Intelligence Briefing – occult energy spike, stabilized). **Location:** 2 (Research laboratory – university). **Complication:** 3 (Media attention – journalist, 48-hour deadline).

Case Setup: The physics department at Holbrook University in Columbus, Ohio has been receiving anomalous radio transmissions for three weeks. A Covenant analyst matched the frequency signature to a Tier 2 artifact: a surplus military radio receiver modified with components sourced from a 1943 German ESP research program. A local science reporter is writing a "mystery signal" human-interest piece for the Columbus Dispatch – deadline Friday.

Clock: The journalist's article runs Friday morning. If the artifact is not secured by then, the story triggers federal interest and the Covenant loses access to the university.

NPC: Dr. Frances Okafor, 44, physics faculty. She knows the signal is anomalous. She wants grant funding, not interference. She will cooperate – for a price.

CHAPTER 16. TRAVEL AND JOURNEY RULES

The Covenant sends agents across the 1980s American landscape – through ice storms and state highway rest stops, across cities that don't know they're being watched, into small towns that are. There are no cell phones, no GPS, no real-time coordination beyond a crackling CB radio or a roadside payphone.

Getting there is part of the story.

16.1. Journey Phases

Every significant journey follows three phases:

Phase 1 – Planning

Before departure, the team answers three questions:

1. **Destination:** Where are you going? How far? What do you know about it?
2. **Route:** How are you getting there? Direct? Circuitous to avoid surveillance?
3. **Load:** What are you bringing? Review Encumbrance. Vehicle capacity applies.

The GM notes the **base travel time** and the **Threat Level** of the journey (see Journey Threat below). If the team has the Field Intelligence Network HQ upgrade, they begin with one free piece of route intelligence.

Phase 2 – The Journey

Divide the journey into **legs** – distinct segments separated by a stop, a hazard, or a change of environment:

- **Short journey** (same city or adjacent area): 1 leg. No encounter roll unless the GM sees an opportunity.
- **Medium journey** (cross-state, 2–4 hours): 2 legs. Roll on the Road Event table once.
- **Long journey** (overnight, 4–12 hours): 3–4 legs. Roll on the Road Event table for each leg.
- **Extended journey** (multi-day cross-country): One leg per major stopping point. Roll for each leg. Each overnight rest (without a secure location) costs +1 Corruption (the exposure accumulates).

Leg structure:

Each leg, the driver (or lead navigator on foot) makes a skill roll:

- **Car or motorcycle:** WIT (Investigate) to read the route, Difficulty 1 (clear conditions), 2 (night/weather), or 3 (active pursuit or unknown territory).
- **Foot or urban transit:** AGI (Sneak) to move without drawing attention, Difficulty 1 normally, 2 in hostile areas.
- **Charter flight or helicopter:** WIT (Tech) to coordinate with the pilot or operate the comms, Difficulty 2.

On success: The leg passes without incident, or the team gains one piece of useful information about the destination. **On failure:** Roll on the Road Event table (or the GM applies a prepared complication). **On push:** +1 Corruption as normal. The driver is rattled; the vehicle takes wear.

Phase 3 – Arrival

On arrival, any damage or injuries sustained during travel remain in effect. Any gear that was pushed during travel may be degraded. The team notes which scene they arrive in (Phase 4 or 5 of the Case File structure).

16.2. Vehicle Types and Travel Speeds

Vehicle	Speed	Capacity (Enc.)	Noise	Notes
On Foot	Slow	Personal carry only	Silent	Surveillance-proof but exhausting. Extended travel = risk of Agility damage from fatigue.
Bicycle	Slow-Medium	+4 Enc. (rack)	Silent	Urban movement; can enter places cars can't. Cannot outrun a vehicle chase.
Compact Car (e.g., Honda Civic)	Medium	20 Enc.	Low	Inconspicuous. +1 die on Sneak rolls to avoid surveillance.
Full-Size Sedan (e.g., Crown Vic)	Medium	25 Enc.	Low	The standard Covenant field vehicle. Reliable. Boring. Perfect.

Vehicle	Speed	Capacity (Enc.)	Noise	Notes
Panel Van	Medium	50 Enc.	Medium	Can transport personnel and equipment. -1 die on Sneak rolls; noticed in residential areas.
Pickup Truck	Medium	40 Enc.	Medium	Useful in rural terrain. Bed cargo is visible. Common enough to blend in.
Motorcycle	Fast	10 Enc.	Medium	Best for tailing, losing a tail, and city navigation. Terrible in bad weather (-2 dice in rain/snow).
Helicopter (chartered)	Very Fast	30 Enc.	High	Expensive; requires a Contact. Arrival is conspicuous. Never use near civilian populations if covert.
Boat (motorized)	Slow- Medium	60 Enc.	Medium	Coastal and river access. Cannot be followed by road. Not available in every scenario.

Vehicle Damage: Vehicles have a simplified **Reliability track**. Each time a vehicle roll is pushed, or the vehicle is involved in a collision, it takes 1 Wear. At 3 Wear, the vehicle has a problem (engine issue, flat tire, blown fuse). At 5 Wear, it stops.

A Tech roll (Difficulty 2, +First Aid Kit bonus applies if using proper tools) can clear 1 Wear per scene of work. Full repair requires a mechanic, a day, and the right parts.

16.3. Road Event Table

Roll **d12** when a Road Event is triggered.

Roll	Event
1	Weather Turn. A fast-developing storm (rain, fog, snowdrift). All vehicle rolls at -1 die until the team stops and waits it out (minimum 30 minutes in-game) or pushes through. If they push, weather worsens.
2	Breakdown. Vehicle takes 1 Wear immediately. Tech roll (Difficulty 2) to address roadside or continue at -1 die on all vehicle rolls.
3	Police Checkpoint. Roadblock ahead – routine or targeted. The team must choose: reroute (+1 leg to the journey), talk their way through (Manipulate Difficulty 2; failure = detained briefly), or bluff past (Sneak Difficulty 3).
4	Road Accident. A civilian incident is visible ahead – a crash, a stalled car, a figure in the road. Stopping may be medically necessary but adds time and a potential witness.
5	Tail Detected. A vehicle has been maintaining pace behind the team for the last leg (see Rules for Being Followed below).
6	Corruption Event. The drive passes through a zone of residual occult activity. Every character gains +1 Corruption. No check required – the exposure just happens. The area smells like copper coins and burnt static.
7	CB Radio Intercept. The team picks up a fragment of conversation relevant to the Case File – a police dispatch, a rival faction contact check, a panicked civilian. Roll Investigate (Difficulty 2) to extract actionable intelligence.
8	Trucker's Information. A rest stop encounter with a long-haul trucker who has been on the road through the destination area. Neutral contact. Investigate (Difficulty 1) reveals one useful local detail (road closures, unusual activity, a landmark). Buy them coffee.
9	Wrong Turn. Navigation error. Add +1 leg to the journey. The new route passes through an area with different terrain (GM chooses: industrial, residential, rural, waterfront – add flavor).
10	Mechanical Oddity. Something in the vehicle is behaving strangely – electronics flickering, compass spinning, tape player recording on its own. Artifact proximity or corruption leak suspected. Lore (Difficulty 2) to assess. No immediate danger – but it should be noted.

Roll	Event
11	Fuel Stop. The team must stop for gas (or food, or rest). A 15-minute window of vulnerability – public space, potential surveillance. Sneak (Difficulty 1) to transit without being noted by anyone watching.
12	Clean Run. No event this leg. The team arrives at the next waypoint ahead of schedule. They may ask the GM one question about the destination that they would have known if they'd had more time to prepare.

16.4. Rules for Being Followed

Noticing a Tail

A tail can appear at any point during a journey – or it may have started before departure (the team's HQ may already be watched). The GM may introduce a tail narratively or trigger it via Roll #5 on the Road Event table.

To notice a tail: * **Wits (Investigate) Difficulty 2** – passive awareness during normal travel. * **Wits (Investigate) Difficulty 1** – if the team is specifically looking for surveillance. * The tail makes no roll – the GM decides if they are being careful. A professional tail (MJ-12, experienced Consortium operative) imposes +1 Difficulty to the detection roll.

Losing a Tail

Once a tail is confirmed, the driver can attempt to lose it. This is a **Chase sequence** (abbreviated):

Three options, each requiring one skill roll:

1. **Outrun:** AGI (on foot) or WIT (driving). Difficulty 2. Success = tail loses visual. Failure = they stay on you, and the leg's Road Event is escalated by one (worsening conditions, additional exposure).
2. **Blend In:** AGI (Sneak) or WIT (Investigate, to find a crowd). Difficulty 2. Success = tail loses the vehicle or person in ambient traffic. Requires stopping or drastically altering route.
3. **Double Back / Trap:** WIT (Investigate). Difficulty 3. Success = not only is the tail lost, but the team may identify **who** is following them (a glimpse, a plate, a voice on a radio). This is valuable intelligence.

On failure: The tail remains. The team may try again next leg (no Corruption cost for failed attempts – frustration is not supernatural). If the tail stays through an entire journey, they arrive at the destination knowing where the team is going.

The Tail Arrives

If the team reaches the destination with a tail still on them:

- The GM places an additional hostile element in Phase 5 (Arrival) or Phase 7 (Confrontation).
- The team does not know exactly what they brought with them until it surfaces.
- One rival faction action clock (if active) accelerates by one step.

16.5. Being Followed – Named Threat Complication

If the tail is a Named Threat or a designated faction operative (introduced in the Case File), losing them requires a **Contested Roll**: the team's skill roll is opposed by the tail's relevant skill (Sneak or Investigate, Difficulty set by that NPC's Wits).

If the Named Threat is allowed to arrive at the destination, they are briefed on the team's location. The GM may use this to introduce them as a threat in the Confrontation phase instead of an earlier scene.

16.6. Atmospheric Travel Notes

The 1980s travel experience has no shortcuts and no digital assists. Consider:

- **Road maps:** Required for unfamiliar routes. Without a map, add +1 Difficulty to all navigation rolls. Maps can be obtained at gas stations or found in the glovebox of a vehicle – rarely accurate for back roads.
- **Payphones:** The only way to communicate in the field. Payphones require correct change (loose quarters are standard Covenant field kit). Calls can be traced within approximately 10 minutes – keep it short.
- **Weather:** Before cellular radar, weather in remote areas can surprise a team. The GM may introduce weather as a narrative beat at any point without a Road Event trigger.
- **Rest stops:** The I-system rest stops are the 1980s version of networking hubs – truckers, salespeople, and anyone moving across America overnight. A character with Manipulate 2+ can gather rumors at a rest stop with a single Difficulty 1

roll.

CHAPTER 17. RIVAL FACTIONS

The Covenant must constantly navigate the political and lethal threats posed by powerful rivals who view artifacts as weapons or commodities:

17.1. Majestic-12 (US Government)

A heavily militarized branch of the American Department of Defense responsible for handling anomalous threats. Operating out of classified black sites, M-12 seeks to reverse-engineer artifacts into Cold War weaponry. They possess vast resources but view human life as expendable collateral.

17.2. The Hellfire Consortium

An elite, global network of corporate executives, politicians, and billionaires who utilize blood magic and ancient rituals for financial gain and political manipulation. They treat the occult as a tool for extreme capitalism, reflecting the "greed is good" ethos of the 1980s.

17.3. The Thule Remnants

Extremist occultists and ideological zealots who survived the mid-20th century. Operating in absolute secrecy, they seek specific, world-ending "Artifacts of Doom" to rewrite historical outcomes and establish a new world order.

17.4. The Network

A decentralized collective of early hackers, phreakers, and pirate radio broadcasters. Anarchistic in nature, they seek to expose the truth of the occult to the public – often inadvertently unleashing horrors they don't understand in the name of "information freedom."

CHAPTER 18. NOTABLE HISTORICAL COVENANT MEMBERS

Because of the rigid structure of 441 members, players are part of an unbroken lineage of historical stewards. The following represent legendary past members from the Covenant archives.

18.1. The Medieval & Renaissance Eras

Member	Dates	Division	Legacy
Godfrey of Bouillon	c. 1060–1100	Recovery	Used the chaos of the First Crusade to seize and sequester dangerous Levantine relics.
Hildegard of Bingen	1098–1179	Keep	A visionary nun who created early containment wards disguised as complex musical compositions.
Albertus Magnus	c. 1200–1280	Wayfinder	Dominican friar who mapped the alchemical resonance of European artifacts.
Roger Bacon	c. 1219–1292	Keep	Designed the first lead-lined alchemical containment chambers, hidden within academic manuscripts.
Marco Polo	1254–1324	Recovery	Used his famous travels as a smokescreen to extract dangerous Silk Road artifacts.
Nicolas Flamel	1330–1418	Keep	Guarded a highly unstable, reality-warping artifact masked as the "philosopher's stone."
Marsilio Ficino	1433–1499	Wayfinder	Translated the <i>Corpus Hermeticum</i> to decipher ancient artifact triggers for field agents.
Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa	1486–1535	Keep	Authored the <i>Three Books of Occult Philosophy</i> as a coded manual for Covenant catalogers.
Paracelsus	1493–1541	Wayfinder	Pioneered treatments for the physical symptoms of early-stage Corruption Cascades.
John Dee	1527–1608	Wayfinder	Used Enochian magic and Elizabeth I's court to intercept Spanish occult weaponry.

18.2. The Enlightenment & Victorian Eras

Member	Dates	Division	Legacy
Athanasius Kircher	1602–1680	Keep	Categorized cursed Egyptian artifacts and built the first deep-subterranean vaults beneath Rome.
Emanuel Swedenborg	1688–1772	Wayfinder	Mapped the ethereal plane, developing techniques to bypass supernatural traps.
Count of St. Germain	1712–1784	Recovery	Used his alleged "immortality" as cover for a generational lineage of Recovery agents.
Giovanni Battista Belzoni	1778–1823	Recovery	Posed as an archaeologist to extract cursed Egyptian antiquities from collapsing tombs.
Sir Richard Francis Burton	1821–1890	Recovery	Master of disguise and linguistics who infiltrated forbidden cities to retrieve stolen relics.
Heinrich Schliemann	1822–1890	Recovery	Used the excavation of Troy as a front to extract weaponized mythological artifacts.
Helena Petrovna Blavatsky	1831–1891	Wayfinder	Normalized the esoteric through the Theosophical Society to enable covert investigations.
William Wynn Westcott	1848–1925	Keep	Co-founded the Golden Dawn, using lodges as safehouses for psychological ward development.
Arthur Edward Waite	1857–1942	Wayfinder	Encoded artifact locations and entity weaknesses into the Rider-Waite Tarot deck.
William Butler Yeats	1865–1939	Wayfinder	Used poetic resonance and automatic writing to locate dormant Celtic artifacts.

18.3. The 20th Century (Pre-1980s)

Member	Dates	Division	Legacy
Howard Carter	1874–1939	Recovery	Handled the catastrophic curse outbreak during the Tutankhamun extraction.

Member	Dates	Division	Legacy
Nicholas Roerich	1874-1947	Recovery	Ran Himalayan expeditions to secure the Chintamani Stone before Axis occultists.
Evelyn Underhill	1875-1941	Keep	Developed meditation techniques that actively counteract Reality Distortion.
Jack Parsons	1914-1952	Wayfinder	Blended Thelema with aerospace technology to attempt destruction of volatile off-world artifacts.

CHAPTER 19. BESTIARY

The world of Project Neon Relic contains two kinds of dangerous things: **people** who have made terrible choices, and **entities** that should not exist. Understanding the difference – and knowing when you are facing which – is a field skill every Covenant agent must develop.

This chapter provides stat blocks for the most common adversaries: human factions who oppose the Covenant's work, and supernatural entities that artifacts attract, create, or summon.

19.1. Stat Block Format

All adversaries – human and supernatural – use the same core stat block, scaled by threat level.

Standard Stat Block

NAME

[Classification / Faction / Tier]

Attributes: STR X | AGI X | WIT X | EMP X

Armor Rating: X (type)

Fear Rating: X (0 for humans unless marked)

Skills:

Force X | Brawl X | Endure X

Sneak X | Sleight of Hand X | Firearms X

Investigate X | Tech X | Lore X

Manipulate X | Command X | Psychoanalyze X

Special Abilities:

Name – Description.

Broken State: [Flee / Surrender / Berserk / Dissipate / Death]

Motivation: One sentence describing what this adversary wants in this scene.

Stat Block Notes

- **Attributes** are used exactly as PC attributes – as both dice pool maximums and health pools. When Strength reaches 0, the adversary is Broken.
- **Skills not listed** default to 0.
- **Armor Rating** functions identically to PC armor – Gear dice rolled against incoming damage.

- **Fear Rating** applies to supernatural entities and rare humans. 0 = no Fear check triggered. See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#).
- **Broken State** defines what happens when the adversary's Strength hits 0.
- **Damage types** in special abilities should specify their type and target: Physical (STR or AGI), Mental (WIT or EMP), or Corruption. See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

Simplified Humanoid Format

Minor human adversaries (background cultists, security guards, common thugs) do not require full stat blocks. Use this shorthand:

```
TYPE (Threat Level: Low / Medium / High)
STR X | AGI X | WIT X | EMP X | Armor X | Firearms X | Brawl X
Broken State: [Flee/Surrender]
Special: [One sentence if applicable, or "-"]
```

19.2. Human Adversaries

Ember Accord Cultist

[Human / The Ember Accord / Threat: Low]

```
Attributes: STR 3 | AGI 2 | WIT 2 | EMP 3
Armor Rating: 0
Fear Rating: 0
```

Skills:

```
Force 1 | Brawl 2
Sneak 2
Lore 2
Manipulate 2
```

Special Abilities:

Zealot's Resolve – The cultist does not surrender until their Strength is reduced to 1. They believe their cause makes them untouchable.

Improvised Ritual – Once per combat, the cultist may spend their Slow Action to attempt a Lore roll (Difficulty 3). On success, they call a fragment of an artifact's corrupting effect to their location: all agents within Near range gain +1 Corruption. On failure, the cultist takes 1 Wits damage (backlash).

Broken State: Zealot's Resolve delays collapse; at STR 1, one more hit Breaks them. Broken cultists either enter catatonic prayer or flee. GM's call.

Motivation: Protect the artifact/ritual/site. They believe you are desecrating something

holy.

Ember Accord Cell Leader

[Human / The Ember Accord / Threat: Medium]

Attributes: STR 4 | AGI 3 | WIT 3 | EMP 4

Armor Rating: 1 (concealed vest – improvised, not rated)

Fear Rating: 0

Skills:

Force 2 | Brawl 3 | Endure 2

Firearms 2

Lore 3

Manipulate 3 | Command 2

Special Abilities:

Burn the Evidence – If the Cell Leader reaches Broken State with a ritual site or artifact nearby, they attempt one final Lore roll (Difficulty 2) to trigger a corruption discharge. On success: all within Short range gain +2 Corruption. This is not suicidal – they expect to survive. They often don't.

Rally the Faithful – While the Cell Leader is active, all Ember Accord Cultists in the scene gain +1 die on Brawl rolls. If the Cell Leader falls, they lose this bonus and their Broken State changes to immediate surrender or flight.

Broken State: Surrender. The Cell Leader is pragmatic enough to value their life over the immediate mission. They will lie during interrogation.

Motivation: You have interfered with something the Accord spent years preparing. They want to delay, contain, or eliminate you before word reaches the Covenant.

MJ-12 Strike Agent

[Human / MJ-12 / Threat: High]

Attributes: STR 5 | AGI 4 | WIT 3 | EMP 2

Armor Rating: 4 (Tactical Kevlar – military spec)

Fear Rating: 0

Skills:

Force 3 | Brawl 3 | Endure 3

Sneak 3

Firearms 4

Investigate 2 | Tech 2

Special Abilities:

Suppressive Discipline – MJ-12 agents do not panic under mundane violence.

Supernatural Fear checks are still required, but they roll with +1 bonus die*

(training).

Tactical Communication – If two or more MJ-12 agents are present, they act simultaneously on the same Initiative card. One card covers the team.

Secure Extraction Protocol – If an MJ-12 team's mission fails (artifact lost, agents dead or captured), surviving Strike Agents attempt organized withdrawal and extraction. They do not chase; they regroup. The agents will know they were seen. A debrief has already been filed.

Broken State: Tactical withdrawal. MJ-12 never dies on-site unnecessarily. A Broken Strike Agent calls for backup on a secure frequency as they fall – a dead man's switch. Agents have 1d6 scenes before extraction arrives.

Motivation: Retrieve the artifact for Project Paper Lantern. Neutralize Covenant operatives if exposed. No witnesses.

Hellfire Consortium Blood Contractor

[Human / The Hellfire Consortium / Threat: High]

Attributes: STR 3 | AGI 3 | WIT 4 | EMP 3

Armor Rating: 2 (ritual garments – treated leather with artifact weaving)

Fear Rating: 2 (the things they've done are visible in their eyes)

Skills:

Brawl 2 | Endure 3

Sneak 2

Lore 4

Manipulate 3 | Command 2

Special Abilities:

Blood Price – The Contractor may spend their own Strength (up to 2 per round) to fuel their abilities. Each point of Strength voluntarily spent grants them +2 dice on their next Lore roll. This does not trigger armor. They choose to bleed.

Corruption Tap – On a successful Lore roll (Difficulty 2), the Contractor forces one agent within Near range to gain +2 Corruption immediately.

Bound Sigil – The Contractor carries a ward. The first time they would be Broken, the ward absorbs it: they are reduced to STR 1 instead of 0. The ward then cracks – a physical object on their person is visibly destroyed. This happens once.

Broken State: Dissipation of the bound contract. The Contractor collapses and enters a catatonic state – their blood price comes due. They cannot be easily interrogated; the contract burns out their ability to speak clearly for hours.

Motivation: Acquire the artifact. The Consortium has a buyer. The agents are an inconvenience that should have been avoided.

19.3. Supernatural Entities

Echoing Remnant (Poltergeist)

[Supernatural / Entity / Threat: Low-Medium]

Attributes: STR 4 | AGI 3 | WIT 1 | EMP 0

Armor Rating: 2 (force of coherence – the entity's structural integrity)

Fear Rating: 2 (objects move wrong; the air gets cold)

Skills:

Force 3

Sneak 3

Special Abilities:

Incorporeal Movement – The Remnant moves through solid objects and zone walls without cost. Zone features (Cramped, Rough) do not apply to it.

Poltergeist (Passive) – At the start of each combat round, all loose objects in the Remnant's current zone animate. One agent in the zone takes 1 Strength damage from thrown debris (no attack roll – environmental). An agent who takes cover removes themselves from the zone effectively.

Corruption Bleed – When the Remnant deals damage, the target gains +1 Corruption in addition to the physical effect. The touch carries something of whatever this thing was.

Broken State: Dispersal. The Remnant's coherence fails; it fragments into an area of ambient cold and auditory static. It may reconstitute (GM decision) if the anchor object that binds it is not removed from the area.

Anchor: Every Echoing Remnant is bound to a physical object. Destroying or removing the anchor prevents reconstitution. Finding the anchor requires an Investigate roll (Difficulty 2) or Lore roll (Difficulty 3) if the anchor is concealed within a larger collection.

Motivation: None – Remnants do not have goals. They are a resonant impression left by violent death near an artifact. They act on the echo of their last strong emotional state.

Shard Construct (Artifact Guardian)

[Supernatural / Artifact-Spawned / Threat: High]

Attributes: STR 8 | AGI 3 | WIT 2 | EMP 0

Armor Rating: 5 (crystallized occult energy – the artifact's self-defense)

Fear Rating: 4 (wrongness of form; the geometry of it shouldn't work)

Skills:

Force 5 | Brawl 4 | Endure 4

Special Abilities:

Occult Shell – Standard firearms deal only 1 Damage per hit against the Shard Construct regardless of weapon rating. Artifact-derived weapons, fire, or electromagnetic disruption deal full damage.

Shard Burst (Slow Action) – The Construct fires crystallized occult shards in a cone. All agents within Near range take 2 Strength damage. Armor applies. No attack roll – the GM describes the burst; agents may spend a Fast Action to Dodge (opposed AGI roll, Difficulty 2 to avoid) before it lands.

Anchored to Artifact – The Construct cannot move more than Long range from the artifact it protects. If the artifact is moved, the Construct follows (teleportation effect between scenes; not instant-travel within a scene).

Falling Construct – When the Shard Construct's Strength is reduced to 3 or lower, it enters a berserker state: it no longer uses Shard Burst (too degraded) but gains +2 dice on all Force and Brawl rolls. Its dissolution becomes imminent and it acts with total abandon.

Broken State: Dissolution. The Construct collapses into inert crystal fragments. The fragments are safe but fascinating to Lore scholars. The artifact it was protecting remains where it was. The Construct does not reconstitute – but similar constructs have been documented at the same artifact after 24-hour gaps.

Motivation: The artifact. Nothing enters its protection radius. Nothing leaves with the artifact.

19.4. NPC Tier Reference

For quick reference when building encounters:

Tier	Label	Description	Typical Strength
1	Grunt	No special abilities; acts in mobs; simplified stat block	2-3
2	Operative	One special ability; acts individually; mild tactics	3-5
3	Elite	Two or more special abilities; acts strategically; has a plan	5-7
4	Named Threat	Full stat block; unique abilities; plot significance	6-10

Named Threats are specific individuals (a faction leader, a bound entity with a centuries-long history) and should be developed individually rather than drawn from this reference list. The stat blocks above represent archetypes, not named antagonists.

19.5. Cross-References

- Fear ratings and check triggers: [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#)
- Faction affiliations and politics: [docs/chapters/17-rival-factions.adoc](#) (Issue #14)
- Artifacts and what spawns Constructs: [docs/chapters/11-artifacts.adoc](#) (Issue #9 origin)
- Corruption gain from supernatural sources: [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#)

19.6. Additional Supernatural Entities

The Mire (Psychic Contamination Zone)

Attribute	Value
Tier	Named Threat (Zone-Based)
Strength	– (cannot be targeted by physical attacks)
Agility	– (does not move; fills a space)
Wits	4
Empathy	5 (uses Empathy to manipulate; passively broadcasts)
Skills	Psychoanalyze 3 (passive pressure), Manipulate 2 (hallucination-induced)
Armor Rating	Immune to physical damage

Attribute	Value
Fear Rating	3
Corruption Cost	+1 Corruption per minute spent within it (scene = +3 total)

Origin: A Mire forms when intense psychological trauma fuses with corrupting artifact energy over years – a long-term infestation of a place by accumulated suffering. Hospitals, prisons, and sites of mass corruption exposure are most at risk.

Special Abilities:

Zone Control – The Mire occupies a defined zone (one to three interconnected rooms). All Wits and Empathy rolls made inside the zone are at -2 dice. Firearms and Force rolls are unaffected; the Mire does not respond to violence.

Memory Bleed – At the start of each scene inside the zone, each character witnesses an involuntary memory of the zone's traumatic origin (GM description). Characters must pass an Endure roll (Difficulty 1) or take 1 Wits damage.

Dissolution Trigger – The Mire cannot be destroyed by conventional means. It can be dispersed by:

- (1) Removing the corrupting artifact at its core (Investigate Difficulty 3 to locate it inside the zone, Lore Difficulty 2 to identify it as the anchor).
- (2) A Containment Ritual (see Wayfinder Division abilities) performed by an agent with Lore 3+, taking one full scene.
- (3) Destroying the artifact at its core (Artifact Fracture; triggers a Corruption Cascade – everyone in the zone takes +3 Corruption).

Broken State: Dispersed. The zone returns to normal. Physical damage from the trauma-origin remains (stains, broken furniture, cold spots). The artifact anchor must be contained; leaving it creates a new Mire within 1d6 days.

Motivation: The Mire has no motivation. It is an environmental hazard with rudimentary self-preservation logic. It does not pursue; it holds.

The Hollow

Attribute	Value
Tier	Operative (2)

Attribute	Value
Strength	5
Agility	2 (sluggish, deliberate)
Wits	1 (no autonomous thought)
Empathy	0
Skills	Force 3, Brawl 2, Endure 3
Armor Rating	1 (physical deadness reduces impact)
Fear Rating	2
Corruption Cost	+1 Corruption on first sighting; +1 if recognized as someone known

Origin: A Hollow is a human corpse reanimated by a corrupting artifact using residual psychic impressions of the deceased. The body retains muscle memory and some learned behaviors – but there is nothing behind the eyes.

Special Abilities:

Artifact Tether – A Hollow is bound to a specific artifact that controls it. While within Short range of that artifact, it gains +2 dice on all rolls. If the artifact is moved more than 50 meters away, the Hollow loses all special abilities and functions as a Grunt.

Recognition Response – If a player character knew the deceased in life and makes eye contact with the Hollow, they must pass a Psychoanalyze or Endure roll (Difficulty 2) or take 1 Empathy damage immediately.

Dead to Pain – The Hollow does not bleed (no ongoing Strength loss from wounds), cannot be staggered, and ignores fatigue. It will pursue until Broken or the artifact is removed.

Broken State: Collapse. The body goes completely inert. The artifact that controlled it is not damaged by the Hollow's collapse, but its occult signature is now readable (Lore Difficulty 1 to identify its history).

Motivation: The Hollow protects the artifact, returned the artifact to its last owner, or simply pursues the last living person it was "tasked" to reach. The GM determines the simple directive at the moment of the Hollow's creation.

The Listening

Attribute	Value
Tier	Elite (3)
Strength	3 (only manifests briefly)
Agility	5 (intangible movement)
Wits	6
Empathy	5
Skills	Investigate 4, Sneak 5, Manipulate 3
Armor Rating	Immune to physical damage while intangible
Fear Rating	2 (initially); 4 (once its nature is understood)
Corruption Cost	+2 Corruption when it speaks directly to a character

Origin: Formed from decades of surveillance anxiety – in a city wired by cold-war paranoia, government wiretapping, and Covenant counter-intelligence operations bleeding occult energy, The Listening coheres as an entity that **only knows how to observe and manipulate**. It does not attack physically; it attacks information.

Special Abilities:

Absolute Silence – The Listening's presence is announced by the sudden total cessation of ambient noise. Phones stop mid-ring. Tape recorders erase. Radio static vanishes. Characters with Investigate 2+ notice it immediately; others need a Wits roll (Difficulty 1).

They Know – Once per scene, The Listening can whisper a secret about one character to another character within Near range. The secret is true. The character who hears it must pass a Manipulate (resisted by Command or Endure, Difficulty 2) or immediately distrust the revealed character for the scene.

Wire Tap – If a character makes a Tech roll within The Listening's zone, The Listening gains access to all information contained in the device used. It may use this information in the same or future scenes (GM's discretion).

Intangible – The Listening cannot be harmed by physical attacks. It can only be targeted by a Containment Ritual or destroyed by removing all corrupted surveillance equipment from its zone of origin and performing a Tech roll (Difficulty 3) to disrupt its signal network.

Broken State: Static. A burst of white noise – every electronic device in Near range emits a single piercing tone and loses 1 Gear Bonus permanently. The Listening disperses. It may reconstitute in 1d6 days if its occult origin point is not addressed.

Motivation: To know everything. To use what it knows. It does not kill – but it will unravel a team from inside if left unchecked.

Fracture Wraith

Attribute	Value
Tier	Named Threat (4)
Strength	6
Agility	4
Wits	3 (fragmented; once higher)
Empathy	6 (weaponized grief)
Skills	Psychoanalyze 4, Manipulate 4, Brawl 3 (manifested physical form)
Armor Rating	3 (partially intangible)
Fear Rating	4 (maximum if the Wraith wears the face of a dead teammate)
Corruption Cost	+2 Corruption on first contact; +1 each subsequent scene

Origin: When a Covenant agent dies during a corruption spike – their Corruption threshold exceeded at the moment of death by artifact activation or entity contact – the psychic echo of that agent does not dissipate cleanly. It **fractures**. The resulting Wraith retains the face, voice, and mannerisms of the deceased, but its core motivation has been replaced entirely by the trauma of its creation.

Special Abilities:

Familiar Face – The Fracture Wraith appears as a dead Covenant agent. If any surviving character knew the deceased, seeing the Wraith triggers an immediate Fear Check (Fear Rating 4). If no character knew the deceased, it appears as a figure whose face they can't quite place – Fear Rating 2.

Guilt Echo – Once per scene, the Wraith can attempt a Psychoanalyze roll (opposed by the target's Wits). On success: the target relives a specific

guilt memory and gains +2 Corruption immediately. The experience is indistinguishable from a genuine flashback.

Corruption Drain – Any character who engages the Wraith in melee gains +1 Corruption per round of direct contact, regardless of outcome.

Memory of Skill – The Fracture Wraith retains one skill from the deceased at their final level. The GM chooses which skill based on the dead agent's profile (e.g., a dead Firearms 3 agent becomes a Wraith with Firearms 3).

Broken State: Release. The Wraith dissolves in a cascade of static images – faces, file documents, artifact photographs – before going silent. Characters who witness the dissolution gain +1 XP (the vision is painful but clarifying). The corruption spike that created the Wraith is fully discharged; the location is safe from this specific entity.

Motivation: The Fracture Wraith is not the dead agent. It is the **moment of death** given form. It seeks to replicate the conditions of its creation – drawing living agents toward high-corruption situations, artifact activation, and the threshold of corruption. It doesn't know it's doing this. It believes it's trying to warn them.

19.7. Corrupted NPCs

Corrupted NPCs are human characters – factional contacts, civilians, or even Covenant support staff – whose Corruption has crossed into active dysfunction. Unlike Fracture Wraiths or Hollows, they are still alive. They still want things. But **what** they want has been bent by prolonged corruption exposure.

Corruption Threshold and Behavior

The Corruption thresholds from [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#) apply to NPCs as well as agents. For simplicity, the GM tracks NPC corruption with a three-stage shorthand:

Stage	Corruption	Behavior
0	0–3	Normal. No mechanical difference from a baseline NPC.
1	4–7	Distorted. The NPC is erratic – inconsistent, prone to misreading motives. –1 die on all social skill rolls targeting them. They believe they are functioning normally.

Stage	Corruption	Behavior
2	8–10	Compromised. The NPC's primary goal has been replaced by the logic of a corrupting artifact. They act with genuine conviction in service of something the artifact wants. Fear Rating 1 (their behavior is uncanny and wrong).
3	11+	Broken. The NPC meets the Fracture Wraith threshold or reaches catatonia. If not Catatonic, treat as equivalent to a Hollow (see above) – still moving, but no longer present.

Running a Corrupted NPC

Corrupted NPCs are not villains in the traditional sense. They are **victims**. Consider the following when playing them:

- A Stage 1 NPC may give the players subtly wrong information – not because they are lying, but because they have stopped being able to distinguish memory from artifact-induced suggestion.
- A Stage 2 NPC may have physically altered their behavior to serve the artifact (hoarding it, protecting a building it lives in, feeding it corruption by exposing others to it).
- A Stage 2 NPC who is confronted about their behavior becomes **aggressively defensive** – they are convinced they are fine. A Psychoanalyze roll (Difficulty 3) reveals the fracture.
- A Stage 2 NPC who is successfully **separated from the artifact** for 48 hours begins to recover. A Psychoanalyze roll (Difficulty 2) can accelerate recovery. Recovery is not complete – they retain the trauma and may have acted against people they care about.

Identifying Corruption

Detecting a Corrupted NPC in play:

- **Wits (Investigate) Difficulty 2:** Notice that the NPC's behavior is inconsistent with their established pattern.
- **Wits (Lore) Difficulty 3:** Identify the specific artifact exerting influence based on the NPC's behavioral distortions.
- **Empathy (Psychoanalyze) Difficulty 2:** Confirm the NPC is compromised; learn how long it has been going on.

Design note: *Corrupted NPCs are the game’s most human horror. The artifacts don’t just corrupt agents – they reach out through anyone who gets close to them. The party’s best informant may already be Stage 1. The Covenant archivist they trusted for six Case Files may have been Stage 2 for months.*

19.8. GM Monster Creation Guidelines

Use these guidelines when building new entities for a scenario.

Step 1 – Establish Tier

Choose the entity’s Tier from the NPC Tier Reference table. Named Threats require a narrative hook (a history, a motivation, a way they can be permanently stopped) and should appear no more than once or twice per campaign.

Step 2 – Assign Attributes

Use the following baselines as starting points:

Tier	STR	AGI	WIT	EMP
Grunt	2–3	2–3	1–2	1–2
Operative	3–5	3–4	2–3	2–3
Elite	5–7	3–5	3–4	3–5
Named Threat	6–10	4–6	4–6	4–7

Supernatural entities may exceed these ranges in one or two Attributes to reflect their inhuman nature – but balance this against their vulnerabilities.

Step 3 – Choose a Primary Skill (and Two Secondary Skills)

The primary skill is what the entity **does in combat or interaction**. The secondary skills represent what it falls back on. Named Threats get three secondary skills.

Step 4 – Define Special Abilities

Limit special abilities by tier:

- Grunt: 0–1 special abilities
- Operative: 1 special ability
- Elite: 2–3 special abilities
- Named Threat: 3–5 special abilities

Good special ability design rules:

1. Each ability should create a **distinct tactical decision** for the players.
2. At least one ability should have a **meaningful counter** that can be discovered with a successful Lore or Investigate roll.
3. Avoid purely defensive abilities – entities that can only be hurt in specific ways are frustrating if players can't find the method.

Step 5 – Set Fear Rating

Rating	When to Use
1	Unsettling – wrong but not immediately dangerous (a Hollow in daylight)
2	Disturbing – genuinely threatening, supernatural in an obvious way
3	Horrifying – the sight alone causes psychological harm
4	Shattering – maximum; reserved for entities of existential scale

Step 6 – Write the Broken State

Every entity needs an end condition. Answer: **What does it look like when this thing stops?** What does it leave behind? Is it permanent?

Step 7 – Write the Motivation

Even mindless entities have a directive. Define it in one sentence. If you can't, the entity isn't ready yet.



CLASSIFIED

PART VI – GLOSSARY

Classification: Unrestricted (Covenant Personnel Only)

Distribution: All Personnel

CHAPTER 20. GLOSSARY OF GAME TERMS

Quick reference for all game-specific terms used in the Neon Relic core rules. Entries are alphabetical. Cross-references point to the chapter where the full rules appear.

20.1. A

Age Group

Character creation choice determining starting Attribute and Skill point pools. Three tiers: Young (14 attribute / 10 skill), Experienced (13 / 12), Senior (12 / 14). See [docs/chapters/02-character-creation.adoc](#).

Anchor

A physical object linked to a humanizing memory. Once per session, a character may interact with their Anchor to heal 1d4 Corruption. See [Anchors](#).

Armor Rating

The number of Gear dice rolled to absorb incoming damage. Each 6 rolled cancels one point of damage. See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

Attribute Dice

White dice in the pool, equal to the relevant Attribute score (Strength, Agility, Wits, or Empathy). See [docs/chapters/03-core-resolution.adoc](#).

20.2. B

Background

Recovery Division's equivalent of Departments. Defines the agent's pre-Covenant expertise and grants narrative hooks. See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

Broken

State when any Attribute reaches 0. The character is incapacitated and rolls on the appropriate Critical Injury table (Physical or Mental). See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

20.3. C

Case File

A structured mystery/investigation for the team to complete. The standard episodic play format, divided into phases: Briefing, Travel, Investigation, Confrontation, and Resolution. See [docs/chapters/15-case-file.adoc](#).

Clearance Level (CL)

Seniority and authorization rank within the Covenant. Equals Division base CL plus Age Group modifier (Young -1, Experienced +0, Senior +1), minimum 1. Determines gear access and organizational authority. See [docs/chapters/02-character-creation.adoc](#).

Corruption

Cumulative psychological and occult damage track. Gained from pushing rolls, Division Talent activation, Fear, artifact use, and supernatural exposure. **Maximum Corruption Threshold** = 10 + Empathy score; exceeding it causes permanent catatonia and character retirement. See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#).

Critical Injury

A specific wound or trauma rolled on a D66 table when a character becomes Broken. Physical criticals use the Physical table (STR/AGI = 0); mental criticals use the Mental & Emotional table (WIT/EMP = 0). Some entries are marked † (Death Check). See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

20.4. D

D66

A roll of two six-sided dice read as a two-digit number (first die = tens, second = units). Used for Critical Injury tables. Range: 11–66.

Damage Type

One of three categories: **Physical** (targets STR or AGI), **Mental** (targets WIT or EMP), or **Corruption** (added directly to the Corruption track). See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

Dark Secret

A specific hidden fact from the character's past – an event, decision, or relationship someone wants buried. Serves as a roleplay device and XP hook ("Did your Dark Secret complicate the mission?" = +1 XP). See [docs/chapters/13-advancement.adoc](#).

Death Check

A single d6 roll required when a Critical Injury is marked †. On 1–2: the character dies (or is permanently retired for mental death). On 3–6: survival, but the Critical Injury still applies. See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

Department

Specialization within a Division (Wayfinder, Keep, Stack). Determines the character's field expertise and Department Skill. Recovery uses Backgrounds instead. See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

Difficulty

The number of successes (6s) required to pass a skill roll. Standard range: 1 (routine) to 5+ (extreme). See [docs/chapters/03-core-resolution.adoc](#).

Division

Character class within the Verdant Covenant. Four playable Divisions: Wayfinder (research/intelligence), Recovery (field retrieval), The Keep (vault security), and Stack (logistics). See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

Division Item

A signature supernatural object issued to every member of a Division. Wayfinder: Verdant Codex. Recovery: Verdant Satchel. Keep: Warden's Bracer. See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

Division Talent

A class-specific ability unique to one Division. Costs +1 Corruption to activate (most talents). See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

Dying

State when a Broken character has an active Death Check Critical Injury (result marked †) that has not yet been resolved. An untreated Dying character will die. See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

20.5. F**Fast Action**

One of three action types in combat. Represents a quick or secondary effort: moving one zone, drawing a weapon, taking cover, or using a small item. See [docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc](#).

Fear Check

A Wits roll triggered by supernatural horror. Each 6 = success. Each 1 = +1 Corruption. No successes = failure (+1 Corruption + Panic Table roll). See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#).

Fear Rating

Narrative classification (0–5) of how terrifying a creature or event is. Used by the GM to determine when to call for a Fear check. 0 = no check triggered. See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#).

Free Action

An action in combat that requires negligible effort: speaking a short sentence, dropping an item, or glancing at surroundings. Unlimited per turn. See [docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc](#).

20.6. G

Gear Dice

Black dice in the pool contributed by equipment. Each 1 rolled on a Gear die causes the item to degrade one step. See [docs/chapters/03-core-resolution.adoc](#).

General Talent

A talent available to any character regardless of Division, providing a mechanical exception or situational bonus. See [docs/chapters/13-advancement.adoc](#).

20.7. H

Headquarters (HQ)

The Covenant facility serving as the team's base of operations between Case Files. Provides medical care, equipment requisition, research facilities, and downtime activities. See [docs/chapters/12-headquarters.adoc](#).

20.8. I

Insight

A permanent mechanical bonus gained from certain Critical Injuries, marked (**Insight**) in the injury name or effect. Represents a silver lining from trauma – heightened perception, empathy, or expertise. Cannot be removed. See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

20.9. M

Maximum Corruption Threshold

The point at which a character's mind permanently fractures: 10 + Empathy score. Exceeding this value retires the character. See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#).

20.10. N

Named Threat

A significant antagonist in a Case File – a faction operative, corrupted NPC, or supernatural entity important enough to have a name, motivations, and stat block. See [docs/chapters/15-case-file.adoc](#).

20.11. P

Panic Table

A d6 table rolled on Fear check failure. Determines the character's involuntary response: Fight (1), Flight (2), Freeze (3), Denial (4), Compulsion (5), or Fugue (6). See [docs/chapters/08-corruption-fear-healing.adoc](#).

Push

Re-roll all non-6 dice after a failed roll. Costs +1 Corruption. Each roll may only be pushed once. Gear dice that show 1 on the push cause degradation. See [docs/chapters/03-core-resolution.adoc](#).

Psychoanalyze

A skill used to treat mental and emotional Critical Injuries. Recovery difficulty and duration vary by injury severity. See [docs/chapters/07-health-damage-armor.adoc](#).

20.12. R

20.13. S

Skill Dice

Green dice in the pool, equal to the relevant Skill rating (0–5). See [docs/chapters/03-core-resolution.adoc](#).

Slow Action

One of three action types in combat. Represents a committed effort: attacking, using a skill, administering first aid, or reloading a weapon. See [docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc](#).

Stunt Points

Extra successes (6s) beyond the first on an attack roll, spent on special combat effects such as increased damage, disarming, or knockback. See [docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc](#).

20.14. T

The Verdant Covenant

The ancient secret society the player characters serve. Discovers, recovers, and contains supernatural artifacts to protect humanity. Organized into three operational Divisions (Wayfinder, Recovery, The Keep) plus Stack (Logistics). See [The Verdant Covenant](#).

20.15. V

Verdant Codex

Wayfinder Division Item. An enchanted field journal that secures memory, decodes language, maps artifact locations, and preserves documents. See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

Verdant Satchel

Recovery Division Item. A specially enchanted field bag that suppresses artifact aura, seals cursed items, warns of instability, and produces basic tools on demand. See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

20.16. W

Warden's Bracer

Keep Division Item. Suppresses artifact magic, warns of containment failure, enables safe handling of cursed objects, absorbs 1 Corruption per session, and grants +1 Armor Rating. See [docs/chapters/09-divisions.adoc](#).

20.17. Z

Zone

An abstract area of space used for combat positioning – a room, corridor, alley, or rooftop section. Moving one zone costs a Fast Action; moving two zones (running) costs both the Fast and Slow Action for the round. See [docs/chapters/05-combat.adoc](#).